Wisdom of the Aged



Craig Hattersley

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Acknowledgments

I would be remiss if I didn't acknowledge some of the people who steered me down this path, two of them English profs at the University of Texas when I returned in the late Seventies to finish my degree. Though I picked up a BS in journalism at UT, I determined at the time I would take every writing class available to polish up my blarney. In that pursuit, I first encountered Katherine Staples in a freshman English class, who allowed me to chart an independent course—chronicling my years at the Fillmore East—as opposed to the requisite "How I Spent My Summer" essays of the class.

She also steered me into the Advanced Expository Writing class (325M), an authorial boot camp presided over by the dean then of polished prose, John Trimble, in whose custody my bombastic bullshit took on a slightly more *genteel* finish. A good deal of exposition herein first saw the light of day in John's classes, though perhaps now without the artistry as shown under his expert eye (and ever more heathen in aspect given the intervening years).

In the UT journalism school, I wrote several pieces for an exceptional professor of feature writing, Rebecca Schorin, who also allowed some leeway to an older, if still headstrong, pupil in doing my own thing. The beginnings of the portion of this book on the Armadillo World Headquarters took root in her class, resulting in an article published in the *Texas Observer*

on the occasion of the 'Dillo closing and later articles in the *Austin Chronicle*.

Thus, some of what ended up in this work first appeared some forty years ago during the tutelage of these teachers. This proved fortunate, as events transpiring upwards of fifty years ago might otherwise have been lost in a somewhat benign haze, the fog of a flagging memory. I have attempted to remain faithful to the truth as I remember, through good and bad, while assigning fictionalized names to some of my cohorts to absolve them of any blame for my wayward ways. I own the mishaps and missteps of my life and only allow that a few colorful characters may have shared some of these adventures.

Introduction

As life is action and passion, it is required of a man that he should share the passion and action of his time at peril of being judged not to have lived.

—Oliver Wendell Holmes

It was the best of times. The Seventies in Austin, Texas, a fortuitous confluence of happy happenstance that led the local comedy troupe to dub the city the "retirement capital of the world—for young people." In 1969 and again five years later, a Department of Labor study declared Austin the cheapest city of its size in the nation. You could rent a small house for $50 a month and eat on a dollar a day as the decade opened. As a result, from 1970 to 1973, the city's population growth of 4.5 percent a year ranked second in the nation. For a young hippie looking to escape the fog of New York City (quite literally, as a report said just living in Manhattan was the equivalent of smoking two packs of cigarettes a day) and start afresh in a more laid-back environment, Austin proved a mercy—as it did for many others—a hippie Valhalla.

The quiet Texas city of fewer than a quarter million inhabitants appeared to be the idyllic spot for the search for escape from the end of times—the bloody riot of the Sixties, what seemed the total unraveling of a staid post-war social fabric. The University of Texas and environs provided a defensible

perimeter, surrounded as it was by a resolutely redneck Southern populace. True, you could get an unsolicited haircut or a thorough drubbing if you ventured outside of the safe zone, and you never stopped on Guadalupe Street at Weedon's Sunoco: A sign there declared "hippies and blacks not served." In Texas, as elsewhere, the nascent free-form lifestyle and earnest pronouncements of the hippie met the weight of a festering conservative resentment to this alien life form, with its earnest quest in Eastern philosophy for Truth and the "Wisdom of the Ages."

This quixotic search didn't sit well with the established order, whose view of the era was tainted by the media perception of a feckless, wanton generation undone by a profligate preoccupation with "sex, drugs, and rock'n'roll." And in truth, many partook of the Sixties only for the sex and drugs, readily accessible as they were. There are obsessives for every vice—sex, booze, drugs, dogma. (It's like the drunk who says, "I know my limit. I just keep passing out before I get to it.") They're the ones who get the press.

For others, the ferment of the times gave them freedom to proclaim, as André Gide said, "I am here to live outloud!" To which the status quo responded: "Shut the fuck up." But still others—perhaps some of the best and brightest of the generation—simply dropped out to follow their muse, making candles, playing music, teaching yoga, anything but suiting up and getting in line. You're never smarter than when you're twenty-one. And you never again enjoy the freedom of youth that allows you to flippantly give the finger to society.

In light of advancing years, I look back fondly at the idealism and youthful zeal that fueled such irreverence. Working at the Fillmore East in the late Sixties, we held the world at our

fingertips, life's answers in the lyrics of a generation's rowdy anthems: Mick Jagger, witness to a giant antiwar protest in London, entoning, "What can a poor boy do / Except to sing for a rock'n'roll band." We were down with that. High-school buds Carlito, Ricky V., and I put heart and soul into grabbing a piece of that action ourselves—until reality impinged upon that dream.

The music scene in New York City would decay and the Fillmore close, and we headed for greener pastures: Austin, Texas, the new frontier. The sleepy college burg offered a more congenial atmosphere amongst like-minded individuals with their kindred laid-back mien, a place for personal examination and a new beginning. And it promised, with its stirrings of an embryonic music scene, the hope of maintaining a countercultural momentum—particularly with the opening of the Armadillo World Headquarters.

The Dillo would be part of a long meandering path to wherever. But it too promised a different reality of some kind, any kind. That remained to be seen. As Beatle George Harrison sang, "If you don't know where you're going / Any road will take you there."

A new way of life, of doing things, seemed all the more an imperative given what seemed at the time the "real" world's descent into madness in the Sixties. Foremost, of course, would be the assassinations of the Kennedys and Martin Luther King, while the country dug deeper into a bloody, protracted war in Vietnam. Madcaps Richard Nixon and Spiro Agnew followed, then Watergate, Kent State, the My Lai massacre. The powers that be weren't exactly covering themselves in glory.

On into the Seventies, a surreal kaleidoscope of events reeled off in numbing succession: first-daughter Tricia Nixon

deciding on a rose-garden wedding with her Harvard beau; Alexander Haig saying the missing eighteen minutes on the Nixon tape was due to a "sinister force"; twenty prisoners and ten hostages dying in the Attica Prison riot, all from police fire; Martin Luther King's mother shot to death while playing the organ in an Atlanta church; Nixon resigning, then Ford pardoning him a month later; Wilbur Mills, chairman of the powerful House Ways & Means Committee, caught cavorting in the Tidal Basin with stripper Fanne Fox; Agriculture Secretary Earl Butz saying that "blacks were interested only in good sex, loose shoes, and a warm place to defecate"; Three Mile Island nuclear plant nearly melting down.

Against a backdrop of Sixties-era depredations on the national front, those in Texas seemed pretty mild—and Austin a pretty safe place to hide away, though the local city council and constabulary didn't think much of the counterculture. In Austin, as elsewhere, the number-one traffic violation for hippies was driving without a haircut. At the time, according to one cop, 80 percent of the Austin police force was ex-Marine, and they didn't much cotton to all the longhairs and their protesting: When Abbie Hoffman (whose attraction to the era's riotous limelight led to his founding of the Yippies, for one) spoke at UT, 11,000 crammed into Gregory Gym. A 1970 antiwar protest drew 20,000, and tear gas wafted down city streets in the one year that Austin lived dangerously.

This behavior didn't sit well with city elders. After a 1969 protest, Wray Weddell wrote in the city's conservative newspaper, "On KOKE, country music deejay Arleigh Duff, calling the marchers 'Hanoi's Little Helpers,' mixed patriotic music with the country Top 40." The *Austin Citizen,* after an incident at

the Chuck Wagon closed the campus hippie hangout to non-students, quoted assistant district attorney Herman Gotcher as saying that longhair radicals "use that place to fornicate their desires." Dallas took notice of the hubbub and passed a law forbidding "lagging" or "sauntering." After a 1971 protest at the LBJ Library in Austin, a Mrs. Logan Gray was quoted as saying, "We could sleep a lot better at night if we could kill them all [the protesters]." Her husband, who sported grease-paint on his knuckles, had to be separated from a protester done up in whiteface so the demonstrator could be arrested.

The university area, at least, provided strength in numbers, much to the consternation of UT officials, who did everything they could to muffle the madness. In 1969, they barred a play, *Now the Revolution*, from campus because of nudity. It went on with no nudity, but was shut down again because of "fire laws." The next month, two employees of the UT Academic Center were fired for sporting long sideburns. That summer, the university made it illegal to enter the East Mall Fountain—to "maintain safety standards"—and banned the alternative publication, *The Rag,* from campus. But the cancer was spreading. In 1966, a third of UT coeds signed up for sorority rush; by '69 it had dropped to 17 percent. In early 1971, UT students, in a futile-yet-defiant gesture, voted 6,226 to 966 to dump UT regents chair Frank Erwin Jr., whose dictatorial rule inflamed passions.

Fortunately, at the time, city leaders had other fish to fry. In 1970 Austin began desegregation of its schools, at the same time school board president Roy Butler's opposition to forced busing was said to be "unyielding." That obviously took some working out. (If things got a little tense, there was always the

Sixth Street porno theater, which was showing *Hippie Orgy* and *Psychedelic Sex*.)

And *bidness,* of course, was still bidness. R. L. Hancock, an Austin utility official, announced in 1972 that the city should buy into the $289 million South Texas Nuclear Project, which, he said, would crank out electric in 1980 (said in the day's parlance to be "too cheap to meter"). By then, however, the cost topped $2.8 billion, and construction ultimately dragged on until 1989—with a final cost of $5.5 billion.

Statewide, Texas government of the time masqueraded as Democratic, but with a decidedly conservative bent—nearly as hidebound as New York's. In one infamous incident, black activist Lee Otis Johnson drew a thirty-year prison sentence in 1968 for passing a "marijuana cigarette" to an undercover police officer in Houston. Those who thought the punishment didn't fit the crime distilled their outrage into a chant—"Free Lee Otis!"—heard on campuses around the state. In 1970, protesters disrupted a speech by the governor, Preston Smith, at the University of Houston with it. Smith, one in a series of potted plants occupying the governor's office, asked a reporter, "What in the world do they have against beans?" When the reporter explained what the crowd shouted, Smith said, "I thought they were saying *frijoles.*"

Against this backdrop, expatriate hippies burrowed in to the Texas Hill Country city and slowly acclimated to the harsh environment—some quite literally, as few jobs at the time allowed for long hair and many a hippie ended up working in construction to get by (a tough go during the long brutal summer). This led to a breed of longhair with hard bark on them. But it also produced over time a grudging acceptance in

blue-collar circles, as well as a sort of solidarity within a hip community otherwise beset by animosity all around. We were all in the same cobbled-together boat.

And the camaraderie held the community together and eventually allowed it to flourish, even as other scenes began to fracture. In succeeding decades, the Texas capital has certainly changed (gotten too big for its britches in some ways), but there remains the old imperative to "Keep Austin Weird," a bumpersticker that still sells well today. Through pandemic and the steady drumbeat of an illiberal orthodoxy nationwide, the music scene remains, vestige of a bygone era—and hope for a better day.

Still, conservative revisionism works to beat down any attempt to celebrate the hip attempt at counterculture so as to relegate it to a footnote in history. In 2017 right-wing blow-by and wannabe king-maker Steve Bannon maintained that hippies were to blame for the 2008 economic collapse. Excuse me? Someone please tell this douchebag that that ship sailed decades ago. History might not be such a harsh judge of our deeds and actions, particularly given the plight today of the middle class.

It's been a slow turn of the screw through the decades, masking the grinding reassertion of control of monied interests in asserting predominance in politics and society, a gradual turning back of the clock to pre-FDR days. Where once a single bread-winner could support a family, buy a house, save for college, and look forward to a secure retirement, decades later a household with two full-time salaries makes less money in real dollars than the idyllic homestead of the past. And the specter of bankruptcy and homelessness haunts a majority

for whom financial security is jeopardized by mischance or a single medical catastrophe.

In retrospect, what we struggled with then, during the big hippie schism, served only as a prelude to what we now face in a society hardened—by design. But the inexorable grind of time, necessity, and economics hasn't yet jaded me; the feeling still remains. In the words of Robert Frost, "They would not find me changed from him they knew / Only more sure of all I thought was true."

~1~

Homegrown Religion

A typical American family of five, we enjoyed an "Ozzie and Harriet" sort of existence in Fifties America. Older Bro and I proudly wore our coonskin caps when Fess Parker lit up the screen as Davy Crockett, younger Sis had her Barbie dolls and stuffed animals. When finally Dad sprung for one of the new-fangled black-and-white TVs, we tuned into the *Mickey Mouse Club* and sprawled on the floor enthralled by the heroics of celluloid heroes John Wayne and Audie Murphy as they battled their way through enemy hordes in the Big One, World War II. We lived and breathed American exceptionalism, drilled in each morning in school beginning with the pledge of allegiance to the flag (appended in 1954 when I turned five with the phrase "under God"). And nobody wanted to be seen as different. We were all good little citizens. I remember in 1956 during an informal poll in class not raising my hand to support my family's fave for prez, Adlai Stevenson, when all else but one supported Ike.

When not in school, we freely roamed the neighborhoods without worry, returning only in the evening at bellows from the parents signaling dinner. Life was good in the bedroom community outside Rochester, New York, blissfully unaware as we were of the titanic struggle with "godless communism." Our only inkling came in elementary school, where we learned to duck and cover—hide under the desk and cover the back of the neck in the event of nuclear attack. It all made some sort of sense, and we did as instructed. We lined up outside the nurse's office to suck on our own personal sugar cube, which contained, we learned, the incredible new Salk vaccine to ward off polio. Good citizens all, we learned of the outside world from one of three television networks.

Our world view was decidedly Middle American: Dad and Mom came from Montana, moving east so Dad could finish studies in photography at the Rochester Institute of Technology (R.I.T.), ultimately transitioning to teaching there. Son of a Montana circuit-court judge, Dad had served in the Navy during WWII, stationed as a photographer's mate in the Caribbean after his brother Frank went missing in the Pacific theater. (He later turned up.) He tried his hand at painting, complete with a show in Chicago of his works, then gravitated toward photography, where he would gain some repute through the years.

As Dad worked teaching six days a week, organized religion played only a small role in our lives, aside from an egalitarian sensibility that illumined our upbringing. Given the option of going to church on Sunday or relaxing with Dad, we stayed home, gorging on the pancakes he'd make for breakfast. Easter morning and other holidays, we duded up and attended mass, but became more estranged as time went on,

with the foreign-sounding words aped in unison by the devout churchgoers and their prim religiosity in Sunday school lording it over our poor untutored souls. Better to be gone than to be different.

Which is not to say we weren't raised to believe in what's right. Dad and Mom, staunch FDR democrats, laid down the law about racist taunts, for instance—or any kind of mockery making light of the less fortunate. We couldn't recite the catechism, but we knew the substance.

Only in later years did I come to find out just how progressive Dad's views really were. When R.I.T. debated over whether to employ a gay man as a photography professor, he lobbied in his behalf, leading to the hiring of Minor White at the school. Our suburban home also served as party central for a generation of young photography students, gathered for the occasional "beatnik party" (to which we, as "just kids," weren't invited). Black-and-white photos of some of these bashes still adorn Dad's section of the archives at R.I.T.

Amid the unremitting normality of life in Upstate New York, we did our best to fit in, with half-hearted stabs at little-league baseball, the occasional fishing trip, a couple of interminable cross-country trips on Greyhound to visit the grandfolks in Montana. We attended elementary school in a progressive district in Brighton, a suburb of Rochester, where I began conversational French in third grade and exchanged letters with a penpal in France. Show-and-tell, an integral part of the third-grade socialization process, generally saw me presenting on some neat rocks I had found, or my latest exploits in Cub Scouts. We were the bears.

Yeah, you look like a bear, Hattersley. Guffaw.

Until that one day.

Passing on the latest from Mom, as is the wont of unfiltered kids, I proudly announced that we were considering moving to Israel and living in a kibbutz.

Hunh?

What in hell was that about?

Unbeknownst to us kids, kept from the horrors of real life, a marriage had disintegrated around us. The why and wherefore never became clear to me, though sketchy details would lay bare the blame on one side or the other over time. An affair, maybe two, anger, recriminations—all well hidden from us—leading to a "mental breakdown," as Mom would assert. And Dad, diagnosed as a manic depressive, fell prey to the tender mercies of the medieval psychiatric practices of the day: electro-shock therapy and massive doses of Lithium.

Not yet privy to the ugliness of the dissolution, we only slowly grew aware of the ramifications of the big D, Divorce (virtually unheard-of in those times), as our happy little universe warped into something entirely different. Dad no longer lived with us in our quiet little suburban neighborhood. Mom, with the first of a string of fanciful notions, a pioneer woman striking out against all odds, determined that maybe we should do the kibbutz thing. She had, after all, fought skunk families and rattlesnakes teaching all grades in a one-room schoolhouse in rural Montana before marriage. And somewhere in the dim reaches of her family tree, there had been some Jewish blood.

Of course, the practicalities of the situation never led to any real attempt to move to Israel. For one of hard-headed Irish-German stock, Mom still never let facts intrude on her extravagant fantasies. She then determined she would strike out on her own, realities be damned, and took a job working

at a chain of small-town weekly newspapers, asserting nobly that she asked only for the minimum alimony support in the divorce. She would become the intrepid newswoman—hard-drinkin', hard-livin' woman of the world.

The first of a long string of boyfriends, met during production of a summer-stock play Mom became involved in, parked his '57 convertible Plymouth in the driveway, showing all the neighborhood what this divorced woman was about in a time when this was *just not done.* Of course, that changed our standing in the 'hood drastically. The longtime friend next door that Sis grew up with could no longer play with her. The good-catholic sentiment of her family dictated that we were now *personae non gratae* on the block, which infuriated momma bear. Mom angrily avowed that she'd done her duty, religion be damned. She had gone through seven pregnancies, but because of her RH-negative blood type, only the three survived.

She upped and sold the house we'd grown up in, after threatening to list it with the NAACP to "serve them all right," moving us thirty miles down the road to small-town Canandaigua for her newspaper job. Thus began a cycle of moves between rent homes and apartments, back and forth to Rochester, in increasingly run-down areas.

Dad moved into a rental near the R.I.T. campus, where the kids would take turns staying on weekends. There I first experienced hanging out with the black kids in the neighborhood, learning how to spit righteously and fashion shivs from wooden dowels and car parts. Still running free, with little or no adult supervision needed.

That arrangement served for a short time, until Mom cracked up her car one icy winter evening. We didn't know

how serious it was then, but Dad had to come shepherd us through the next couple months until Mom could again fend for herself, complete with horrible scars, a plate in her head, and a metal rod holding her arm together.

Sooner than later, small-town Canandaigua wore on us. My only friend had been Johnny, who lived next door, son of some older bible-thumping holy rollers. Though older even than Bro, he too had few friends and took me under his wing, and I accompanied him to high school wrestling each day, serving as his practice opponent, and became something of a team mascot, traveling with them to matches. I made few friends my own age.

My sole sortie into pre-teen society had ended on a sour note, one of those painful memories that subsume any fond recollects. I wanted badly to be a part of things, and so took lessons in the foxtrot and box waltz at Miss Botsford's School of Dance, culminating in the grand formal dance. I showed up dressed in the one white shirt I owned, neatly pressed, and found, to my mortification, that all the other boys sported suits and ties. When queried about my sport coat, I allowed as how I'd hung it up when I came in, and bluffed and blustered my way through the evening, exploding in tears in the car as Dad drove me home. I'd had enough small town.

As it was, however, Mom soon recovered enough to begin working again, this time at the paper's home office in Rochester. So in my second year of junior high (always the Dark Ages for blossoming teenagers), we moved back—into Strathmore Circle, a small project in a tough Italian neighborhood of inner-city Rochester. The denizens there sported greased-back hair, black-leather "fence-climber" boots with pointed toes, and tight, short high-water jeans approximating the James

Dean look of the times. I learned to fight to find a slot in the pecking order, despite efforts to remain relatively invisible in the rowdy school halls.

This proved difficult at times, given our deteriorating economic situation. Each new school year involved a cheap upgrade to our limited wardrobes, which meant that going into junior high in Rochester I had just two pairs of pants, one a light-tan corduroy pair that barely fit as my weight steadily climbed. To my horror, these had been washed with a red sweater in the project wash area, and they turned a decidedly pink color. But with no other choice, I had to wear them, and suffer the consequences. A chubby kid in pink pants drew a fair share of macho derision—and worse.

Our transient status contributed to a growing isolation, as we hadn't much time between moves to develop any lasting friendships. This didn't really faze me, as I was ever the introvert anyway. I managed to pull in decent grades despite the problems created by dislocations, in part because Mom never remembered to transfer our records to each successive new school district and I invariably wound up in the "middle track," where they stuck kids of indeterminate intelligence. This did allow me, at our inner-city stop, to gain favor and some small measure of protection by providing answers to test questions to the football stud in my English class. But it didn't totally remove me from the scrabble to find some sort of identity in the volatile projects.

One incident led to my first encounter with the authorities. While waiting for the school bus one morning, I squared off against Bruce, for whatever reason *du jour.* He popped me one then, before I could return the favor, took off running. When all efforts to corral him failed, I ultimately climbed onto

the bus when it arrived and settled, seething, in the back. Bruce stood in front, occasionally turning to smirk at me, adding no end to my festering mood. I bided my time. Then, nearing the last stop, when he had given off keeping an eye on me, I strode to the front of the bus and, in my best John Wayne style, wheeled him around and landed a haymaker on his nose, declaring, "You can't run now, Bruce."

Blood flew, girls screamed, and we grappled in the aisles, flailing away until the bus driver jerked the bus to a stop and yanked us apart. Hence my first visit to the principal's office, where momma bear declared that it was Bruce's fault, hitting me then running. The principal couldn't disagree but suspended me nevertheless. Oh well. Some time off to watch soaps (all that daytime TV offered) and ponder what cachet my schoolbus bravado might attach to my rep.

It *did* provide some measure of relief from the constant clash of testosterone-induced swagger, the bloody encounter testifying to the fact that I *would* throw punches. Most fights of the time involved frantic wrestling around until one chokehold proved devastating and the bout ended with a quick "I give." This upped the ante a bit, giving me some brawler cred—no small matter.

Mom had little clue about any of this. She continued her charge into a newspaper career from the new location, hanging and drinking with her peers and various politicos, achieving some measure of notoriety of her own. This left little time for much in the way of parenting. As Sis later noted, we raised ourselves. Dinner often meant a bag of cold burgers brought home by our tipsy mother long after dark, or a quick trip to the Golden Point in Rochester, a precursor to McDonald's, where we'd each get a dollar to stuff our bellies. We soon learned the

merits of Hamburger Helper, which served to fill kids quickly on a late evening. Seafood was limited to fishsticks or Howard Johnson's fried clams. Breakfast often was a half-dozen donuts to split, secured the night before—and often eaten then.

As the middle child, I tended to roll with it, swallowing my turbulent teenage emotions. That's the way Mom was, so I dealt with it, even as disappointments piled up. Her limited view as a part-time parent saw me as the kid who did well in school, for which I enjoyed some sort of favored status as a result. And besides, at a young age I decided I would be president some day, and prudently plotted out my ascension: To be president, you have to be a politician; to be a politician you have to be a lawyer. A mother's pride—the son who wants to be a lawyer.

I proudly assumed the title of anointed one, Momma's little capitalist. I was a mercenary little bastard. I wanted nothing more than to be rich and famous. From grade school on, I always hatched some sort of scheme to make money to augment any pittance of allowance. Early on, I found a rapt consumer class in third grade for a product I marketed devised with straight pins: I loaded on three designer colored beads and a piece of boondoggle and made tiny swords, which I pinned to a display cloth and sold at three for a nickel. Big seller. I always sported a pocket bulging with small change.

As soon as I came of age, I started throwing a paper route, carrying on through various stops in Rochester and Canandaigua—a tough way to make a dime during the frigid pre-dawn mornings of Upstate New York, though kids in the clime were pretty inured to the worst that winter could offer. We frolicked in the drifts of arctic blasts and delighted in the days when weather precluded attendance in school, choosing then to

build snow forts and toboggan down local hills till impending frostbite drove us indoors.

An otherwise-erratic home life, however, caused increasing conflict, given Mom's desultory attempts at parenting, her drinking, and a marked bad taste in men. A series of forgettable liaisons with boyfriends of questionable repute, some of whom ultimately wound up dead (including one minor-league Mafioso type) aggravated the tension. Bro, who as eldest probably had the best sense of what was going on, fought heatedly with her, and Sis, ever the daddy's girl, couldn't countenance putting up with a one of these deadbeats. I sublimated as always, marinating in teen angst, and held it in.

I only began to realize how far things had gone one morning in the projects as I was getting ready to catch the schoolbus. I ducked back into the room I shared with Bro to grab something and saw him, hunkered down between our beds hiding. He shushed me, telling me not to say anything. He was skipping that day. I didn't rat him out, of course, though I muddled through the day wondering what the hell was happening to us.

Two seemingly incongruous events of that school year—1963–64—served ultimately to open cracks in the façade of an American dreamscape. In November 1963 John Kennedy was assassinated in Dallas, quickly adjudged the work of a lone gunman, Lee Harvey Oswald, but left simmering in doubt in subsequent years. (The Church Committee in 1978 would allow that it was "probably" the work of a conspiracy.) Thus began the slow seepage of revelations over succeeding years about the dark workings of our hidden government in the U.S., with its penchant for, among sundry other black ops,

assassinating foreign leaders who might threaten American corporate interests—all in God's name.

Of course, none of this had yet disturbed the common ethos of American exceptionalism. Yet I remember hearing the announcement over the school loudspeaker about Kennedy and falling into an anxious funk, aggravated on the bus ride home from school by junior-high girls chittering away as usual, oblivious to the news.

A second event, in February 1964, at the time a seemingly frivolous paean to a gaggle of girls, was the appearance of the Beatles on the *Ed Sullivan Show* in front of 73 million Americans—three-quarters of the total adult audience in the United States at the time. Adult America rolled its eyes at the sight of teenage girls in the audience screaming and crying over the band. Years later, a young friend remarked that her father believed fervently that the Beatles were the sole cause of Sixties turmoil. Maybe true, but perception oftentimes stands in for truth. In any event, the show drew the nation's attention to the mop-top band.

The next day in class, I jokingly combed my Vitalis-sodden locks down onto my forehead, just fleetingly, though at least one girl remarked how good it looked like that. (A morning ritual at the time involved flooding the hair with the noxious stuff, combing it back into the *de rigueur* ducktail, which then hardened into an immutable coif sculpted with the ladies in mind.) I wasn't going to go there, though, and quickly slicked it back into place. It would be years before the dry look took over. None of us was enough of a trendsetter to readily adopt the mop haircuts (not of a very manly nature, and mocked by mature America), though ultimately we did go dry, with the carefully tousled look structured for hours before a mirror.

Dress codes enforced in school at the time ensured no hair would slouch down past the collar, and only society aberrants would dare wear a shirt not tucked in. That was enough to be hauled from the school hallways and dressed down.

We were, after all, raised to be extremely proper, with attendant good manners and a young person's tendency towards meticulous appearance. Our whole generation, a product of the times, was preoccupied with odor and its eradication. Only the rare student didn't tote a pack of gum for fresh breath and the rare teacher who didn't have some sort of publicized regulations concerning penalties for its use.

Young-man fashion ultimately decided that we made the scene redolent of colognes like Canoe or English Leather. Always *au courant*, we rejected Old Spice as something you bought your father for Christmas (a nice little gift set, including soap-on-a-rope or the like). My father probably went to his grave with cases stowed away in his attic. Part of our morning ablutions included a liberal sousing of the day's dress till we reeked, such that our appearance in any room was foreshadowed by bilious clouds of fragrance—strong enough to clear an asthmatic's nasal passages.

Thus, our preoccupation with conforming to the norm shielded us from a growing malaise in the country. Unbeknownst in our narrow little worlds, tensions already strained at the seams of our society. In 1963, when George Wallace became governor of Alabama, he defiantly proclaimed "segregation now, segregation tomorrow, and segregation forever!" In May 1963, Alabama Public Safety Commissioner "Bull" Connor later unleashed fire hoses and police dogs on the demonstrators and arrested them by the score. In August, Martin Luther King Jr. delivered his "I Have a Dream" speech on the

steps of the Lincoln Memorial to an audience of some 250,000 during the March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom. By 1964, it had begun to boil over, with the Harlem riots hitting the news, followed directly by similar riots in Rochester in the old neighborhoods Dad had recently vacated. In the insular white neighborhoods, the prevailing sentiment ran to *what in hell did they want?* As things settled down in Upstate New York, good citizens everywhere put away their guns, clean and well-oiled.

To our itinerant family, it might as well have happened in another universe, as we had hunkered down in another move away from Rochester. Mom had become editor of the weekly newspaper in Canandaigua, some thirty miles south. During summers for a couple years at that point, absent any cheap daycare options for three kids, she'd dump us at the Canandaigua Swimming School—where the locals took swimming lessons on the lake during the day—with fifty cents each for our lunch of choice (ostensibly for a burger and soda or the like, though I'd just as likely opt for a bag of Cheetos and a carton of chocolate milk). Sometimes, though, bro and I might go out on a limb and gamble lunch money in an anxiety-ridden game of Euchre against one of the lifeguards at the school, older guys in college. A win and you'd eat big for the day, a loss and you'd go hungry. One good upshot of summers thus spent was that through all the lessons taken I became quite the swimmer, and even progressed into teaching young'uns myself.

At some point, Mom had decided that the daily commute from Rochester didn't work, so we moved back to Canandaigua—right in the middle of the spring semester of my freshman year in high school, 1964. This proved disastrous to my grades, as I

suddenly had a month to prepare for finals in classes I hadn't been taking over the course of the year. Particularly adept at the laziness of youth, I had been accustomed to doing just enough work at school to get my grades and skate by. My GPA took a hit I would struggle to overcome, as we stayed there until I finished high school, though in several different locations around town.

I labored as well to find my place in a well-defined teen society there. Though we had lived briefly in Canandaigua previously, the small town was essentially a bedroom community where most of the kids had grown up together, and by high school local teens had gravitated into cliques to which one did or didn't belong. I wasn't cool, good-looking, athletic, or any of the other established norms that allowed for ready acceptance, and I fell into a carefully crafted persona of the brash, bold, and witty outsider. I soon happened upon a small crowd of like-minded miscreants, and one particular varmint, Carlito, would remain my partner in crime over the next fifty years.

If anything, Canandaigua epitomized small-town America, nestled as it was in the Finger Lakes region of Upstate New York. The name means "chosen spot" in Iroquois. It's worthy to note that the Iroquois Federation of tribes ruled an empire in the Northeast that at one time dwarfed even the Roman in size and extent. In the 21 years I lived in New York, I never met an Indian. By the Sixties, the tourist and his vacation dollar were king, with Canandaigua Lake and its amusement park the court.

High school reverie, as such, generally consisted of cruising Main Street quaffing a tallied amount of illicit six-packs in the back seat of an older dude's clunker, in search of forbidden fruit. A fruitless quest, mostly, because sex in its most common

form nestled only within the folds of *Playboy* magazine—and in the fevered dreams of pubescent boys. The search, nevertheless, proceeded apace in all earnestness, however ineptly.

Ultimately, frustration and the predetermined, defined path to success—college—led young Canandaiguans out into the world. By high school, we had all mapped out, as our parents expected, our personal paths to glory. Given the times, with the escalation of the war in Vietnam, the real options had become more and more limited. If you went on to college, you would be exempt from the draft. That point was made perfectly clear when the body bags from earlier graduating classes began arriving home. Still, ever the good citizens, we told ourselves: "I'll do my duty if I'm called upon by my country. But I think I'd rather be getting on to college."

Besides, college was the defined road to success. We never believed that cowardice entered into the decision. We felt for sure that we would fight if we had to, but wouldn't go looking for it. At that time and beyond, Vietnam was a blue-collar war, waged on the backs of *hoi polloi* progeny for the politics of national honor—or some such. We believed the government rationales on communism and domino theory. And we partied on.

~2~

The Heart of the Matter

Carlito and I had managed to gather around us a crusty bunch of Canandaigua misfits. We didn't hobnob with the town's finest teens, who hung out at the country club or yacht club during the summer or the Bristol Mountain ski lodge in the winter. The product of a lower-class upbringing, we had no money to speak of to buy the many things classmates sported as accouterments of the good life. None of us dated much (*my* first date would be a disastrous senior ball). We had no clue how to interact with any of what we considered the desirable girls. We weren't part of any "in crowd," but we worked hard to make sure they maybe liked us—or at least tolerated us. We opted instead for Friday-night penny-ante poker games rotating among our houses.

We gravitated smoothly to gambling associated with the racetrack that opened up eight miles outside of town, immersing ourselves in literature on handicapping horse races and booking bets amongst classmates. This fit in well with the

underworld-cool persona we sought to project. It would've been better if we could have actually made money doing it.

And even better if Mom had not gotten so wrapped up in track life. Her favorite bar lay within spitting distance of the track, and she began drinking there with some of the shady characters who worked on the backstretch—the barn area—with horses. Her mother died about that time, leaving her what amounted to a tidy sum derived from Texaco stock she'd squirreled away, nearly $80,000, a handsome stash in those days. She used a small chunk of it to buy us a house, a small three-bedroom ranch-style house just outside town. But the rest she quickly frittered away on one drunken boyfriend or another, blowing a big part of it on a string of horses for a smooth-talking trainer down on his luck—who promptly shipped them out of her life for parts unknown.

I was aghast, as were my siblings, but had myself felt the allure of the backstretch and maybe understood better than they her boozy inclinations. I had been writing for the town's weekly paper as the local kid voice (speaking truth to power when the YMCA raised the price of ping-pong from a nickel to a dime) and then added a column on horses to watch at the track—a poor man's betting guide. And when an older neighbor came back one morning with fifteen dollars in his pocket made working for just one day at the track, I headed for the big time.

In comparison, the paper route I'd thrown for years paid a meager six or seven dollars a week, tops. And it meant getting up daily at 5:00 a.m. to make the rounds, as well as chasing down deadbeat customers in the evenings to collect. If I had to get up early to work, why not make it worth my while . . . This new source of quick cash attracted many of the town's teenagers. The trainers at the track needed hotwalk-

ers, people who walk the horses around the shedrow each morning to limber them up while their stalls are cleaned. For walking a horse thirty minutes, you could make a dollar; ten horses a day, a minimal effort, paid a princely wage for those times. Young Canandaiguans, thumbing rides, dotted the road to the track every morning when school was out. And before long, we all wore boots, spit a lot, and spoke in a fair drawl (for New Yorkers).

The first two summers I worked there, I really had to hustle to get into the backstretch. To pass the gate into the stable area, you needed a pass, and to get a pass, you had to be sixteen. So I skirted the gate and climbed the fence in remote corners of the spacious grounds to avoid security guards. The first summer, I walked horses for whoever paid me, from the seediest of low-life hucksters to the brassiest of the big-money operators, who wheeled and dealed horses like used cars.

I could never be sure I'd make it into the backstretch every morning. The guards caught me jumping the fence several times, lectured me, and booted me out—only for me to return to hit the fence again the next morning. I wore a cowboy hat two sizes too big in the hope that it would cover my youth as well as my head. In the cafeteria, I carefully sat with my back to any guards who might be in drinking coffee. All in all, I stayed pretty much invisible for two years of summers and weekends.

Much of the time, I walked horses for Mario, a Canadian sharpie who shipped five horses a week in and out of higher-class tracks in Canada. He often led all trainers at our track in wins (as well as in bets placed, no doubt). Mario wintered in New York, choosing not to migrate to Florida tracks with the majority of trainers. He exercised his horses during the winter

by riding them cross-country through snowdrifts to muscle them up. The dude was tough, and he was brutal.

Horses that didn't win for him when he expected were likely to get knocked around. You didn't cross Mario—a few kicks in the gut, a lashing across the head with a bridle, sometimes an out-and-out whipping. The horses trembled at his command.

When I started working with him, he had managed to purchase an expensive filly cheap because she had undiagnosed problems and couldn't run. He babied her along for a year, feeding her lumps of sugar and apples, never as much as raising his voice at her. She nuzzled right up to his coddling and pampering. Mario never allowed anyone else to even touch her, and she soon became a ferocious bitch.

He finally discovered that she had a cyst in her ovaries, which the vet removed, and his precious could run again—like the wind. She beat the best competition at the track so badly that no other trainers would enter their horses in a race against her. She was the class of the track.

But only Mario could get near her. Whenever I ducked into the stall to feed her, she reared up and came after me, all hooves and teeth. I still carry around a dent in my head from one of her flailing attacks. I took to feeding her when Mario wasn't around, so I could defend myself with a shank or bridle. Better not let Mario catch you going after his darling.

Finally one day, standing near her stall with my back to her, holding a horse for the blacksmith to shoe—just as Mario approached—she lunged out against the webbing at the front of her stall, jaws spread, and nailed me in between my shoulder blades.

The pain! Wheeling quickly and ignoring Mario's shout,

I put every ounce of strength into one solid punch that landed with a thud square on her snout. She stopped dead, her knees wobbled, her eyes glazed over, and she staggered back, shaking her head. I dropped the reins of the horse I held and resigned my position, with great satisfaction. I didn't like the way Mario handled horses anyway.

After overcoming my initial fear of these giant, skittish beasts, I'd learned to love them. Racehorses have been inbred over the years for speed and endurance and are, consequently, high-strung animals. Many young Canandaiguans found they couldn't control thoroughbreds and wound up being dragged around the stable area a few times before they decided to find employment elsewhere.

Early on, I mastered what police call a "command voice" and managed to add some conviction to it. A horse has to know who's boss, or he'll make his own rules. At the same time you have to respect them because every year stable hands die when they stray into the path of a flying hoof. You always have to stay on top of a racehorse—be in command. But Mario took mastery of his horses to the extreme; he had no feeling for his stock.

I had turned sixteen and wanted a steady job, as well as the gate pass that went with it. More, I wanted to work for a level-headed trainer. So, I went to Johnny Rowne, an old-timer I'd helped on occasion (and who had a soft spot for my mother—and she, him). He liked me because I'd shown him I could handle horses. But, more important to him, it seemed he saw something in me. Johnny's horses were his pets, his children almost. He didn't want anyone working for him that didn't think his way. He hired me because I affectionately clowned with his kids.

Of course, that meant getting a haircut. You couldn't get a pass if your hair hung past your collar or fell down on your forehead. They didn't want any no-account besmirching their reputations. This rule would remain in force until, several years later, they tried to muscle a jockey with money who showed up for work and took them to court. But for that gate pass, and to work for Johnny, I hit the barber and cleaned up my act.

Johnny, then in his late sixties, was a plain little man with simple tastes. A full-blooded Cherokee, he had worked with thoroughbreds for fifty years, beginning as a jockey not long after the turn of the century. He lived in a small room at the track so he could be close to his horses. Every morning during the summer, I'd knock on Johnny's door at 5:00 a.m. He always popped right out, dressed in gray work pants and a gray jacket zipped up tight, the tiny collars paralleling the jut of his chin. A battered gray Stetson, pinned up in front like Gabby Hayes', covered half his head and a mop of still-black hair. His weather-hewn features and dark complexion contrasted to an eternal beard stubble, which bristled gray.

Johnny cut quite a comical figure: the grizzled pint-sized dude with a rollicking gait, not quite convincing anybody with his gruff manner. Everyone knew Johnny was a softie.

Each of his horses had a nickname. Johnny's "Big Horse," a towering brown gelding named Part Time Indian, he dubbed "the Injun." The old bitty of his string, Flora Bonda, was "Mother" (though when she occasionally tried our patience, the nickname became somewhat stronger). Our favorite, a small, stout, black gelding named Freedom Rider, we called "Junior"—he being the friskiest of the family.

Johnny raced "the Injun" for nearly ten years, setting a couple of track records in the process. By the time I hired on, though, the horse approached retirement. Johnny had made him into a big, lazy pet. You didn't even need a shank to lead him around the shedrow; he just followed you, stopping when you stopped. Finally, a year or two before Johnny legally had to retire him, he put the old trooper out to pasture. I noted—but was too young to really share—Johnny's anguish when his Big Horse died.

"Mother," a squirrely old mare, also had won some big races for Johnny. The years I worked with her she spent recovering from bowed tendons, a common problem in the fragile front legs of thoroughbreds. Because she couldn't be run, or even exercised, she became quite rank, hard to handle. Just when her legs finally healed, she went berserk in a thunderstorm and threw her hip out, permanently disabling her. So, Johnny shipped her out to end her life chewing grass on a farm.

"Junior" had real personality, always shuckin' and jivin', nippin' and playin'. At one time, he ran at class tracks against high-dollar horses, but problems with his front knees gradually devalued him. Seven days a week, Johnny would spend hours after the chores were done rubbing and wrapping Junior's knees, keeping "the porky little devil," as he called him, healthy.

Every morning at five as Johnny and I appeared at the shedrow to dole out dippers of breakfast oats, there'd be Junior, grinning, bobbing his head, and stomping his feet, as if to say: "Let's go, you guys. Let's get this day on the road."

"Shit, Craaaaig," Johnny would say, always stretching my

name out four or five a's, "You'd better air out ol' Junior first this mornin', or he won' be worth two dead flies."

Junior always performed well for Johnny, earning a steady flow of cash. He ran so well one particular season that another trainer claimed him for $2,500. (Horses running in claiming races, the majority of them, can be claimed before the race runs, changing owners after.) Johnny didn't say much—it's all part of the game.

Over the next few months, Junior ran for his new owner against a slightly higher class of horses. All along, he ran like a palsied cow, badly beaten in every start by a class of horses he should have competed well against. The new owner dropped him back down to the $2,500 level, but could still barely get him across the finish line ahead of the meat wagon. Johnny chuckled, saying, "They just don' know 'bout them knees, Craaaaig."

Finally, the new owner—perplexed that a horse that earned $9,000 in the previous year couldn't win back a penny of his investment—dropped him down into a $2,000 race. Johnny immediately claimed him back, pocketing the extra $500. Junior then proceeded to win another $10,000 in the next year. Older hands at the track, who'd seen it all happen before, knew better than to claim one of Johnny's horses: Nobody could get them to run as well as the Indian did.

It had little to do with Junior's knees, really. Anybody at the track can rub knees. But not everybody knew which farmers in the county sold hay with just the right mix of alfalfa in it (Johnny said too much alfalfa gave the horses gas). Nobody else but the Indian knew the country roads that hid patches of wild clover the horses so loved. Few others spent

every waking hour puttering around the shedrow, attending to small hurts and cares. Johnny entwined his life around the lives of his charges; he left himself time for little else.

We worked together over the next two years, the two of us maintaining nine horses. Racetrack routine often tied up sixty hours a week and was rough on a young man's night life, but working conditions made it seem more a way of living than just a job. But the wages paid certainly wouldn't have allowed me to retire young.

The next summer, I quit to earn real money, as an apprentice carpenter on a high-rise construction job. I lasted a month. When I returned to the track, Johnny had my job waiting for me. He knew I'd be back. I was hooked.

Not that Johnny and I made a rosy couple. We had our differences. On the afternoons we had horses entered in races, we returned to the shedrow after lunch for preparations: extra rub-downs, brushings and combings (no braids or flowers in the mane for Johnny's horses), and pep talks. Some horses ran better when their legs were iced, so we'd hold them standing in a tub for hours before racetime.

But on afternoons we didn't race, negotiations began in earnest. I usually tried to skate into town, following the urgings of my youth, although Johnny would want me to stick around and learn always a little more about horses.

I'd tell him I loved horses but I'd make my money with my head. I'd be a rich lawyer and maybe own a string of horses—which Johnny would train. He always just chuckled and gave me that "crazy-kid" look.

I didn't apprentice out to a blacksmith who asked because blacksmiths are a nervous bunch, and all seem to be

missing a finger or two. I didn't apprentice out to the vet, who was interested, because I couldn't hack the many years of science classes. And I wouldn't commit to Johnny because the racetrack offered no way to get rich quick.

As noted, I was a mercenary little bastard. The Indian had to barter with me to get me to mow the lawn, and any extra tasks that he needed help with on off afternoons had their price. My free time cost him dearly. I didn't really know the value of what I had.

Postscript: When I decided to move on, to check out life in New York City (detailed later), Johnny couldn't believe it: "What you goin' do that for, Craaaaig? You don't belong down there. They ain't like you."

He sighed and shook his head, too tired for the crazy-kid look.

After my first aborted year in the city, I returned upstate, looking to head back under the shedrow. I finagled my way into the backstretch, but was shocked to find our barn now occupied by a fat Florida trainer. Searching the stable area, I finally found Johnny, head down, drinking coffee by himself in the kitchen. His beat-up Stetson was mashed down further than usual, covering his eyes. His dark complexion had turned ashen, with a frightening tint of yellow.

This wasn't the Johnny I'd sat next to on overturned buckets, eating fresh corn-on-the-cob and laughing at the kittens skittering from stall to stall in hot pursuit of invisible monsters.

He talked in a slur about doctors and medication, saying he had retired. "I sold mah tack, Craaaaig. I don' feel so good."

I filled the conversation with questions about Junior and the rest, trying to keep it light and easy to conceal the horror in my heart. Haltingly, yet clearly attempting to comfort *me,* he said they were all turned out to pasture on a friend's farm.

Remorse and grief choked the words from my mouth. I could say little more, except, finally: "Damn, Johnny. Take care of yourself."

He reassured me, saying: "Them doctors was pretty smart. They got me on all kinda treatments. Don' worry 'bout me."

Feeling useless, powerless, I managed to blurt out something about calling me if he needed anything. I felt hollow, facing a man with so much of what must be peace of mind and love in him (something that had heretofore eluded me), reduced to holding a cup of coffee with two hands to steady it. I held back my tears only out of respect. I wished then I'd never left Johnny, and that we could spend the rest of our lives together clowning with the horses.

I heard soon after that Johnny had died. I swore that someday, somehow, I'd find the words to describe what he meant to me. But they just don' make words like that anymore.

~3~

Higher Education

The racetrack life did provide us a certain cachet amongst our peers in small-town Canandaigua, albeit of a somewhat seedy nature. We were *those* types. But for us, this seemed a step in the right direction. We hadn't blossomed early into the athletic dudes who starred on the various sports teams, allowing them the glory of the day—and the honor of rubbing shoulders with the upper strata of town teens (karmic justice, however, that they would wind up in town selling insurance to the locals).

Nor did we fall heir to the emoluments of the monied class in town, trendsetters in fashion and thought. Though truth be told, a good portion of the burg's wealth stemmed from eager participation in peddling illicit refreshment during Prohibition. We didn't *know* these things then; we just experienced them. And scrapped hard to establish ourselves as someone to be reckoned with, on some level.

As is the wont of teen boys, we fought our obligatory

fights, though with no one in particular who would embarrass us by kicking our asses. I made a stab at the wrestling team—as much for lessons in self-defense as glory—but found the going rough. A rather unmotivated pudgester weighing in north of 220, I actually won the competition to represent the team at heavyweight for our first scrimmage. But I quickly hit a wall, facing off against a man mountain who tipped the scales at more than 300 pounds. I danced around for a period and even led 2-1, until we grappled and I tried a fancy maneuver called the Chinese Slingshot—designed to quickly sling him over my body and land with me over him. Instead, his prodigious bodily inertia turned the trick move into a slow-motion disaster and plunked him flat on top of me. I could scarcely breathe, let alone move. Match over. As I got on the team bus afterwards, one wise ass quipped, "Nice flip, Hattersley."

In the next wrestle-off to see who would be the team heavyweight (refereed by teammates as was the practice then), I saw I wasn't to be the chosen one, beaten on a quick count when I tried a clever roll to escape. My teammates wanted Clem, who I had beaten in the first go-around, to be the guy, and that made it all too apparent. *Fuck this.* I left after showering and never returned. So ended a rather unpromising wrestling career.

Like most teens, I was basically pretty damn lazy. I never did more than it took to get by. I did just enough studying to get the grades, blessed with a memory that allowed for the storing of massive amounts of data for regurgitation come test time. As we settled in to high school, my GPA gradually climbed, allowing for the occasional problem as when once caught mentioning to some less benighted members of the class what might be on a forthcoming test.

Like everyone else, I took the courses counselors told me I had to take: "You want to be a lawyer? Okay. You're in these classes."

There weren't any options; it was a package deal. High schools programmed students to make them presentable for college. And as we all knew, you either went to college and became something or ended up collecting garbage or digging ditches. Canandaigua High did offer a few classes for those not on the college track—things like metal shop—but kids in the class only seemed to produce an inordinate number of cool stick shifts. Besides, Uncle Sam had need of those not destined for higher education. Vietnam—ever a blue-collar war, as college students got a deferment—began to siphon off needed recruits, nearly 200,000 by the end of 1965.

The war remained a world apart in Upstate New York, a year or two removed from when body bags began coming home regularly, older brothers and then even classmates. We believed the stories told us by our leaders and felt that we, too, would do our duty if called upon. It was easy to share in the national hubris of the time when your ass wasn't on the line. Besides, we just had other things to do. We were going to *be* something in this world, once we slogged through the unremitting boredom of required courses. Never have I had to fight so hard to remain awake than in two years of Latin, a must-have class for legal wannabes, taught by an older lady who droned on interminably in a lifeless monotone. *Gallia est omnis divisa in partes tres . . .*

The tedium of Sixties high school required some acting up to stir restless teens from their lassitude—generally in the form of the elaborately planned prank pulled in class or on a hapless classmate. One mind-numbing math teacher, whose

class fell just before a late lunch period, had waged war against students bringing snacks to class to ward off hunger, threatening detention and worse for offenders. So Carlito, towel draped over his arm, came into class one day, spread a table cloth on my desk, and proceeded to take monsieur's order from a proffered menu, returning with a lunch tray from the cafeteria and puttering about serving me. To his credit, the teacher took it in good stead, laughing along with the class, as Carlito and I were two of his best students.

My crowning achievement in tomfoolery, for which I was enshrined in Class of '67 lore, involved Roger, a star lineman on the football team. Befuddled by an assignment whereby he had to write a letter to a friend in French (a class he struggled mightily in), he asked my help, knowing I had previously excelled in it. The fool. Enlisting the aid of an old French dictionary, I penned an impassioned letter to a girlfriend, making copious use of words such as *forniquer* and *copuler,* after the requisite shedding of clothing and such. He, of course, had no clue what it said and dutifully turned it in. As news of my exploit spread, I was celebrated far and wide amongst my peers. The French teacher, a rather small, foppish man, didn't share in the hilarity, and stopping in the hall where I stood awaiting the day's end, looked me squarely in the eye and said, "I'm shocked," walking quickly away. Small price to pay.

The general approbation for my prank solidified a growing reputation I had built for sheer *chutzpah.* Where once I had relied upon less-savory skills to enhance my street cred—I had a flair for shoplifting on assignment to augment a meager income over winter months when the racetrack closed—I now could count some literary dash as coin of the realm. I still had to build some scholastic credit to bolster my dossier for

the impending challenge: applying to college. I joined Chess Club, Latin Club, and made it into the National Honor Society. I became sports editor of the school paper, where I could terrorize athletes with my witty word play and caustic sense of humor. John Acquilano, a favorite history and politics teacher at Canandaigua High, recruited me as broadcast announcer for home football games.

Yet other impulses vied for my attention. Bro, two years my senior, had opted out of college life when he graduated in 1965, moving to New York City to live with Dad, who was teaching at places like Columbia, Pratt, and the School of Visual Arts while writing for *Popular Photography*. Bro landed a job working for the J. Walter Thompson advertising agency, a prestigious outfit, thus allaying Mom's fears for his future prospects. But unbeknownst to her, he also began hanging out in the West Village, where bands like the Luvin' Spoonful and the Blue Magoos played to growing audiences. Dylan hung out, the Doors were beginning to get radio airplay, and the Fugs were a must-see on the college scene.

Bro abruptly quit the ad agency, growing his hair long and working instead at the Night Owl (a live-music club on Third Street, site of much hipster ado). Mom naturally flipped out, railing at him for blowing a promising career in advertising. Ever a trendsetter, she was in the first wave of parents to crash on the rocks of the Sixties.

With her eldest son, she could write it off. He was as rebellious and cantankerous as she, probably just a black sheep. As the number-two son, always able to succeed despite all-consuming laziness, I still aspired to riches, planning to retire a millionaire at thirty to a life in politics. She still had me to pin her hopes on.

As I diddled my way through the remaining two years of high school, I'd look forward to Bro's visits from the city. The long hair gave me pause initially, as it struck me as somehow unmanly at that point, stuck as I was in ruling mores. But the girls in my class just loved it. He'd come to visit at school on occasion, and the girls would all bubble up around him. There had to be something to *that*.

His visits also meant I'd hear the latest music from the burgeoning Village scene—and maybe get high as well. In those days, smoking pot wasn't something you did lightly, and for good reason: If you got busted, it could mean twenty years to life in Nelson Rockefeller's New York. Any trysting with the demon weed gave rise to extreme paranoia. You pulled the joint out from the inside of your shoe when you stood poised to run in the middle of the pitch-black football field with two hundred yards of open ground all around and a hundred directions to run.

Yet the times were a-changing, and as a desultory high school career wound down, a vague uneasiness settled in. I had coasted through senior year, adding on extracurricular activities to pad my flimsy résumé, but the feeling grew that nothing would ever be the same. Despite my flip waggery and assumed devil-may-care attitude, I had managed to stay out of real trouble long enough to actually graduate third in my class, something I counted on to propel me into a good college—*wouldn't it?* But that would entail some real work, as prevailing wisdom said that if you thought high school was bad, just wait till college. *High school hard? Shit.*

Nevertheless, since I planned on untold riches in life, I figured I'd shoot for the stars and go Ivy League. So I sent applications to Harvard and Dartmouth. My politics teacher,

who'd been sort of my guardian angel (that is, he saw something in me despite my being such a wise ass), talked me down: "Don't be counting on that. You know, Syracuse U. has a good law school."

I don't remember ever hearing a thing from Harvard, though I undoubtedly received some sort of form letter expressing regrets. Dartmouth thought I merited some amount of consideration and put me on their wait list, for what little that was worth. Syracuse, just ninety miles down the road and a far more prudent, economical choice, beckoned, and I became an Orangeman, working on a dual journalism/political science degree. I'd graded out well enough to receive a chunk of scholarship money and only had to borrow a couple grand. Like most kids at the time, that's what you did—just visit the bank with your parent and sign some papers.

Carlito opted to pursue accounting at the New York Institute of Technology in the city, a credible business school; besides, he could hang around in the Village and see what was happenin'. In one of my last visits to the city before leaving for college, I helped him move into a room just off Central Park. It was one large bedroom—a converted attic on the top floor—but it also included kitchen privileges, which he shared with others. This was to be the first rest stop for countless friends sojourning to the big city for a weekend, making the 360-mile trek from Canandaigua.

Many of the journeys to the city were in search of something, even if only for a small piece of the New York City lifestyle. A lot of times, trekkers didn't even know what they were looking for, only that they wanted to see.

When Carlito moved in, it seemed quite appropriate, so we redecorated his drab room with the landlady's consent.

Our grand concept involved painting two walls and the ceiling orange, the other two walls black. Needless to say, the landlady didn't love the décor, but Carlito proved a model renter and he *was* a student. So, feeling secure he was not a potential ax-murderer or the like, she let it stand—and stayed, for the most part, away from the top floor.

Soon after settling him in, I left and headed to Syracuse. Belatedly, as it seemed that he was going to have all the fun (staked out his own pad and all), and I hated leaving and missing out. Carlito stayed to welcome the first wave of Canandaigua tourists and, almost incidentally, go to school. At that point, school was supposed to be the primary preoccupation. Events would yet make it a hindrance.

Then off to Syracuse, where I did what I knew how to do. I played the professional student, going to classes and taking the tests. A freshman's awe of new vistas and what for me was a heavy workload muffled any protest: I couldn't afford to entertain self-doubts. Cowed by the sheer weight of college, I felt only constantly in danger of falling behind.

But as the year wore on, I began to realize that college differed from high school only in intensity. It was the same old shit. In fact, with proper time management, I could get the week's worth of work done on Sunday, leaving the rest of the time for more pleasant diversions.

That fall of 1967, weekends often revolved around Saturday football games. Syracuse had been a major power in college ball, culminating in a national championship in 1959. A series of all-star running backs powered the Orangemen, featuring the likes of Jim Brown, Ernie Davis (the first African American to win the Heisman Trophy), and Floyd Little. By my freshman year, however, the team foundered, poised on

the brink of irrelevance despite moose running back Larry Csonka. Syracuse struggled to a 6–6 record.

Afternoons after the games, student frustrations boiled over in a riotous mass that descended on the green between frat houses, where kegs fueled emotions. At the time, you only had to be eighteen to drink, and a drunken throng engaged in a testosterone free-for-all. As spectators to the battles, my dorm mates and I moved from arena to arena, gathering around wild-eyed combatants until an unceremonious KO bade us venture on. On the perimeter of the thousands, nervous university and city cops stood vigil, a cordon of righteousness prepared to die to keep the riot from the city. A splendid time was had by all.

During the week, students turned to the business at hand, and I found myself growing more introspective, considering what I had become and what I'd rather be. Dorm life then was pretty settled. You had three squares in a university cafeteria attached to the living area, where you could eat whatever you wanted and however much you could cram in. You could pack on the pounds without much thought and many did. But I determined that I needed to change myself, and began monitoring my intake, then haunting the gym every night after dinner to work on my basketball game. After showering, I'd weigh myself and note the gradual improvement as I discovered the latent athlete emerging. College life began to work in my favor.

The dorm also provided me with the working capital I desired. Freshman English, a necessary pox on the lot of us, provided a chance for quick cash, as my pecuniary nature rapidly perceived. My graduation gift had been Mom's electric typewriter as she had no money to give me and plenty of typewriters at work, and I parlayed that into spending money.

I began by typing up dorm mates' papers for them, making good use of the skills gained in a high school typing class and erasable bond to deliver a perfect product. But then I discovered where the real money lay: Papers for freshman English, a required subject, were the bane of college students. So I soon hawked my wares as a ghost writer, ready and willing to expound—to the required limit, for the required two-fifty-a-page fee—on virtually any poem or story in the freshman English syllabus, taking into account customers' relative writing skills. I got so cocky doing it that I could guarantee a B on the paper if clients exhibited a certain artistry of their own.

The only trouble I encountered in this avocation was with my old friend from the Canandaigua football team, who'd won a scholarship to play for Syracuse. I knew the quality of his writing, so for his papers I'd just pop a sheet of paper in the typewriter and flail away for two pages, taking care not to use many big words. Easy money. It seems everything progressed smoothly for the first six papers I wrote for him, but then he couldn't (or wouldn't) afford the seventh, penning his own, an unfortunate move. The professor flunked him, realizing he couldn't have written the first six, and he had to take freshman English again in the summer. His bad. Business was brisk in 1967.

A touch of desperation fueled my burgeoning business, as all felt the pressure to maintain grades and stay out of the draft, which increasingly demanded more inductees for our Vietnam venture. Our little brush-fire police action (how it was initially described) was cranking up into a full-scale Audie Murphy, *Hell Is for Heroes* feature. Not everyone in the dorm responded well to the strain.

My roommate, a hapless sort plagued by a dominating

father, completely lost it that semester. Dubbed "The Fish" on the floor (to my "Country Joe"), he blew off everything, playing Monopoly and Risk through the night, eating delivered pizzas and drinking beer, then sleeping all day and skipping classes. After flunking out midway through the semester, he enlisted in the Marines. I've often wondered if George made it through okay. He had a bad habit of falling asleep drunk early in the morning with his record player set to play, over and over, the song "Birds of a Feather" by Joe South. To this day, I cannot stand to listen to that tune. For a semester and a half I roomed with my typewriter and a booming paper business.

My courses in modern American history and politics began to take their toll on me freshman year, souring my aspirations for political stardom—given the price you paid to suck up to the powers that be and their affluence. I learned therein of the roots of Vietnam, a war France waged to retain colonial hegemony in Southeast Asia (then called French Indochina). The French had refused to allow Vietnamese independence after World War II even though the Vietnamese had fought with allies against the Japanese. In eight years of war, France could not extinguish the desire for independence in its colony, culminating in its disastrous defeat at Dien Bien Phu.

In the Geneva Accords signed after peace talks, the world powers decided that the Vietnamese should in fact determine their own future. This was their Revolutionary War, after all, the fight for self-determination. But this couldn't stand for the adherents in the U.S. to the domino theory of communism. (Eisenhower himself said in 1954 that if elections were held, eighty percent would likely vote for Ho Chi Minh.) So we were off to the races. Interestingly enough, only years later was it revealed, with the publication of a book by Robert McNamara

(Secretary of Defense under Kennedy) that JFK decided the U.S. needed out of Vietnam and ordered the first one thousand troops withdrawn. Fifty days later, Kennedy died in Dallas along with that plan.

As my political awareness increased, so too did my desire to apply myself in new, *righteous* directions. And the campus quad, with its tables of youthful advocates hawking their political wares to all who would listen, attracted me with its missionary zeal. I pondered for a time joining the Peace Corps, made popular as it was during John Kennedy's presidency. I had, after all, stuffed envelopes for JFK in 1960 in democratic headquarters at Mom's newspaper office. But I wasn't ready to make *that* big of a commitment. I opted instead for signing up with the Peace and Freedom Party and the Students for a Democratic Society, the SDS (a fact, I'm sure, duly recorded in an FBI file somewhere), attending a couple meetings to check it out.

Above all, these SDS meetings proved to be tedious: long, drawn-out arguments over semantics mostly, with one wild-eyed weirdo arguing vehemently for campus action—of *any* sort—to "show the man," or some such. We dismissed him as an anarchist then, though in retrospect he was in no doubt part of the CointelPro Program we'd later find out about, just itching to break hippie heads and employing provocateurs to jump-start rioting. At some point, he ultimately persuaded perhaps half of the group (probably because of a growing boredom with the interminable meetings) to charge down and occupy the McDonald's on campus. I went along and sat in the restaurant, but soon began to feel pretty silly. This didn't really seem to me to be the way towards reform of any kind, and the college kids working there and haplessly watching were

in the same boat as I (though maybe even in cheaper seats, if possible). And besides, McDonald's was where I went to get my twenty-five-cent strawberry milkshakes. And since I had a quarter and believed more strongly in the freedom of milkshake, I bought one and left, ending my association with SDS.

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Beginning of the End

The SDS experience at Syracuse wasn't far different from that at many other colleges nationwide, as subsequent discussions with other baby boomers showed. While opposition to the war spread to the general population (a 1967 Gallup poll revealed that an increasing majority of Americans considered our military involvement in Vietnam to be a mistake), burgeoning demonstrations by and large remained relatively peaceful. A linkage to a more visceral civil-rights movement became clear when Martin Luther King Jr. said in 1967, "If America's soul becomes totally poisoned, part of the autopsy must read 'Vietnam.'"

The good portion of the hullabaloo and media attention drawn to the antiwar movement came courtesy of the Yippies, the Youth International Party (founded by, among others, Abbie Hoffman, Jerry Rubin, and Paul Krassner). Their appeal lay mainly in their irreverent sense of humor, seen in elaborate and satiric antics such as their appearance at the visitors' gallery

of the New York Stock Exchange, where they chucked fistfuls of real and fake dollars to the traders on the floor below, causing on the one hand boos and hisses and on the other a mad scramble for the loot. (The gallery was subsequently closed until a glass barrier could be installed.)

While we enjoyed the theater of the inspired chaos threatening the status quo, Syracuse students remained pretty sedated. The male freak scene there, such as it was, consisted of fashionable young dudes maybe with sprouting sideburns and hair creeping over the collar, if only in response to high-school dress codes no longer in force. Revolution came slowly in the gray skies of Upstate New York: The passive intelligentsia were content with having their letters published in the school newspaper and in observing from the fringes the Saturday-afternoon football fracas. A ready supply of drugs—nothing more potent than rather mediocre pot—supplemented the alcoholic beverages of choice available to all in the many campus bars. Syracuse police avoided campus confrontation, undoubtedly to avoid busting anybody whose family might be of import. An uneasy peace settled in at SU while elsewhere campus demonstrations built in size and intensity in protest of the war. Events in the spring of 1968, however, soon heated things up.

At the end of March, President Lyndon Johnson, beset by seething racial resentment in the country and antiwar fervor, declared he would not seek reelection. What looked to be a hummer of a contest loomed. Just five days later, Martin Luther King Jr. was assassinated in Memphis, precipitating another round of race riots in a hundred cities nationwide. In our Syracuse dorm floor of some fifty males, the only two black guys shared a room in a corner by themselves. I knew one

peripherally, as we played together on our intramural basketball team. In a naked show of solidarity, I took a small stash of hashish I had to their room and smoked them out. They seemed to appreciate the gesture.

But the upcoming election aroused me like nothing else, as steeped in politics as I had become. Vice President Hubert Humphrey, a genial political hack, would no doubt run. Eugene McCarthy, long a leader in antiwar politics and a darling of intellectuals, had assembled a rag-tag army to do battle with LBJ. But even as Johnson quit the field, McCarthy faced the problem of not being a saleable commodity. Nobody could know for sure how strong the middle-America backlash was to the racial unrest and campus demonstrations—and the Democratic party bosses weren't about to gamble. Bobby Kennedy appeared the heir apparent, whipping McCarthy in the primaries straight out to June primaries in California. But Sirhan Sirhan blew him away during the celebration.

On the Republican side, politicians like George Wallace and Richard Nixon campaigned on restoring law and order to a "silent majority" troubled by the unrest, bad blood kept a-simmer until it boiled over at the 1968 Democratic National Convention in Chicago. There, in an immense, farcical horror show staged by Chicago police and Mayor Richard Daley, Hubert Humphrey won the Democratic nomination. The whole scenario played out like something out of a wild, Republican dirty-tricks campaign.

Demonstrators flocked in to disrupt the convention in Chicago: In April the city had undergone two days of rioting after the death of Martin Luther King, leaving 11 dead, 48 wounded by police gunfire, 90 policemen injured, and more than 2,000 people arrested. During the race riots, Democratic

machine boss Mayor Daley gave police the authority "to shoot to kill any arsonist or anyone with a Molotov cocktail in his hand . . . and . . . to shoot to maim or cripple anyone looting any stores in our city." Against that backdrop, Daley vowed that "law and order will be maintained" during the convention.

Events began humorously enough, as Jerry Rubin and friends attempted to nominate Pigasus the Pig as Yippie candidate for president. Several hundred spectators and reporters had gathered to witness the staged media event, and police who were already there waiting arrested Rubin, folk singer Phil Ochs, and five other Yippies. He also promised, on behalf of Pigasus, a fair election campaign—and if Pigasus won he would be eaten. Rubin avowed this would reverse the usual democratic process in which the pig is elected "and proceeds to eat the people."

Conditions deteriorated in the ensuing days, as tempers flared and actions grew more outrageous, with the whole world watching. In incidents later characterized in the Walker Report as a "police riot," demonstrators—along with TV reporters, doctors, and whoever else happened along—were beaten senseless by the cops. In *Miami and the Siege of Chicago,* Norman Mailer wrote:

> *The military spine of a great liberal party had finally separated from the skin . . . the power had decided, "No, do not let them march another ten blocks and then disperse them on some quiet street, no, let it happen before all the land, let everybody see that their dissent will soon be equal to their own blood; let them realize that the power is implacable, and will beat and crush and imprison*

and yet kill before it will ever relinquish the power. So let them see before their own eyes what it will cost to continue to mock us, to defy us, and resist . . . There are more cowards alive than the brave."

In that climate, what right-thinking, middle-of-the-road American could have believed that chirpy Democratic lackey Hubie could measure up to the turbulent times as they were? At least they accepted that Nixon could be an asshole when necessary. This asshole factor might well have ultimately turned the tide of the election: an attempt to bring back the staid Eisenhower years of sedate nihility, all in the guise of law and order. When the votes were counted, it was decided that maybe the kids *had* gone too far. . . .

Meanwhile, back in Syracuse, my dabble in SDS had pretty much soured me on the local version, and as for the Peace and Freedom Party, not much can be said. The only time I saw them in action played out the next fall when Democratic vice presidential candidate Edmund Muskie came to the university to speak. The PFP candidate for VP (I can't for the life of me remember her name) showed up with a bullhorn, shouting down old Ed whenever he tried to say anything. Ultimately, my sense of fair play saw me siding with the crowd when they grew annoyed with this tactic and told her to clam up and shove off. So much for my Syracuse activism.

Social life at the U had proved much more engaging. Freshman year, by the spring of 1968, had devolved into barely restrained boorishness courtesy of our dorm-floor denizens, a succession of antics blowing off steam (as is generally the wont of young Big Men on the Campus). By then, the habitués of our ward had cultivated a rep as campus bad boys. Every

week there'd be new stories about what happened over the weekend when Vic and Dave got drunk, came back with outlandish tales or an appropriated street sign or other memento. And we lived, as always, for the perfect practical joke.

One day, while Vic was in the floor phone booth talking to a girlfriend, pranksters piled up all the lounge furniture and sealed him in. Mark then grabbed one of the floor fire extinguishers and proceeded to hose him down through available openings. As happened, the curses and blandishments of said victim were met with uproarious laughter and a hardy: "What's that, Vic? You say you want *more*?" No mercy.

The floor RA (resident adviser) only happened to be around when it came time to clean up the messes.

Another hapless fellow, seen on the floor as too cool by half, happened to get his door jammed one evening so he couldn't get out of his room. His screams of rage and protestation echoed down the halls as a number of inebriated floor fiends, upon discovering his dilemma, filled galvanized garbage cans with water and poured them under his door. His worst longshoreman dialectic brought only guffaws and the refrain: "What's that, Bob? You say you want *more*?"

Amused as I was by the floor antics, I had to husband the limited funds gleaned from my ghostwriting business and couldn't often partake in the liberal lubrication leading to said buffoonery. Others in the dorm received allowances that gave them free rein to imbibe on weekends and cut loose. But they sometimes shared in their good fortune: On one occasion, Vic and Dave enlisted my aid in the polishing off of a gallon of Gallo cream sherry. To one like myself, not yet familiar with the ups and downs of alcohol consumption, it was an expe-

rience never forgotten—and one of the few times in my life when I could not, try as I might, walk a straight line afterwards, bouncing from wall to wall in the dormitory. I awoke that night from a sound sleep, jolted to semi-sensibility by my abrupt fall from bed. After a hurried stumble to the bathroom, I discovered that cream sherry tastes as sweet coming up as it does going down. You live and learn.

My weekends that spring often entailed a different adventure—hitchhiking the ninety miles back to Canandaigua to visit the nascent hip community in our small town. Or catching a Greyhound bus for a trip to the city to see how Carlito was getting on. That spring, he and I exchanged visits on a couple weekends, him escaping New York or me Syracuse. By that time, my roommate had flunked out, and I had an extra bed anyway should he care to drop in.

For one particular visit, I scored some tickets to our first rock concert together: the Young Rascals and Martha and the Vandellas. We sat somewhere towards the back and side, but our vision was in no way aided by our chemically fogged perceptions. We spent much of the show trying to figure out if Felix, lead singer of the Rascals, had grown a beard.

The bus trips to and from New York City, as we exchanged visits, made it really hard to go for just a weekend. The Greyhound route through Pennsylvania made for hours of ossifying boredom, a six-hour vigil, minimum. One ride—the best, cause I remember it least—was spent passed out on the floor of the bus. I had had to catch a midnight bus (during a holiday weekend) and did not want to lose any sleep. So I went out that Friday and got properly polluted. When I finally boarded, all the seats were taken, so I lay down on the floor

in the back and fell sound asleep. Next thing I remembered, someone shook me to wake me up for the New York stop. No hangover, felt great, great ride. Ah, youth.

The first time I ever tried acid was on a bus to the city. Needless to say, it was a trip. I happily rode through the evening hours, watching the lights flit by, and, thank you, I enjoyed the show.

Later on, when a second high school buddy, Ricky V., moved into a new apartment with Carlito on the Lower East Side of New York, we expanded our repertoire. Ricky V. smoked cigarettes, which were then allowed on Greyhounds, and he devised a method for surreptitiously smoking pot en route. For even if you sat in the toilet in the rear and blew smoke out the window, the smell of pot quickly permeated the bus. Not a good thing in Rockefeller's New York. Ricky V. solved that with generous, noxious clouds of a fifty-cent cigar, which had the tendency to move decent folk to the front of the bus as well as blanket the tiny marijuana smell emanating from the bathroom.

Meanwhile, I had managed to establish a toehold at Syracuse U. Freshman year had served to acclimate me to the "rigors" of college life and form friendships in the dorm. The fall semester of 1968, however, started out badly. That spring, my mother had neglected to send in the hundred-dollar advance fee then required by Syracuse to reserve the next year's studentship. I didn't remember having paid it before freshmen year, with all the money that changed hands, and I myself never received any notice that it had to be paid.

This, of course, I didn't find out until I went to register that fall. After having gone through the whole ordeal, standing in long lines to sign up for each class, finally elbowing my

way through to the payoff window, I was informed my name wasn't on the list and I couldn't register.

After my mother's ensuing frantic scramble to raise the loot and ship it on down the line, I registered—dead last, before they folded up the tables and closed down. It was a god-awful schedule: eight o'clock classes five days a week and a nine o'clock French class Saturday morning.

And the courses left when I finally got to register were the absolute bottom of the barrel. One delight, a fine arts course on Renaissance painters, consisted of a two-hour lecture, twice a week, to eight hundred students. Three exams for the semester made up your grade. Required reading for the class, the professor's own book, was a handsomely bound goliath that made *War and Peace* read like Mother Goose.

The one course I held out any hope for was in religion, at a time when I began to experience some spiritual awakenings. As it turned out, the class was light years from religion as spiritualism, more an exercise in bloviation. The professor reveled in constructing each sentence of his lecture in obscure sagacity, designed, no doubt, to impress the coeds. Though I prided myself on my own vocabulary—wont to pontificate in my own right (while cranking out English papers at any level of bullshit)—this guy left me feeling like a slobbering idiot. I only understood him on vague levels of cosmic cognition, like the comprehension of a Southern Baptist confronted by his first Buddhist topknot. I wore out the pages of my dictionary and thesaurus trying to write papers in his vernacular.

That probably sums up my feeling towards the majority of college courses at the time. In succeeding years, great effort went into making college more germane and pertinent. But back then, college revolved around dull professors who took

themselves and their subjects *very* seriously, usually because they were scared half to death to be up front of the class. Which usually resulted in cascades of showy dialectic—the old veteran showing the kids what he's got, an exercise in auto-eroticism. By that time, the only students still nodding and smiling along were the kiss-asses and the twelve-year-old child geniuses.

Then as now, most college kids aren't, basically, overly bright. College, we were told, is just what you've got to do to keep from having to doing manual labor. "Dumb" people don't go to college. But people perhaps written off as "not college material" earn a good living as plumbers, electricians, carpenters, mechanics, and the like. Legions of students tend to blunder their way through college into life. They work a lot of public service jobs and drive a lot of Ford Focuses. Those with connections work at the country club and drive Cadillacs.

College, in reality, is basically the time spent between classes. If it weren't for the classes, college would be a lot of fun. All those fledgling boys and girls—their only discipline forevermore their own devise. And self-discipline usually takes years to perfect.

I struggled in my attempts to maintain, in the face of unremitting boredom that settled in. For the entire fall of 1968, I plodded through one stultifying class after another, each consisting mostly of lectures to the masses in a ponderous auditorium with the occasional test determining grades. My living conditions further compounded the situation with a growing feeling of isolation. I no longer tucked into the friendly confines of the dorm, with its attendant built-in friendships; finances dictated I now inhabited a room with three new faces in a funky apartment building on the edge of campus. My little

area did have a door on it, though, so I only had to share a bathroom with three others.

My "suite" was a small room divided to appear larger, like two closets, with a sink and a counter, which I adorned with a pair of pet gerbils I acquired for comic relief and companionship. Gerbils make a great little pet—low maintenance, cheap to feed—though they littered every couple months. I finally tired of giving away the current litter as they aged out and passed it all on to the next sucker. Gerbils go on forever—they're like a chain letter.

The Zenith Circle of Sound stereo record player I had positioned on my footlocker next to the bed played a lot of the Beatles' white album that semester. Some of the old gang from the dorm would drop by, get high, and listen to all four sides. My copy of the album cover was stained by the bottom of a large wine jug, a circular, labyrinth pattern. Since this was the era of the trick, pop-art album covers, we told one of the guys that you were supposed to immerse the Beatle cover in vineagar and salt, and a portrait would emerge. We told him I forgot to put the salt in mine and fucked it up. We also planned on telling him later on in the evening that it was a joke but forgot—and didn't get back to him till after his cover had been soaked to a soggy pulp. Just like the good old days in the dorm.

But life had changed in college without the dorm rats offering proximal support. A little bit of time had ticked off and everything had changed. It was a disillusionment along the same lines as my one-and-only panty raid in freshman year.

It must have been the first week we'd moved into the dorm when word spread that a raid was on (no doubt something upperclassmen propagated to make the newbies feel

part of something). Quickly, several hundred young freshman studs assembled and surrounded a handy girls' dorm and chanted for panties. Probably one bra and a water balloon later, I put my hands in my pockets and casually walked away. I was starting to feel like a real asshole. Another part of moving into Syracuse U. also involved a little beanie that all frosh were supposed to wear around. These quickly found a home in the dorm trashcan.

But sophomore year, all that had changed. No longer in the dorm, I couldn't just walk down to the lounge in the evening to watch *Star Trek* or the Smothers brothers. Nobody who lived in those rickety old apartments could afford a TV. A majority of the occupants of the old building were art students (the starving artist ethic and all). Actually, it was pretty hip to live there; it was hip to be poor and wear blue jeans and work shirts. I was hip.

Semi-aroused by a politics professor who managed to make one class interesting, I put in some more hours stuffing envelopes and calling registered democrats for the Hubert Humphrey campaign. The prof hated Nixon and railed long and bitter about his antics in the Alger Hiss era. I had worked on the 1960 campaign, after all, stuffing envelopes and running errands, extolling the virtues of one John F. Kennedy to all my classmates. And when the election results rolled in late that night at party HQ, I rejoiced with the local hacks, seeing it as somewhat as a personal victory, given my efforts.

My minimal involvement at Syracuse sustained my interest in an otherwise dull election in '68. The two main campaign characters excited little enthusiasm. But stuffing envelopes in a tawdry little office was in no way like leading a charge

downhill on a white stallion, something my youthful idealism yearned for, so I soon retired my stuffer. I even stopped at a sidewalk stand and this time seriously read through piles of pamphlets and brochures on the rewarding life in the Peace Corps. *Nah.*

Being disinterested was rapidly becoming very hip. It took a Spiro Agnew to jolt the jaded back to reality. The growing unrest on campuses and increasingly vocal young militants provided fodder for the Agnews of the world to use in fears to come, whipping up the grumbles of a "silent majority" patriotism into a voting force—my country right or wrong. Hippies weren't exactly idolized in bedrock America anyway: It figured someone like Spiro would want to cash in on that.

Otherwise, the election had devolved into a rather Tweedledee–Tweedledum affair, though old Hubie showed a slight edge in moral fiber. After JFK was blown away, things had started to go downhill for me politically. For starters, Lyndon Johnson was about as inspiring as creamed spinach, and so far out in front of old weird Barry Goldwater that he surely didn't need my help in the '64 campaign. After JFK's Camelot, the political arena seemed stiflingly mundane.

Nixon managed to ignite a little of the liberal fire on campus. When he came to campaign in downtown Syracuse, we marched in a candlelight parade to a designated section at the very back of the auditorium where he appeared. The main complaint students voiced with Dick's campaign was that he said over and again that we would fix things if elected, ending the war in Vietnam, but never saying how—a secret plan. So, cleverly weaving this thematic statement into tasteful protest, we waited in the auditorium till Nixon rose to speak, then

all stood and sang "The Sounds of Silence." In his inimitable greasy style, Nixon calmed the Republican majority in attendance by telling them to let us have our say.

In the months before the Nixon administration assumed control and began drawing lines, there seemed to be an immense, psychic lame-duck trough of despond, a cosmic lull before the storm. The movement had picked up some crazies along the way, and some of what you heard from both directions was surreal. It seemed like the mood of the country was at a hard boil, but it was to be nothing more than the first bubbles and wisps of steam for what was to come.

In school, the courses began taking their toll on me. My basketball game was way off; my gerbils were gone. My memory banks were short-circuited by attempting to jam too much useless information into them at one time. Inexorably, finals in the fall of 1968 approached. My grades, never of a solid stature that semester because of an insidious lassitude, teetered on the outcome of the final set of tests.

It shaped up into being a monumental week of sleepless nights wired on No-Doz, cramming for the frantic days outputting data. The day before finals week, when I should have been girding my loins for the looming battles, I caved instead. I started looking for another way out. Truth be told, I carried a 3.6 GPA from freshman year—down from my own expectations—and didn't want it to slip further. I somehow figured that these grades would convey if I started up anew at another school, a foolish assumption of youth.

I went down to my counselor's office and withdrew.

I was a man with a plan. I called Carlito and Ricky V. in New York to invite myself in as a charter roommate at their deluxe East Third Street apartment. I called my father and gained

asylum from "college"—at the School of Visual Arts, an art and photography school of some repute. My father taught photography there, so I wouldn't have to pay any tuition.

Dad, of course, was tickled pink that his young'un wanted to take up photography. When I had told him the summer before that I was taking a photojournalism class at Syracuse, he sent me a mammoth trunk full of paper, film, utensils, glassine envelopes for storing negatives, developing tanks, light meters, and even an old Nikon camera once owned by Pete Turner, a former student of his.

Mom was not real happy. Her one son who could crank out the grades and had a chance of being the lawyer (and politician) he planned to be turned into a scruffy photographer overnight. She lamented my youthful impetuosity, but, to her credit, gave way and let me decide. I would find my own way.

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Mean Streets

Idealists make a great mistake in not facing the real facts sincerely and resolutely. They believe in the power of the spirit, in the goodness which is at the heart of things, in the triumph which is in store for the great moral ideals of the race. But this faith only too often leads to an optimism which is sadly and fatally at variance with actual results. It is the realist and not the idealist who is generally justified by events. We forget that the human spirit, the spirit of goodness and truth in the world, is still only an infant crying in the night, and the struggle with darkness is as yet mostly an unequal struggle.

—Jan Christiaan Smuts

In the city, you were free to be what you wanted to be. Nobody hassled you because they couldn't be sure if you were some bottled-up crazy who might stick a knife in them. You soon learn in the city not to mess with someone else's trip.

Even a thought ventured in the wrong direction—a slight nuance, the smallest air of disdain—could lead to a massive pummeling.

Some neighborhoods you didn't venture into, and if you did, you went in broad daylight—and scurried out forthwith. NYC in 1969 contained the nucleus of modern man at the time; the greatest of good and the baddest of bad walked together. Any new concept of living naturally made its way to the city, both for its tolerance and its anonymity. Many in the embryonic hippie movement had yet to decide on their "back to the basics" inclinations until they breathed of the decaying scum in the city.

In New York City on a summer day in 1969, you could shower, take a walk around the block, then wipe a sooty black sweat off your face. As noted, the pollution there was the equivalent of smoking two packs a day of cigarettes. Some days you could walk out to the avenue and see no farther than maybe twenty blocks to the north. Everything past that was shrouded in a sulfurous yellow haze.

Weekends, especially when odd weather conditions showed blue sky, city denizens flooded Central Park, flying kites, playing softball or soccer, all in general celebration of the sun—an escape from the tedious concrete existence of the city. Months were planned around escapes upstate or just "out to the country," but most people never really got away. The city will always hold its own.

The ghettos, then not well defined and localized but massive and diffuse (poverty of mind and body that a thousand scholarly liberals couldn't imagine), went on forever. Your average redneck would have lasted about as long in the ghetto as

he would have in a pool of starved sharks. You plucked those big fish from the small pond of the suburbs and slapped 'em down on the Lower East Side 1969, the junkies would have carved them up. All those hallowed terms associated with the golden visions of America, equality of opportunity and rugged individualism, didn't resonate well in the dark heart of the city. The beasts of a thousand generations of man lived there, peering out of the darkness and snickering at the odd customs of this civilization that lived in the fluorescent sterility of a million Madison Avenue commercials. You came to this land, you were subjected to street justice, swift and merciless.

While the West Village—once the province of beatniks and poets, given over to the newly hip—promised excitement, music, and more, the East Village stunk of rotting garbage, piss, and passed-out winos. Long before money seeped in and gentrified the area, society's derelicts haunted this outpost of civilization. But, boy, rent was cheap.

It was said that a civilization can be judged on its prisons, and the bungholes of our cities serve as our modern-day gaols. Mired in his own set of problems and aspirations, the average citizen forges on, not even aware of the screaming, surreal horror that lurks there, nurtured in the rotting puke of the ruins of our great society.

> *Well, you see: once upon a time there was a blazing fire inside me. The cold could do nothing against it, a youthfulness, a spring no autumn could touch; a source of light, glowing wells of joy that seemed inexhaustible. Not happiness, I mean joy, felicity, which made it possible for me to live . . . There was an enormous energy there . . .*

A force . . . it must have been the life force, mustn't it?
. . . And then it grew weaker and all died away.
—Eugene Ionesco

But the city did offer its attractions, including an incredible overlap of cultures. You could buy a slice of pizza at one sidewalk stand, step next door and eat curried rice at an Indian restaurant, then cross the street to buy halvah and "shoe leather" (apricots pressed by some God-given miracle into thin sheets and wound up on spools) at the delicatessen. And New York City never rolled up its sidewalks and went to sleep. At any time of day or night, people bustled by on the streets with their errands and places to go. And into that mix ventured the Sixties hippie.

After the vaunted 1967 "Summer of Love" vaulted the movement into the public conscious, reality set in. The real "peace" and "free love" movement lasted probably all of a day before the knives and fast raps began penetrating the benign haze. Gradually, lessons hard learned yielded to a much more brutally realistic outlook. A generation of kids who had shaved their heads in Mohawk haircuts and popularized the Davy Crockett coonskin cap and buckskins had crossed a line, envisioning some new egalitarian construct of civilization, but they had not stepped into the sunny meadows they had envisioned—rather to the ugly underbelly of society, relegated therein by their limited commercial prospects.

But still, to many this seemed a step in the right direction. For Carlito, working on his accounting degree, that meant finding a job to keep his bachelor pad afloat. He answered an ad and found himself helping to clean out an old movie theater on Second Avenue. His boss was Bill Graham, and the

theater became the Fillmore East. Carlito then started working the box office when it opened with the Doors and Janis Joplin.

The theater sat a block and a half from St. Mark's Place (Eighth Street everywhere but between Second and Third avenues). All manner of human garbage descended to linger there. While the West Village still exuded a sort of bohemian class for visiting tourists, the East Village, home to the Fillmore, reeked from the angry mix of human flotsam residing in the area.

On St. Mark's, the Electric Circus reigned, a speed-freak mecca, and the colorful decay and stench of the young minds hanging there lent itself well to the thieves-market air of street chaos. On weekends and holidays, the Tactical Police Force set up shop to protect the clucking tourist masses that dared venture there to search out the "real city." To be in the TPF, you had to be over six feet tall and a hundred and ninety pounds—and *bad*.

Cops in the city were tough, it goes without saying, but they could be the best thing that ever happened in a pinch. In 1969, papers reported that some hundred thousand junkies haunted the city, a jungle of rotting humanity. The need for smack turned jagged nerves desperate, so knifings and shootings were just another fact of life, like deserted streets and slobbering winos.

Mike E., a Fillmore employee, was once unfortunate enough to find himself being soundly beaten by a pair of assailants, when an avenging squad car screeched up and spilled out nightstick-wielding cops. Thus sprang like the phoenix from the bloodied pile of would-be robbers the public-minded spirit of a new Mike E.

And all Fillmore employees went out of their way to

cultivate a good relationship with the local constabulary. Occasionally, a cop or two on the beat in the Fillmore area would stop in on a cold night, and we'd all make sure they got anything they might need: cigarette, coffee, wine, a toke. (Most city cops were pretty street-wise, with too much to worry about with junkies to sweat the small stuff.)

During the big shows with sell-out crowds, several precinct cops would be slipped ten each to escort Carlito to the bank with the box-office receipts. Word had it that Bill Graham picked up the tab for extravagant catered layouts at the precinct Christmas parties. One fine fall Sunday, we even sponsored a football game in Central Park between the cops and Fillmore employees (6–6 tie). It may have been true then that New York City was one of the few places in the country where hippies welcomed the sight of that blue uniform. Junkies did more for the police image in the city than any ten kill-crazy terrorist groups.

The Lower East Side, the Village included, was not a very nice place in 1969. During the winter, the morning papers would carry a small notation somewhere chronicling the number of frozen stiffs found that day.

Into this brave new world ventured Carlito, moving into an inexpensive apartment on East Third Street, an architectural masterpiece in Early Cro-Magnon Gothic. It squatted directly across the street from the Bowery Men's Shelter (Third Avenue turned into the Bowery at Third Street). The typical fourth-floor walk-up boxcar flat, it featured three rooms in a row, with a toilet stall the size of a large phone booth sandwiched to the side of the middle room, the kitchen. Actions within this stall in any but a standing position required the door to be slightly cracked to allow for knees. Thus, the fa-

cilities were appropriately labeled—from a similar sobriquet on a construction site Johnny-on-the-Spot—"Expo '67 Polish Pavilion."

Bathing required a working form of "Beat the Clock." In the post-war rush to build newer and more efficient tenements, slum moguls economized on space by stashing the tub next to the sink in the kitchen, covering it to serve as a drain board when not in use. This presented an additional problem because the door to the outside opened into the kitchen, on the other side of the sink, so the bather often found himself in hot water, literally, when friends arrived.

The door itself had to be solidly braced to withstand a not-uncommon onslaught from junkies and sundry reprobates. Several standard door locks fortified the entry plus a chain, a deadbolt, and—the final deterrent—a burglar bar. For those who have never lived in a high-crime area, the "boogie bar" is *the* last line of defense. It's simply a half-inch steel rod that secures to the floor, centered a couple of feet from the bottom of the entryway, and props securely to a receptacle in the middle of the door. Unless you have the key to release the rod from outside, you literally have to break the steel bar levered against the door to get in and rip off the apartment.

Our boogie bar at Third Street gave three junkies a hard enough time on one occasion. We were on our way laboring up four flights of stairs to the apartment, when three dudes we didn't know scurried down past us. Only when we got to the door and began the unlocking process did we discover that the locks had been mangled useless. They just didn't have the time to try to figure out how to get past that final line of defense.

I hadn't been long in the city at that point and still reck-

oned myself a force, so I blew up and went roaring down the stairs after the culprits with Carlito and Ricky V. trailing behind. On the street, I thought I recognized one and, taking his arm, bade him come into the building a moment so that I might have a word with him. He obviously demurred and backed off. Aggravated beyond all reason, I wanted to have at this guy but then noticed a beat cop approaching. I blew a gasket.

Beckoning him over, I blustered: "I caught this motherfucker and his friends trying to bust into my goddamn apartment."

Wheeling to the buster: "If I ever see your fucking ass around here again I'm gonna blow your motherfucking head off."

Cop to buster: "Did you hear what he said?"

New York City justice.

It took me aback that anyone might even think one of these tenement apartments harbored anything worth stealing. Anyone with a modicum of decency generally avoided the neighborhood.

Once in a while a Salvation Army entourage would invade Third Street at nine in the morning to broadcast marching music and prayer at a hundred decibels toward our windows. Usually having gotten to sleep scant hours earlier (and not at all overjoyed by this amplified injection of the Lord), we would quickly put them to rout with a return barrage of one-hundred-decibel metal-band Blue Cheer directed back out the window at them.

Other mornings, the frustrated musicians among the local winos proved harder to dissuade from their extended conga jams on alto and tenor garbage-can lids. Blue Cheer artillery

only added to their reverie. Screaming threats to "beat the shit outa you," sounding afar from fourth-floor windows, failed to penetrate the wine fog, though something along the lines of "I'm gonna blow you motherfuckers away," accompanied by the display of a weapon, could generally bring the session to a halt. Even in the gutter, discretion is the better part of valor.

With the men's shelter across the street, it eventually proved useful to employ one enterprising wino to stand guard over our building for a dollar a day. Sitting on the steps with his arsenal of zaps (broken bottles, clubs, or thick lengths of electrical cable) and his own pint secreted nearby, he'd keep all the other winos from passing out, puking, or pissing in our building—a common problem for the time.

Still, it was relatively safe living just west of Second Avenue. On the Lower East Side in the late Sixties, you could venture as far east as First Avenue or maybe Avenue A, but you took your chances going as far as C and D. During daylight hours, you might sally that far from civilization but only if you were well armed and on high alert. Hard-core gangs, speed freaks, and junkies ran the welcome wagon there.

Third Street east of Second Avenue suffered a drop in property values when the Hells Angels set up shop in an old storefront. But before they moved in and made all of the eastside bikers into Angels ("we's all friends, RIGHT?"), there were two main gangs, the Aliens and the Motherfuckers, bitter enemies.

Ah, the good old days—happy memories of a phalanx of green-shirted Fillmore "ushers" repelling a Motherfucker attempt to storm the fire exits in the middle of a sold-out show.

On one occasion, an Aliens head honcho was killed in a knife fight with a Motherfucker, so the Aliens grabbed an MF,

tied him to a chair, and burned him to death. And probably roasted marshmallows on the flames. One night in front of the Fillmore, a street punk was stupid enough to rip off a biker. A couple of bikers uprooted a street sign and chased him down the alley beating him over the head with it.

By the time the Fillmore hit full speed, some forty inside and outside "ushers" worked to channel people in to their seats and enforce the rules mandated by fire laws. The outside crew, because they had to deal with street people, grew into a bad bunch of mothers (and they were *all* my friends).

The crowds of concert-goers commingling with the dregs of the East Side and the warps and dark alleys of a million weird minds necessitated an especially "skilled" outside crew. Kim, for one (who was actually quite an artist), stood six foot six and weighed in north of two hundred and fifty pounds. A former biker, he'd once made a living running guns for the Black Panthers. He proved the key to an uneasy understanding with the Hells Angels when they moved in.

The outside crew *all* ran big and bad. They regularly handled knifings, beatings, and ripoffs while lining up the incoming second-show crowd behind barricades, which allowed for quick first-show customer exit. When Graham or one of the bands threw a party at the Fillmore after a grueling weekend, I'd make sure to drink a few with every one of the outside crew, making them all good old drinking buddies.

Eventually the junkies got so bad that Graham hired one of the crew (a black belt in karate) to stand guard in the lobby during the day—with a machete in his belt, no less—so the customers coming in to buy tickets wouldn't get ripped off.

On one particular night, a junkie pulled a knife on one of the outside crew and allowed that he'd "cut me up a nigger."

Unfortunately for him, he stood facing away from the backstage door, whence issued a certain Ronnie C. from the backstage crew—at the end of a combination twenty-yard dash/dropkick, blasting the assailant haplessly into the clutches of a quite perturbed black brute.

> *At the outset, the man refrains from contention during the initial stages of strife. He suffers a little, but he knows that he needs to walk together with his associates and cannot advance alone.*
>
> *—I Ching*

This New York provided a lesson in street. Canandaigua and Syracuse didn't even show up as big dots on a map of the state. A "country" boy has a way of running into things, even with eyes wide open. Thank God for the survival instinct.

For a time I found a safe place in the courses I took at the School of Visual Arts, a far cry from those I languished in at Syracuse. The emphasis was entirely art, of course, but the teachers themselves were far more laid back and much easier to like. The students made friends effortlessly, sharing an interest in art and photography as they did, and they readily accepted me even though my dad taught there. (I didn't enroll in his class to avoid any semblance of impropriety.) In the city, it was important to have friends in different places to hang with, as you won't find many on the street.

That would take some time, though. There weren't any openings at the Fillmore the first weekend after I arrived in the city, so I went and watched the show. Carlito worked in the offices during the week and usually worked the box office during shows on the weekends. Ricky V. had secured a spot

on the "crew" during the week, working the backstage on weekends. Thus, I was virtually assured a job, as the upstaters moved in, and the next weekend I became an "usher."

For my first weekend, though, Carlito had off and secured a couple tickets so we might just sit and watch the show. To enhance our experience, we split a tab of acid—something we never more than dabbled in—because the headline act left something to be desired: Iron Butterfly. After their initial success with their theme song and a first album, they "soared" to not-so-great heights with "Ina-Gadda-da-Vida" and its "fabulous" drum solo. By the time they reached the Fillmore, they teetered on the brink of music's bottomless chasm claiming forgotten stars.

So we made sure we were quite high to watch the old dinosaur take its plunge. We wondered about the opening act with the weird name. Somebody allowed as how they might be good, though they'd never played in the States. We goofily assumed our seats, medicinally enhanced as we were—front row on the right. We babbled semi-coherently to each other and fussed in our seats until the sonic boom from a stack of amplifiers blasted us into our chair backs as ten feet away, Jimmy Paige launched into Led Zeppelin's first tune. I don't remember much about the set, drug-addled as we were, though something about it messed with my DNA. I wanted to *be* that guy.

For the nonce, however, I needed to generate more income than the Fillmore would provide. I applied for a proofreading position advertised in the *Village Voice,* then a small relatively conservative weekly—before changing to tabloid form and going hog wild. I sent in a puffed-up résumé glorifying my proofing and editing work around Mom's newspapers

and the columns I wrote, my glorious success in three semesters at Syracuse, larding it on thickly. I lamented that my one drawback was that I had long hair (Beatle-ish, anyway, not much beyond mod). Summoned to the office, I was met by a shaggy dude who looked like Jesus Christ incarnate, and he offered me the gig.

The job, as it turned out, proved rather daunting. One day a week I'd catch a Path train in the afternoon out to Newark to the building that printed the paper, sitting for hours with my tunafish sub for sustenance while grizzled old Linotype operators delivered warm proofs of the contents of that week's paper. I snuffed and scratched at the galleys till the last piece of lead fit neatly into place, then made my way back to the train station. At two or three in the morning, walking around in Jersey can be intimidating, but I strode hard the darkened streets like I belonged and never did have a problem, saved perhaps by the early-morning hours midweek. Not exactly the gravy train, but with weekend nights spent working the Fillmore I felt pretty good about my prospects.

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The Fillmore Follies

The truth is, I do indulge myself a little the more in pleasure, knowing that this is the proper age of my life to do it; and, out of my observations that most men that do thrive in the world do forget to take pleasure during the time that they are getting their estate, but reserve that till they have got one, and then it is too late for them to enjoy it.

—Samuel Pepys

From its opening in April 1968, the Fillmore East faced something of an uphill battle. Because it was theater seating only, a strict set of fire laws that applied to movie theaters had to be enforced. And Bill Graham had a real fetish about things running smoothly.

In a theater holding upwards of 2,600 rock fans, one single lobby upstairs delimited the area where patrons could smoke. No dope, just cigarettes. The upstairs lobby and bath-

room area, with sometimes as many as 500 smokers seeking relief, became a beat for two "ushers" to patrol. Zeroing the pot smokers in the cigarette haze was the easy part, with peering over the door of toilet stalls for people shooting up, the hard. When you did espy junkies tying off, a harsh bang on the door and a loudly barked "get outa there" served to freak them out sufficiently to ruin their routine.

The no-smoking law within the theater proper meant that the ushers had to pack flashlights to quell urges in their assigned sectors to revelers seeking to imbibe burning substances during the show. Telltale smoke or light from a patron brought an avenging beam of flashlight, embarrassing the offender into submission.

Other fire laws stipulated that the aisles and stairs had to be kept clear of people at all times. The interpretation: The customer rented the space in and in front of his seat for the duration of the show. That's his space, not the aisle or in front of the stage or sitting on the stairs to the balcony. This caused some unpleasantness.

One of the primary assignments of the ushers down front, after seating customers and resolving ticket problems (uprooting malingerers seeking a better location), then became establishing a line of defense to prevent the crowd from rushing the stage, a common occurrence at wilder shows. On several occasions, it did get out of hand, jeopardizing expensive lighting equipment and monitors onstage. At that point, the command would be given to tighten the perimeter and link arms across the front of the stage to protect the equipment.

My first experience with these last-ditch measures proved to be almost my undoing. During a Saturday-night late show with the Chambers Brothers, riding the crest of their hit song

"The Time Has Come Today," all hell broke loose. From my assignment on the top of the left aisle, I saw the right-side aisle begin to fill with revelers. With a righteous youthful zeal I stood at the head of my aisle, spreading my arms to hold back a surging throng from invading the turf I was sworn to defend. This lasted a heroic short while. Three rowdy young Black Power acolytes elbowed their way to face me and allowed as how they were going to lead the mob down to the stage—over my dead body if necessary. In my polite way, ever the peaceful hippie (which probably saved me a severe beating), I explained to them that it was my job to keep the crowd out of the aisle, though the other aisle had long since filled.

They escalated. One began throwing karate punches at my open face, seeing how near he could come without actually hitting me. In my predicament—the British guard in file meeting the savage horde—I didn't flinch. *Show no fear.* My resolve ultimately crumbled though under repeated assault, and I collapsed into an aisle seat. (Later, Ricky V. at work on stage said the hands there had all been aghast that some dimwit was attempting to stem the tide on the aisle. *Who is that fool? Is that Craig?*) Happily, the command soon circulated to ring the stage, and I returned to duty.

The throng surged to the front, constrained only by the linked arms of the beleaguered ushers. From his vantage point on the wings of the stage, Bill Graham roared commands and the stage crew scurried out to pull the monitors back from the brink. The Chambers Brothers finished their last encore to bedlam and began acknowledging the crowd behind my splayed form. Two of the brothers began taking off some of the bling adorning them and extending it towards their adoring fans. I didn't see this because it was happening behind my head. All

I saw were the elbows and armpits of the fans as they lunged over, around, and through me to get at the baubles.

Graham, to his credit, realized what his employees often had to put up with. He was a shrewd booker, so weekends usually featured a sold-out show, while anything he lined up for during the week had to have solid potential for a sellout. During one spring month, Graham booked 28 of 31 days possible, with probably 90 percent of the shows at or near capacity. Over the course of a year, the crews dealt with a lot of people. Many a grueling week was followed by a catered affair, where the staff, scruffy by choice, rubbed elbows with the uptown record-company execs (nearly all male at the time) and their foxes in $500 dresses.

After a sold-out week of Crosby, Stills, Nash, and Young, for instance, a grand spread greeted the crew, the band, and the socialites—the crew and the band leading the way. After many a flagon of heady punch, members of the band and assorted other notables (including doorman Jay Benson, a mean keyboard player) launched into an extended drunken jam onstage. It had our motley crew dancing all over the empty theater, watched by the disinterested, the jaded, the bemused, and the longing. The uptown coterie didn't share in our release from the drudgery we faced nightly, primly observing the bacchanal from on high.

For the net result of strict enforcement of the fire laws, as demanded by Graham to appease the political gods, was that the druggies always sent the chemicals screaming through their bodies *before* they came into the theater, a fair trade for keeping the joint open. With such strict application of the rules, however, came a rather odious reputation. An article in

the *Rolling Stone* dubbed ushers in their emerald-colored Fillmore East football jerseys the "green-shirted goons."

Well, we were sometimes not really crazy about the people we had to deal with, truth be told. We had a small employees' lounge between floors to relax in when on break, aptly dubbed the "Bummer Palace," as it usually filled as well with customers who'd OD'd on some drug or other and needed flight instruction from worldly employees.

One fond remembrance of such a person revolves around our struggles to transport her to the palace. During some raucous rock show or other, this six-foot-two-inch, two-hundred-forty-pound damsel in the throes of drug-addled distress writhed in the aisles down in front of the stage. Grappling with the top end of her tormented mass, a fellow usher on the other end, we hefted her and proceeded to lug her up the aisle then up the stairs as, all the while, she put every ounce of her unnatural strength in attempting to choke me to death.

In contrast to my harrowing experiences in crowd control, my life in art school provided an idyllic counterpoint. School itself proved pleasant enough, and I enjoyed the friendship of my classmates, but in the end it took up too much time. I understood all too well that my attempts at artistry were half-ass at best. I had other things on my mind.

Immersed in the rock'n'roll world, Ricky V., Carlito, and I practiced at being a band, much as did everyone in our generation who could carry a tune in a handbasket. We bought a lot of sheet music (mostly Beatles) and learned a bunch of songs. Fueling our efforts after a time, we were allowed to practice onstage at the Fillmore, with the light-show folks testing out their equipment while we played. As we tried to become more serious, this took up more and more of our waking hours.

At the same time, the grubby little apartment desperately needed something. For a while, we were content to live with dirty white walls in the front room and mattresses on the floor for sleeping accommodations, prototype of the hippie crash pad. We simply kept a felt tip marker handy and let visitors sign in on the wall. Many a word of wisdom adorned that room.

We soon tired of the décor, though. So when not in school or at work or at band practice, I painted the front room. It did so much for our self-esteem that I went ahead and painted the kitchen and the back room too.

Next, in my first encounter with speed, I determined that our bedding arrangements required upgrade as well. After a brief pep talk with the roommates, during which I extolled my own prowess with a hammer and saw (I *had* worked a month one summer as an apprentice carpenter on a high-rise project, after all), I ventured down and bought a half-ton or so of two-by-fours, four-by-fours, plywood, and nails, lugging all on my shoulders a half-mile to our apartment.

One night while the others worked a show, I popped a pill and set down to draw up plans. Soon abandoning that effort as fruitless, I had at it, nailing and sawing, bracing and re-bracing. When the gang returned, there it stood: a monolithic, gothic set of bunk beds in the back room. When my father saw my handiwork, he cracked up. He allowed as how the flood could come through and raze every building in Manhattan, but my bunk beds would still be standing.

With all the time spent on redecorating and work, my studies suffered. I was just not into school. I loved the people. We even had a blow-out party in our beautiful new apart-

ment with a bunch of the students from school. But my schedule proved untenable, and something had to give. I dropped school because it ran dead last on my list of priorities. I didn't even have time to notice this last small line I crossed. I was living the life.

With our jobs at the now-famous rock emporium, we had achieved some sort of major status in the eyes of our small-town Canandaigua brethren, longing as they were for a taste of the big time. Visits from upstaters, usually unannounced, ran on a highly irregular schedule. We averaged probably one visit a month, though some months it seemed like everyone and their cousin plopped in at once. As practitioners of the good-vibes tenor of the times, we felt good about being big, though. It was big of us to take in these travelers, one and all, without as much as a discouraging word. It was quite hip to be big. We had something we never came close to possessing in high school—bigness.

Most of the time visitors were people we wanted to see anyway. They knew when they came that it wasn't the Waldorf Astoria—but we had it. Sleeping bags served for spill-overs, though the girls, of course, had the option of sharing a resident's bed. Ground rules: Resident always slept in resident's own bed.

Occasionally, though, these visits ended rather poorly.

A couple acquaintances, Steve and friend, dropped in for a weekend one time. Quite the drug dealer back upstate, he brought along some mescaline for all to sample. With everyone quite alight, we decided to take the boys out to a fancy restaurant and show 'em the ropes. We chose an elegant, romantic Italian place in the West Village. A rather upscale

establishment, we had to spiff up and slop down with cologne. The restaurant, a very fashionable haunt of the upper middle-class and intelligentsia, best typified the image we wished to portray to our friends from the sticks.

The world-weary patrons ignored these somewhat shabby interlopers, as we were squired in and seated, directly adjacent to a couple obviously celebrating some occasion. He wore a full-dress tux and she a beautiful evening gown. We felt rather vulgar when we ordered a pitcher of beer before supper and tried to keep our conversations to a polite mumble.

Unfortunately, after the first pitcher and well into the second, Steve began to loosen up considerably. He allowed as how he was in such fine fettle because he was tripping, drinking beer, and at the same time not getting sick—a most disquieting thought. Steve said that usually when he tripped, if he drank any beer he got sick and threw up. We nervously checked his eyes to make sure he looked okay.

There was a brief pause in the action as our neighboring celebrants were served an elaborate meal, complete with flames and sizzling platters.

Then Steve continued his soliloquy. He was interrupted a brief moment as he turned to the celebrants and greeted them—with a beautifully arcing geyser of vomit sousing the tux, the dress, and the flaming repast. He then turned back and resumed talking. We beat a hasty retreat from the establishment, needless to say.

> *Success depends on three things: who says it, what he says, how he says it; and of these three things, what he says is the least important.*
>
> —John Viscount Morley

By that time, the Fillmore had established an uneasy peace with the denizens of the Lower East Side, a balance of power given the size and might of the outside bouncers. In the spring of 1968, when the Fillmore first opened up, most of the trouble with the bikers happened. The first few months of 1969, I too had to man the fire exits and help repel Motherfucker attacks, but the Hells Angels soon moved in and made peace.

The Angels' moving in and consolidating the rival gangs generally eased the tension level at the Fillmore. The only problem we ever personally had with them was in the proximity of their lair to our humble abode on Third Street.

Carlito's brother Spud and Sis, classmates in Canandaigua two years younger than we were, had moved to the city and assimilated into the Fillmore as well. They had the unfortunate experience of discovering the Angels' arrival on the scene while making their way west on Third Street one day. On the block just across Second Avenue from ours, they came upon an impressive array of motorcycles—so impressive that Spud stumbled going by on irregular pavement. Because of this indiscretion, he and Sis found themselves immediately surrounded by a towering horde of Angels, quite perturbed that one such runt could have stumbled so close to their steeds.

Allowing as how this commotion had mightily disturbed their afternoon, the Angels seized as reparation Spud's spankin'-new $40 real-leather Jimi Hendrix hat. Never having grown to much over five-foot-five-inches tall, Spud politely inquired how he might get his hat back. The proffered alternatives—fisticuffs or an outright trade for the woman—offered little hope.

To make it all legal, the shaggy behemoth claiming his

hat gave Spud two joints (skillfully rolled papers resembling joints, anyway) and sent them on their way, unhappy but unmaimed.

Bill Graham once described this atmosphere quite appropriately: "New York is gutter warfare. Industrial psychology. There's no salt and pepper for me. . . ."

Evidence of this abounded. And Bill Graham never backed down. One night in 1968 (the wild and woolly days), as the crowd filed out of a show, a nonaligned biker type looped a bike chain over the heads of several customers to crack Graham on the nose, bloodying it. Graham wheeled and roared into action, beating the shit out of him. Bill was no pussy.

But as 1969 wore on into May, things began to settle down a bit. The inside and outside crews had all worked together for a while, and the shows ran smoothly. And the people Graham had running the East Coast operation all proved first class.

Kip Cohen, Graham's top dog then, had a knack for deportment in crisis situations. Heavily into meditation, he had a way of smoothing out even the biggest problems. Before each show, he'd emerge from his darkened office reflecting a meditative halo of calm, ready to face the show. (He later went on to work for A&M Records.)

J.P., house manager at the time, excelled at keeping the show rolling. If there was a problem the ushers or even head ushers couldn't handle, he'd take over. Rumor had it he had been a hit man for the Mafia, and nothing in his comportment belied that. The guy always had a beautiful woman on his arm. If there ever was anybody that just *had* to get in a fight with somebody from the Fillmore, he might eventually run into J.P.—and wind up out cold. I quickly did my best to suck up to J.P. at the Fillmore.

With such a blend of finesse and know-how radiating down to the staff, the shows began to take on a professionalism heretofore unknown in the jungle of the East Village. Many of us on the inside crew, hippies looking to forge some new way of life through yoga or meditation, aspired to the cool and calm radiating from Kip. These pseudo-biblical aspirations—to be "gentle as a dove but wise as a serpent"—were sorely tested in those occasions when emotions raged nearly out of control.

On one night, May 16 of that year, The Who played to a sold-out Friday-night show before a rabid crowd of druggies and drunks. By midway through a fanatical set, the crowd, up to the top of the second balcony, pranced on their seats dancing and swaying. Now, standing on your chair was a no-no at the Fillmore, but events had spiraled out of control. Heading out to the final flourish, the band launched into a full-throttle, kick-ass version of "Summertime Blues," sending the crowd into paroxysms of boogie mania.

About that time, the ushers (we were the few that retained sense) began commenting to each other that they smelled smoke. And lo, soon thereafter wisps of smoke began drifting into the theater and forming a fog bank in the dome—which gave us considerable cause for alarm. Finally the order came to begin evacuating the customers. It seems that street people had liberated the store sharing the building with the Fillmore, contending that the store was over-charging, and torched it.

So how to carry out this mass evacuation? Obviously, it wouldn't be cool to start yelling "Fire!" in a crowded theater. But every person I approached to talk to, yell at, or attempt to cajole off a chair fought me off—they were too far gone into "Summertime Blues" oblivion.

There I fretted for a moment, agonizing over having to get into fights with people to save their lives. Just then, not halfway through the big song, some guy came bounding down the aisle and jumped onto the stage, grabbing the microphone away from Roger Daltry.

Now, The Who often in their long and illustrious careers had to deal with rowdies . . . and reacted accordingly. Daltry seized the interloper from behind, and Pete Townshend kicked him in the balls, sending him careening off the stage. Having disposed of the problem, they ended the song—only to find that the interloper was a plainclothes cop. After cops swarmed the stage, evacuation proceeded smoothly, but Townshend spent the night in the can. (*I* never saw the ID that the cop said he flashed when he jumped onstage.)

In the two years I worked at the Fillmore, I saw The Who probably twenty-five times and never tired of them. Something crazy always happened with the early bad boys of rock. Keith Moon, the drummer, was famous for trashing his drums during the encore—he was crazier than a shithouse rat. At a party before one set of shows, Moon got drunk and on a dare ate a Styrofoam cooler.

One night, following a rousing performance, Townshend threw his guitar, a $350 instrument, into the audience to end the show. So the next night, Spud and Ricky V. crouched at the front of each aisle with giant butterfly nets concealed before them. The grand crescendo came, and the boys gripped their nets in anticipation of snaring a thrown guitar, but Townshend smashed his guitar in a million pieces and threw the shards into the audience.

Another band popular enough with the staff to be almost

considered the house band at one point was the old Savoy Brown, with Lonesome Dave, Kim Simmonds, and gang. They had a particular affinity with the guy who swept up the backstage area and helped on set changes, a hulking bear named John Ford Noonan. His ratty old blue-jean coveralls, full beard, and pirate scarf made him look like a Kodiak gypsy. Whenever Savoy Brown played, John came alive.

As the band cranked up their boogie, John would edge out onstage, beckoned by Lonesome Dave, and do the "noonan" with the lead man. The noonan, as best as can be described, is something like a cross between a Mau-Mau rain dance and the stoned-chicken grind. The real action, though, transpired backstage between shows. Noonan would lay in wait for some uptight, uptown groupie to slink backstage after the band. As one such approached backstage center, he slouched up and seized the damsel frontally and, lifting her off the floor, humped her unmercifully. A real blow to the ego—and the source of much hilarity for the crew in the days long before the "Me Too" movement.

While working at the Fillmore, Noonan actually wrote a play that won the Eugene O'Neill Award (*The Year Boston Won the Pennant*). But he was better as the gypsy pervert entertaining the backstage gang.

Bands like Savoy Brown tended to be weekend headliners. Graham shrewdly booked those acts that played to packed houses—two shows each night on Friday and Saturday. He was slightly more conservative for weeknight shows. If the band didn't have the drawing power for the given day, he wouldn't book it. Good poker players play their winners and dump their losers.

The difference between the character of one sold-out show and that of another in the next week depended on the nature of the headlining acts. Thus, if he booked Jefferson Airplane you could count on a boisterous, hard-to-handle crowd, with some real *upagainstthewallmotherfucking* radicals tossed in—never a fun bunch to deal with.

Frank Zappa crowds, on the other hand, tended to be half crazy, and you could never be sure if they were serious or joking. During a break between songs in one memorable Zappa set, someone in the crowd yelled out, "Fuck you, Frank,"

To which Zappa calmly replied: "Oh yeah? Fuck me, hunh? Okay, how about ten minutes of dead air?"

With that, Zappa and the band lit up cigarettes and leaned on amps for exactly ten minutes, casually checking their watches occasionally. Nobody else offered any such comments during what remained of the show.

Occasionally things went bad when all seemed right with the world. Sly Stone and the Family Band played several times during their heyday, and they were fairly well liked by the staff. But on one particular night, Sly got carried away on hit song "Higher." At the end of the early show, the crowd was gettin' down, so Sly paraded the entire lot of them out the side fire exits in a pulsating conga line, then back in—along with a thousand miscellaneous speed freaks, winos, and street people. It took the crew the better part of an hour and a half to clear the place out for the second show, a task that usually took twenty minutes, including cleanup. Graham swore to the crew that he'd never book Sly Stone again. And he didn't.

Some of the most annoying crowds came to see the heavy-rock groups. All the punks from Queens in plastic jackets, tight pants, and mod haircuts would grace the Fillmore with their

smart mouths and serious 'tude. We gritted our teeth for these shows and stuffed cotton in our ears when ear-splitting metal bands like Mountain and Grand Funk Railroad played. Even working in the second balcony, high above the action, you'd leave with a headache at the end of the night.

But probably the hardest crowd to handle showed up for Grateful Dead concerts. They were pretty generally tripping out of their gourds, and it can be hard to convince anyone so wasted to remain in one place, one seat. A tripping crowd is set adrift from any normal mental processes, seeking only to go with the psychedelic flow. Attempts at reasoning fall on deaf ears.

During Dead shows, crew members had to have their wits about them to maintain a modicum of control in the mayhem while trying to enforce the rigid fire laws. Therefore you didn't drink out of any sodas you didn't yourself open. Acid-laced drinks circulated widely during Dead concerts. Then the people spluttered so far out of control at times that you'd welcome the presence of reinforcements from the outside security gorillas. If you couldn't reason with a blasted reveler, hippie to hippie—*brother, these are the rules the man makes us live by*—imploring him to, say, move from the forbidden zone, you just gestured for the big guy, who would the impel the interloper back to his assigned seat.

Tripping people are much more responsive to gorillas. A gorilla's logic is inescapable. If they won't listen to long-winded explanations and polite entreaties, they'll sure step to for brute force.

I heard the Dead probably twenty-five times as well and never liked them, always too wound up dealing with the crowd to actually stop and listen. All the little fire laws we

were charged with enforcing seemed flat-out petty to zoned-out Dead crowds. Well, they *were* pretty petty, truth be told. But they were the rules that the Fillmore had to abide by in order to stay open. And it's not like you could just say to Bill Graham, "I don't really want to do that."

The Dead were so notorious for late-running shows that Graham booked them one time for a week, beginning each night at midnight ("The Dead at Midnight"). We'd stagger out after the shows each night to blinding sunlight of a new day, the city bustling off to the morning's work. It took several weeks to get back to a normal sleep schedule.

Sis, always a Dead fan, delighted in those shows. When she and Spud moved to the city, they quickly joined the staff, as the joint welcomed these "nice" people from Upstate into the fold. Sis scored a somewhat safer job working in one of the concession stands. The Fillmore sported stands upstairs and down, serving pastries, yogurt, juices, and the like. No alcohol. That was for the best, though; crowds proved hard enough to handle drugged up.

Because of its theater status, the Fillmore couldn't sell booze anyway, but discerning drunks on the staff could usually sniff it out. Graham provided coolers of beer for the bands (those that partook) and the backstage crew, as well as satisfying any extra requests ("riders") from the stars. Janis Joplin's dressing room was always well stocked with Southern Comfort, for example.

It was so well stocked on one occasion (enough also for the soiree afterwards), it overflowed on Ricky V., who sipped copious amounts at his command post on the backstage entrance. We later learned the extent of his tippling when Janis

came back to the office between shows and asked, "Who's that cute little drunk running around backstage?"

Ricky V. was relieved of his duties for the evening and, shortly thereafter, carried bodily back to the apartment after passing out. And he missed the big party. The parties were a good way to let off steam, both for the staff and bands. The chic and the hangers-on served as jaded witness.

Early on at the Fillmore, Jim Morrison of the Doors got plastered during sound check before the show and had crew members hoist him up on a light boom, dangling by his knees high above the stage. All feared for his safety and his blossoming career, not the least of whom was bandmate Ray Manzarek, who troubled about, muttering, "There goes the act."

Not all of the rock stars proved so problematic, of course, and their fans behaved in a much more civilized manner. Some of the easier crowds to manage came to see groups such as Procol Harum, the Byrds, Traffic, and The Band. Class acts drew a classier crowd. The Band concert, single shows all week, came during the climax of a busy spring. Coming off the release of their debut album, *Music From Big Pink,* The Band was heralded as the group backing up Bob Dylan. By that time, the staff worked as a smooth-running unit and spirits ran high. During this short-lived era of good feeling, the crew felt like it inhabited an island of sanity in the midst of all the chaos erupting in the outside world.

Once again, the bonhomie of the times saved Ricky V.'s neck from the chopping block. For The Band shows, all the uptown bigwigs showed up. Albert Grossman, who handled stars like Dylan, Joan Baez, and The Band, happened to be hanging out backstage watching the set. Ricky V. approached

Grossman as he strayed into his sector and asked him if he had the obligatory pass for his backstage area.

"Why, no. I'm Albert Grossman," he replied.

"I don't care who you are, pops. If you ain't got a pass, you gotta go."

Ricky V. had a penchant for stumbling into trouble. Sometimes it seemed like he only opened his mouth to change feet. He had a similar run-in with Abbie Hoffman, darling of the revolutionary set, when he tried to slide in backstage without a pass. Hoffman, never the master of politesse, responded to Ricky V.'s rebuffs with pointed remarks about finding someone with some authority, and ventured that Ricky V. "should clear up your acne, kid."

At which point Ricky V. allowed as how he wouldn't let Hoffman backstage even if he came back with God himself. But, as Ricky V. recounted later, Hoffman returned with an even higher authority: Graham.

But Ricky V. did get the last laugh. He was working onstage during the Woodstock performance of The Who, when a formation of planes flew overhead to drop supplies. Hoffman rushed the stage and grabbed the microphone, purportedly intent on telling the crowd that the planes were sent to bomb the hippies. He ostensibly had some notion about mobilizing the half-million people into an army.

Pete Townshend may or may not have recognized him, but it's doubtful if it mattered. He swung his guitar in a mighty arc and conged Hoffman over the head, sending him flying off the stage into the audience.

Alas, regardless of their doom,
The little victims play!

No sense have they of ills to come,
Nor care beyond today:
Yet see how all around 'em wait
The Ministers of human fate
And black Misfortune's baleful train!
Ah, show them where in ambush stand
To seize their prey, the murderous band!
Ah tell them, they are men!

To each his suff'rings: all are men,
Condemned alike to groan;
The tender for another's pain,
The unfeeling for his own.
Yet, ah! why should they know their fate,
Since sorrow never comes too late,
And happiness too swiftly flies?
Thought would destroy their paradise.
No more; where ignorance is bliss
Tis folly to be wise.

—Thomas Gray

Guff: How *Not* to Not Take Any

The West Fourth Street station of the Eighth Avenue subway lets you out on Third Street in the West Village, home of the old Night Owl Café. By that time, however, it had been made over into a poster shop, with the run-of-the-mill black lights and day-glo posters.

Ricky V. and I hurried from the subway east on Third Street, bound to the East Side to the offices of the *East Village Other,* where we had contracted to paint their walls, top dollar.

As we made our way to the intersection, the noon pedestrian traffic clogged the streets, and our being late for our contractual obligations had in no way added to the humor of the situation. As we buzzed along, just across the street from the Night Owl, a five-foot five-inch nondescript (no sleazier than the norm) black dealin' man accosted Ricky V., grabbing his arm and saying, "You wanna buy some grass, man?"

In his familiar, genial manner heightened by our tardiness, Ricky V. jerked his arm away and replied, "No, I don't want any of your fucking grass."

Continuing through the crowd and crossing McDougall Street, we noticed that our insistent entrepreneur had then taken up following us, to what end aroused our curiosity. Turning to meet him on the corner, Ricky V. was greeted by your basic I'm-gonna-kick-yer-ass shove.

With my typical upstate charm, bolstered by my aborted stint on the Canandaigua wrestling team, I stepped in between the two: "Hey, don't do that."

The quick smooth flash of fist to jaw told me that our man wasn't buying true grit this year. Six feet, one inch and a hundred ninety-five pounds of me, momentarily stunned with this dastardly attack by such an obvious lightweight, recoiled swiftly with all the agility acquired in months on the Syracuse basketball courts. Seizing the little rat bastard, I grabbed him and prepared to wrestle him into submission. *Sooner or later the boys in blue down the street or some of the crowd will break it up after I've worked him over a bit.*

Alas and alack, the immediate sounding thunder of cavalry hooves on the pavement proved to be yet more Indians, ye verily the tribe of my intended pummelee.

"Well, hell," I seem to remember thinking as a war club of some devise knocked the swagger and most of the sense out of me, dropping me to my knees. "This ain't fair."

I vaguely remember looking up through the haze of semi-consciousness as Ricky V., the offender, was smacked from brother to brother—John Wayne, barroom-brawl style—with the final roundhouse delivered by our entrepreneur turned avenging warrior, sending Ricky V. in a slow-motion pirouette off the ground and flat on his face in the middle of the street.

Busy as it had been elbowing our way through the crowds seconds earlier, the din of battle had produced deserted streets momentarily, as if the noon rush paused to take shelter from a sudden downpour. With the final KO, however, business as usual resumed, with our five ravagers slipping into the concrete.

Unsteadily picking myself up and wending my way through a fog, I helped Ricky V. up from in front of a line of honking cars, and stopping our wounds, we headed unceremoniously east. Ten times on the way home, I had to tell Ricky V. what had just happened to us. To this day, he still can't quite remember what went down.

Laugh and the world laughs with you,
Weep, and you weep alone;
For the sad old earth must borrow its mirth,
But has trouble enough of its own.
—Ella Wheeler Wilcox

Summer in the city is a bitch. My father used to joke that the first thing city kids learn to do is open fire hydrants

for a quick shower, and the first thing cops learn is how to shut them down. Sooty sweat is bad enough, but the concrete holds the sun's heat to make sure you're uncomfortable all night, as well. During summer nights, half of the city sits on the roof or the fire escape. In the packed confines of the Fillmore, changing into t-shirts and shorts gave little relief to the crew. The ancient air-conditioning system could barely manage a whisper of relief—not enough to stir the cigarette haze that hung over the second-floor lobby.

So Graham worked a deal with the management of Tanglewood, an eighty-eight-acre classical-music venue in far-western Massachusetts and summer home of the Boston Symphony Orchestra. Though the site served primarily to present open-air symphony concerts, the owners agreed to let Graham book a few rock shows. To ensure a turnout, Graham would line up two or three name acts together—the first such featured The Who, Jefferson Airplane, and B. B. King.

The "Fillmore's Finest Forty," as billed in the programs, provided security: keeping interlopers and freebooters out and order within. A nine-foot-tall chain-link fence bounded the entire area, not much deterrent to the determined gate-crasher and a whole lot of fence to guard with forty people.

For the first of the rock extravaganzas, we spent hours in a meeting setting up a tight walkie-talkie communications system to link vital sectors on the fence with internal pavilion security. Naturally, once it was underway, that fell to shit and you were on your own out on the perimeter. This first show took place before Woodstock ushered in a proliferation of outdoor rock concerts, and we didn't think there'd be any more than a few thousand people to contend with—about

the average Fillmore crowd. But on that occasion, twenty-five thousand fans showed up, the most ever seen at Tanglewood.

For that premier engagement, Graham leased a bus to drive the staff out to the country, complete with a beer keg and innumerable joints (a good time was had by all). He arranged for us to stay in dormitory rooms of a nearby college that had emptied for the summer. But, having been cooped up in the city for so long, some of us figured it'd be real *neat* if we slept out under the stars. The thrill of the great outdoors had long since been replaced by the chill of the country air when I was awakened from a fitful sleep at five in the morning by the chattering of Spud's teeth. Before I could drift back off, the soothsome sounds of a police bullhorn shattered the quiet, ordering us off the hill we occupied. We were trespassing. Next time out, we went with the dormitory rooms. For the first show, we received a box lunch consisting of a cold piece of chicken and assorted sides, greeted with a chorus of grousing and griping to Graham. Next time out, after the success of the first, he provided a catered buffet complete with steaming chafing dishes and the works.

For that first outing, I worked the outside fence in one front corner. Several dilapidated storage sheds squatted in the corner, adjacent to a gate that served as an employee vehicle entrance. In my solitude, even my official walkie-talkie with the hours-before-the-concert gab and tomfoolery crackling the airways couldn't ease my mind. I fretted about having to defend by myself this pivotal point in such an expanse of wilderness.

Working fast, I established a command post on top of the largest shed, right on the corner, carrying up a pile of rather

menacing chunking rocks for long-range firepower. I had no intention of actually throwing them at anybody, but I dreaded the thought of being at the mercy of miscreants on the outside not so inclined. Scouring the other buildings, I came upon a formidable array of combat weapons: an axe handle, some stout staffs, and a good-sized lead pipe that hefted like some monster Viking club.

Setting up my new-found arsenal at various points along my sector, isolated as it was from any other security person, I selected the pipe for companionship. Definitely a two-hander and rather cumbersome, it nevertheless lent me just the right sinister touch. Anybody venturing into my domain to sneak in would think twice when they saw this crazy-looking bastard with the pipe. We hadn't ventured so far from the city that the people didn't have *some* street sense. Making myself comfortable with a book, perched at the pinnacle of my command-post building, I warily passed the hours before the onslaught.

My attentiveness was soon rewarded. Five guys suddenly burst from the cover some fifteen yards outside the fence, heading towards command central. I roared down the roof with a fearsome growl to where they had gained a hold on top of the fence and smote the fence top a mighty blow with my war pipe.

Hands abuzz, they dropped like Evil Knievel jumping a canyon, amid questioning of my ancestry and general hubbub. They soon responded to my snarling and warlike posturing by trailing off morosely to bless someone else's sector.

The afternoon dragged on in endless display of muscle and pipe up and down my length of fence, dramatically calling into the walkie-talkie (to dead white air) for reinforcements when overrun—winning a few, losing a few more. The

trick lay in intimidating intruders before they made it over the fence. No sane person would tempt fate or a lead pipe (without any assurance that I wouldn't really crown them). Once they made it over the fence in force, it was walkie-talkie time.

"Hey, you guys. Get outa here."

"Yeah, sure, asshole."

We breathed a sigh of relief as light faded and the picket lines were pulled inside to the pavilion for the final blow-out. The Fearless Forty sat in aisles to forestall any attempts to rush the stage, cudgels left behind at the perimeter.

At these Tanglewood shows, incidentally, Graham became one of the first to utilize videotape equipment at rock concerts. Cameras up front filmed the action and it was projected on a giant screen so the people sitting in back could see up close what was happening onstage.

~7~

Losing My Religion

Because an all-powerful police tried to force us to hold our tongues, every word took on the value of a declaration of principles. Because we were hunted down, every one of our gestures had the weight of a solemn commitment.

—Jean Paul Sartre

When they're out to get you, paranoia is good thinking.

—Johnny Fever, "WKRP in Cincinnati"

The Chicago police riots at the Democratic National Convention brought to the fore of public conscious the violence that had festered during the Sixties civil-rights movement. The brutalizing of blacks with fire hoses and police dogs, the murders, somehow had remained only in the subconscious of a somnolent public, unfazed by the militarization of local constabulary until confronted by billy-club justice live and in

color on network news. But only in later years, following insistent reportorial probing using the Freedom of Information Act, did it become apparent the depths old perv J. Edgar Hoover would sink to in his quest to maintain control, expanding his beloved FBI Cointelpro program from its original mission in the Fifties of commie hunting to include protesters—first black then white. (After the public humiliation of Joe McCarthy and his schizoid obsessions, Hoover's fixation on commies led one Justice Department prosecutor to say that Hoover may have kept alive the witch hunt because his "informants were nearly the only ones that paid the party dues.")

In an October 1956 memo, Hoover targeted black leaders, claiming the movement was infiltrated by communists, subsequently tacking on protesters of most any ilk under the rubric "national security." In the Sixties, when an FBI special agent wrote that the Black Panther Party in San Francisco seemed to mainly be engaged in feeding breakfast to children, Hoover blasted him, implying that the agent's future in the organization relied upon finding proof that the Panthers were a "violence-prone organization seeking to overthrow the Government by revolutionary means." Evidence be damned, Hoover embraced extra-legal methods to attack his perceived menace, writing, "The purpose of counterintelligence action is to disrupt the BPP and it is immaterial whether facts exist to substantiate the charge."

Subsequent investigations, most notably by the Church Committee in 1976, revealed increased collaboration between the FBI, Central Intelligence Agency, National Security Agency, and the Department of Defense. The CIA launched its own domestic espionage project in 1967 called Operation CHAOS.

The head of CHAOS, James Angleton, was fired as counterintelligence chief in December 1974 after it was revealed he had presided over a massive program to spy on opponents of the Vietnam War. Resistance to the war had blossomed, challenging the mighty machine that sought to reinforce the politics of status quo.

By 1967, a draft system calling up as many as forty thousand men for induction each month had heightened tensions. The draft and its college deferment favored white, middle-class men, relying on the poor and minorities to stock its larders. Although blacks only represented 29 percent of the draft-eligible pool to 63 percent of whites, 64 percent of blacks were drafted, 31 percent of whites.

The 1967 Gallup poll showing a majority believing Vietnam to be a mistake had grown to 58 percent in October 1969. By May 1971, only 28 percent supported the war—at which point Gallup stopped asking the question. Not surprisingly, college enrollment reached nine million by the end of the Sixties. Colleges and universities in America had more students than ever before—many only to avoid ending up as kabobs on Viet Cong sharpened-bamboo punji stakes—and these institutions sought to control increasingly rowdy campuses.

An incident in 1968 at the predominantly black campus of South Carolina State University presaged the campus violence to come. A protest over a segregated bowling alley in Orangeburg led to the arrests of several students, followed by more vociferous demonstrations—at which point police began beating protesters, men and women, with billy clubs, sending eight to the hospital. As tensions escalated over the next few days, some two hundred students gathered to protest and

the governor called out the national guard, saying that black-power advocates were running amok on campus, ascribing the boogieman of the day with a descent into chaos.

On the night of February 8, 1968, students there started a bonfire on campus, and a thrown object injured one officer trying to put out the fire. Eight South Carolina Highway Patrol officers opened fire into the crowd with carbines, shotguns, and revolvers, lasting only ten to fifteen seconds. Twenty-seven people were injured in the shooting, most shot in the back while running away, and three blacks killed—one a local high school student sitting on the steps of the freshman dormitory waiting the end of his mother's work shift. This didn't rate as much as a nod in the media, in the pre-dawn light of the civil-rights era, as this was just one more case of dying while black.

Only when white students began falling did a blip register on the national radar. The stage had been set earlier at Berkeley in California, presided over by the rigid law-and-order mindset of Governor Ronald Reagan, who derided campus administrators for allowing protests and called Berkeley "a haven for communist sympathizers, protesters, and sex deviants." Chafing that students had claimed a trashed-out plot of university land and cleaned it up as their "People's Park," Reagan sent the Berkeley Police and Highway Patrol officers in to fence it off. A subsequent protest quickly festered into confrontation, bolstered when Reagan's chief of staff, Edwin Meese, sent Alameda County sheriff's deputies in to beef up forces in the park.

Meese, a rock-ribbed control freak, unleashed cops against protesters, instructing them to use whatever methods they chose against the crowd. Officers in riot gear with

badges obscured to hide their identities began flailing away with nightsticks. As protesters retreated, the law followed, firing tear gas and buckshot at the crowd's backs—opening up on all present. One bystander sitting on a nearby roof died from gunshot wounds to the chest, and another, a carpenter, suffered a shotgun blast to the face, leaving him permanently blinded.

Reagan declared a state of emergency and sent in twenty-seven-hundred National Guard to patrol the city (against the wishes of the Berkeley City Council, who voted 8–1 against the measure). Nationally, upright politicos took note: A bill surfaced in the U.S. House of Representatives that would cut off Federal aid to universities that failed to head off campus disorders. Nearly a year later, Reagan, in an address before the California Council of Growers, defended his decision to use the California National Guard to quell Berkeley protests: "If it takes a bloodbath, let's get it over with. No more appeasement."

Such was the rigid imperative of the establishment, yet the tumult in factious Berkeley only received passing notice in the media—until four days later and the violence spread to Middle America. Nationwide protests had erupted following Nixon's April 1970 incursion into Cambodia (after promising to end the war during the 1968 election). At Kent State University in Ohio, though, only a fraction of the school's nineteen thousand students took part. Antiwar rallies attracted no more than three hundred people at best, and even the appearance of Jerry Rubin of the Chicago Seven drew only about a thousand. Rubin, a practitioner of the escalating rhetoric that goaded the powers that be, intoned: "The first part of the Yippie program

is to kill your parents. They are the first oppressors." Not a great PR move, though not really serious either.

It certainly succeeded in yanking the chain of Ohio Governor Jim Rhodes, who called out the National Guard for the latest protest, saying:

> *We've seen here at the city of Kent especially, probably the most vicious form of campus-oriented violence yet perpetrated by dissident groups. They make definite plans of burning, destroying, and throwing rocks at police and at the National Guard and the Highway Patrol. This is when we're going to use every part of the law enforcement agency of Ohio to drive them out of Kent. We are going to eradicate the problem . . . They are not going to take over [the] campus. I think that we're up against the strongest, well-trained, militant, revolutionary group that has ever assembled in America.*

The governor had made campus disorder a key issue in a campaign for the U.S. Senate, and after calling up the guard, he showed up in the city of Kent, pledging: "We are going to eradicate the problem. . . . It's over within Ohio."

Without consulting guard officers or the university administration, he ordered that all campus assemblies should be broken up. On the afternoon of May 4, 1970, National Guard troops fired on a group of protesters, killing four and wounding nine. Two of the dead were students walking to class, one a member of the Kent State ROTC.

Nationwide shock at the killings led to a new wave of campus protest. Four days later, eleven students at the University of New Mexico were bayoneted in a confrontation with

the guard. In New York City, two hundred construction workers, mobilized by virulently anti-communist union bosses, attacked a protest of a thousand protesting college and high-school students, reportedly beating those with the longest hair with hard hats, clubs, and steel-toed boots while a token showing of police stood by and didn't interfere. And on May 15, forty Mississippi State Highway Patrolmen opened fire with shotguns at predominately black Jackson State College, killing a college student and a high-school student (standing *behind* police lines) and wounding twelve others. Once again, the death of black students garnered little notice.

The Kent State shootings, though, led to a nationwide student strike, closing more than four hundred campuses across the country, and a hundred thousand demonstrated in Washington, D.C., against the war and the killing of unarmed student protesters. As a precaution, Nixon was taken to Camp David for two days for his own protection, and the military was called up to secure the city.

Amid the bedlam of a nation threatened by the specter of insurrection, the Fillmore did seem an island of sanity. After Kent State, Graham decked the theater's marquee in black bunting and posted a memoriam to the students killed. It expressed well the angst we in the Fillmore family felt over the rapidly deteriorating social roil. The general anxiety gripping the nation did wear on us, and in the spring of 1969 I found myself descending into malaise, casting about for a new me. The influence of people like Fillmore GM Kip Cohen certainly helped. In life, it seems we're always guided to a better (or at least different) way by those who have gone before us, an older person perhaps who can provide some new insight, a new path. In a way, the soundtrack of the Sixties, led by the

Beatles and a whole slew of new bands, served that purpose, as the musicians seemed a step ahead of the young, showing the way. Right after Kent State, Crosby, Stills, Nash & Young rushed out the tune "Four Dead in Ohio," the obligatory lament of current events expressing the shock and rage of the generation.

Sinking in melancholy while busying myself being there and *doing* things, I suffered too from having no outlet to channel my physical energies and maintain a sense of physical well-being I'd achieved for a time on the basketball courts at Syracuse. Here I was in the middle of all that happened, working at the *Village Voice* and the Fillmore, one of the hotspots of the Sixties, and I grew increasingly bummed out by my lot in life.

This sort of disquiet, I maintain, represents one of the greatest forces for the changes we go through growing up: Life isn't always a primrose path we gaily traipse down towards our preordained goal (like my youthful aspiration to be president one day). Rather, we stumble along the path of our existence until a building internal strife brings you to an angry epiphany: *Man, I can't fucking stand this. I gotta do something different.*

That revelation came to me through the busy spring of 1969. Constantly on the move, I lived the hippie dream, yet a growing inner discontent nagged at me. I had decided that the only thing a person is guaranteed of attaining if so inclined is happiness, that notion intoned by the Donovan Leitch tune "Happiness Runs in a Circular Motion." You put out a happy vibe and it's returned to you. That of course presupposes personal happiness. I felt that I surely could attain happiness (a feeling sorely tested in a lifetime of trying) and worked to that

end. At the Fillmore, interacting with thousands of people, some ripped out of their minds on their drug of choice, that did seem to serve me well (and probably kept me healthy). But I still had to face what I was—and wasn't.

For one, I had to confront that I wasn't cut out to be a lead singer in a band. My self-consciousness, overriding shyness, and lack of social confidence made for a painful experience standing out front and trying to put on a show. No Mick Jagger or Roger Daltry, I felt like the fifth wheel in a four-man band. I just didn't have it in me. While Ricky V. and Carlito and a drummer friend made earnest attempts at rock-guitar stardom, I struggled to forget myself in performance and play the lead man, the showman and "star." I just didn't have it in me. I couldn't get out of my head. And I alone knew how totally worthless I really was as a human. My salvation *du jour* came from friends drawn in by the gravity of the Fillmore orbit.

Several already-accomplished musicians had begun hanging out with us, oftentimes gathering in the front room of our humble abode for impromptu jam sessions. Guitarists Andy and Tony and bass player Stephen joined with us and filled the room with professional sounds, resplendent with four-part harmony. In that setting, I didn't have to worry about getting out of my own way, but rather lost myself in the music created by the whole. I wish I could have packaged that. Following one session and aglow with that extra-spatial feeling singers, for one, can reach, I remarked to Stephen that I wished that could have been in a studio recording. "That's where it's at," he told me.

Stephen had already gone there, doing studio work on several records, and what's more had jammed with the likes

of Eric Clapton and Jimi Hendrix. He had that cred. He came into our group as a friend of Bro—who had since left to check out the scene in San Francisco—and in response to my disquietude suggested yoga, lending me his book of exercises. Thus began my transformation, steered into an exploration of Eastern philosophy and the Wisdom of the Ages.

I had tried unsuccessfully to find something in a religion class at Syracuse that might address the spiritual inklings that teased at my consciousness. But I found instead the husk of religion beaten to death in a mountain of pompous posturing. Yoga and its attendant philosophies promised a path towards a spiritualism, a way of moderating the internal clamor—that inner voice creating such restlessness and dissatisfaction over what I had yet to become. *Making peace with myself.* I jumped in with both feet.

> *Life isn't about finding yourself. Life is about creating yourself.*
>
> —George Bernard Shaw

> *The first and best victory is to conquer self.*
>
> —Plato

What I saw on a daily basis in the bowels of the city, the depths of depravity we experienced every day when we stepped out of our hovel into the Bowery, had opened me up to an alternate way of thinking, of searching for some good in all the bad. For a time, maybe, that meant getting out of my head onto some medicinally induced plane, tempting fate as it were. At times, that led to the strangest of circumstance.

On one such occasion, Ricky V., Carlito, and I planned a

happy jaunt into psychedelia, and each dropped a tab of what was purported to be mild acid. Carlito had to finish up in the box office, so Ricky V. and I caught the subway up to Dad's apartment to visit. We had a nice chat there but shortly began to notice the designs on a rug in the apartment begin to crawl around, so we quickly begged off and made our way back to the subway station—consumed in gales of laughter (as often happens when lifting off on LSD). We struggled to maintain a straight face to the world in the subway station, but as Ricky V. remembers:

> *While waiting for the train, we noticed brand-new posters for 2001 [the 1968 movie* 2001: A Space Odyssey*]. Holy CRAP! IT'S THREE-DIMENSIONAL! When it dawned on us that it was a two-dimensional poster, we looked at each other and burst out laughing again. We did calm down enough to get on our southbound train, although we had to sit apart from each other to prevent another outburst. You sat in the middle of the front car and I stood at the front, watching the oncoming tracks. We came to a station, stopped, the doors opened and a police officer got on. The train waited for what seemed like a week, the doors still open. The policeman stood rocking up and down on the balls of his feet like Barney Fife. I felt like I should turn around and did so, noticing you sitting with your face in your hands hiding your mouth. I knew you were laughing because the veins in your forehead looked like a road map of the Smoky Mountains. I nodded politely to the officer. This guy looked like Ichabod Crane, thin with protruding chin and Adam's apple. The officer turned and stuck his head out*

the doors and just then they closed, trapping his head. When he pulled it out, his hat popped off and fell on the platform as we pulled away. I was looking right at him. He turned and looked at me right in the eye. I began unraveling and had to turn back to face the front. Laugh? Uncontrollably. I could see your reflection, tears streaming down your hands, your forehead now looking more like the Rockies.

The strangest things happen to you when you're tripping. We managed to make it back to the Fillmore and help Carlito close up. A couple cops stopped by to escort Carlito to the bank, but he just told them there weren't any deposits that night. We couldn't face a ride with the police in our condition. Rather, we stuffed the day's receipts—some thousands of dollars—into a bag and cavorted merrily the mile or so to the bank, skipping and singing without a care to make the deposit. A guardian angel surely watched over us that night.

Such antics played out in the off days between shows, as the job required full use of all mental faculties to cope in the maelstrom of drugged-up music fans. I wouldn't partake of as much as a joint when working. Only in days away from the Fillmore could you get high, though one heavy psychedelic experience turned me off to the "thrills" of LSD.

Sis, Spud, and I had dropped a tab one evening, thinking of getting high then maybe checking out the nightlife. But the rapid onset of supremely strong acid quickly left us lying on the kitchen floor of the apartment, immobile. We became totally incorporeal—three souls bobbing in a field of energy. I perceived a great light and began moving toward it, at which point Sis stopped me, telling me not to go there. We somehow

recovered sensibility a while later, but I never again tried acid. Was that a near-death experience or just a mind-blown drug ride? No idea, but the closest I'd want to come to finding out.

I entered a seriously contemplative phase of life then, spending the better part of the next couple years on a macrobiotic diet, eating mainly vegetarian with some fish thrown in (quite the challenge, given my childhood experience in seafood had been limited to fish sticks and Howard Johnson's fried clams, all slathered in tartar sauce). Like other hippies, my readings ranged far and wide, encompassing the writings of Kahlil Gibran (author of *The Prophet*), Buddhists, and Hindi philosophers but never straying far from a search for some kind of spiritual meaning. Enlightened Dad, long into the esoteric, encouraged my quest, loaning me his books on Sufism, one of the main tenets of which struck a deep chord: If you say you are a Sufi, then you're not—i.e., if you say you're spiritual or religious, you're not. Or more prosaically, the proof is in the pudding. I remember telling Dad that I felt I could be anything I wanted to be, but I just didn't know what that was. "You've still got time," he advised.

In innumerable ways, what we sought didn't venture far afield from Christian precepts, and many of the generation gravitated ultimately towards established religion. One bit of Eastern philosophy advised that there are many paths up the mountain. Or as George Bernard Shaw wrote, "There is only one religion, though there are a hundred versions of it." Of course, the hippie brand of religion didn't sit well with bedrock America, which initially accepted the conservative portrayal of the hip as dirty, smelly, unshorn heathens—the subject of scorn if not outright violence. In truth, those unfortunates who went off the deep end in drugs or had been

loosely tethered to reality anyway fit that description. Water seeks its own level.

But many of those I had grown up and went through the changes with were anything but the slovenly derelicts characterized in a conventional media looking for the sensational. That wouldn't have been cool. For them, morning ablutions involved all manner of powder, creams, deodorant, sprays, and an inordinate time spent in front of a mirror. Peacocks could learn from them. Walking in a group on New York streets, you'd see all checking out their reflection in large store-front windows for the desired effect. On one such promenade with the gang, we joked about that tendency, at which point I piously intoned that I didn't do that anymore: It only served to build myself up or tear myself down.

You're never smarter than when you're twenty-one . . . or twenty . . . or nineteen. And in my budding self-righteousness I saw on the streets some signs of what must surely be my life's clues for sought-after serenity. Walking one day testing my inner peace, I looked in the eyes of each person I went by—out of character in New York in most any time, as people avoid looking at each other, fearing the worst. Not judging, only observing. I met the eyes of a young black, and as we passed he leaned over and whispered, "Peace, brother." A revelation. And an affirmation. As has been said, we wear a different mask for each person we meet, without realizing it. What if you tried doing away with a mask?

Floating down the street another day in a rough part of town feeling somehow liberated and at rest momentarily with myself, I passed an older religious sort, long gray hair and beard dressed in an assortment of full-length robes—like he stepped out of the movie *The Ten Commandments.* As I ap-

proached, he smiled and turned his hands up in supplication as if preliminary to asking for alms. I didn't have anything to give (even if I would) and just returned his smile and shrugged, turning my hands up slightly to so indicate. No words were exchanged. His smile broadened, and a beatific light emanated from his face, and in that moment I saw what the old illustrations in biblical texts depicted when they showed a circle of light around a religious figure's head. Extraordinary. We see what we choose to see.

> *The man depends on others for his joys and sorrows, which generates an uncertainty of moods. His sincerity is impure and contaminated with external influences.*
>
> —F. Scott Fitzgerald

I was yet casting about for what that *me* should be. I wanted to be shunt of that boisterous boob I had been as a teen, acting out as a mask for my own serious doubts about my self-worth. What I'd seen in the joyful aura of the be-robed supplicant beggared any notion I had held of life, of right and wrong—of happiness itself. As one prescription of my nascent spiritualism taught, you can be happy whether you're at the top of the mountain or the bottom. I had a lot to learn.

I had come in to the NYC apartment with my own concept of how life and particularly home life should be, carried over from the routine I had become accustomed to at home. Mom, for all her faults, ran a tidy ship, true to her Germanic roots, and expected us all to keep a clean house, continually carping at us through childhood. Everything in its place. That was my norm. Only in retrospect can I see how anal I grew to be with that upbringing. And now, for the first time, I lived with high-

school buddies with different concepts of what "clean" represented (something often reserved for when a male and female first move in together). Their *casual* approach to maintaining some semblance of orderliness chafed at my niggling fastidious nature, further grinding on my growing angst.

In an act of sanctimonious fervor, I decided on one of those precipitous decisions that mark growing up fueled by youthful impatience. I would leave New York and head back upstate, venturing forth to find a true spirituality in those eternal truths that would lead to inner peace and happiness. I would spread the light to the environs of small-town Canandaigua. To his credit, Stephen tried to counsel me against it, advising that wherever I went I would face the same problems in myself. But I knew better.

I headed off on the next grand venture. The center would not hold. Ricky V. and Spud would stay in New York, Carlito ultimately following a love interest to California, where he'd work for Bill Graham at the Fillmore West.

My first great idea upstate was to immerse myself in yoga, opening up a studio to gather like-minded aspirants in an abandoned shed on land near Mom's house. I would live the contemplative life, exploring my inner space and teaching myself music on a cheap acoustic guitar I picked up. But the farmer who owned the old building rebuffed my request to rent the shed and fix it up—aghast that this long-haired weirdo might even think it possible. Canandaigua sported only a handful of hippies still and didn't cotton to the freaks. I then bummed a ride out to the racetrack to see if Johnny Rowne might consider hiring me on again, only to find Johnny near death.

Disconsolate, I stuck my thumb out to return home—only to be picked up by a state trooper. He didn't try to hassle me, only give me a lift, but he seemed to know a lot about me, about the apartment in New York City. He said that "they" had someone watching the place—which struck me as a bit funny, some poor schlep having to hang out with the bums on the Bowery to monitor our little dump. Like we were some kind of big-time drug dealers. I guess he figured this was some cautionary tale to drive me back to the straight-and-narrow.

But such was the tenor of the times in small-town Canandaigua. A growing rift separated the small hippie enclave from the devout Americans. Friends from high school passed by without a word, some even more belligerent. On one occasion, an old poker-playing buddy singled me out to ask if I could get him some weed. I saw in my periphery his friend, a student of police science at the local community college, carefully following the conversation. I gave him the trumpian two-step—I lied through my teeth. "No, I don't do that, man." Word had spread that the wannabe cops received an "A" in class for information that resulted in the bust of local miscreants. I began to see that my move had been a big mistake.

~ 8 ~

Back to the Country

The Nixon campaign in 1968, and the Nixon White House after that, had two enemies: the antiwar left and black people. You understand what I'm saying? We knew we couldn't make it illegal to be either against the war or black, but by getting the public to associate the hippies with marijuana and blacks with heroin and then criminalizing both heavily, we could disrupt those communities. We could arrest their leaders, raid their homes, break up their meetings, and vilify them night after night on the evening news. Did we know we were lying about the drugs? Of course we did.

—former Nixon domestic policy chief John Ehrlichman, interview with *Harper's* writer Dan Baum

In the final year of the unsettled Sixties, several milestones marked the era. In January, Richard Nixon became the thirty-seventh president of the United States. Later that year,

Nixon addressed the nation, asking the "silent majority" to join him in solidarity with the Vietnam War effort, and attack-dog Spiro Agnew, his vice president (who later resigned after being investigated for conspiracy, bribery, extortion, and tax fraud) denounced the president's critics as "an effete corps of impudent snobs" and "nattering nabobs of negativism." In May, an American teenager died in St. Louis, Missouri, of a baffling medical condition—later confirmed as the first known case of HIV/AIDS in North America. In June, the Cuyahoga River in Ohio once again caught fire, leading ultimately to the Clean Water Act and the creation of the federal Environmental Protection Agency. Also in June, a police raid on the Stonewall Inn, a Mafia-owned gay bar in New York City, led to days of rioting as the gay rights movement went public in a big way. In July, the lunar module *Eagle*/Apollo 11 landed on the moon. That fall, journalist Seymour Hersh broke the story of the My Lai Massacre of hundreds of Vietnamese civilians by U.S. troops, and in December, the Selective Service conducted the first draft lottery to conscript new troops for the war. Also in December, Black Panther Party members Fred Hampton and Mark Clark were shot dead in their sleep during a raid by Chicago police officers.

Perhaps of more import for hippies, trying as they might to establish an alternative universe, two August events signaled significant change to their prospects. The first, the Manson murders, played in the media nationwide, a lurid story of a drugged-out "hippie" family killing seven California people as a prelude to what they envisioned as an apocalyptic race war. Unfortunately, this played into the conservative notion of sex-enslaved stoned longhairs fomenting havoc in sober Middle America. Conversely, though, in some twisted way,

it provided some measure of protection for those targeted for physical abuse and worse: Suddenly the whole nation knew that there were some real fucking crazies out there. Now it wasn't only in New York City and other big environs where some hippie could possibly go ghetto on you. Though never remotely connected with any real hippie notion and alternative lifestyle, Manson nevertheless impacted the scene through his unconscionable acts.

The second momentous event in August 1969, Woodstock, saw a half-million young'uns show up for the rock phantasmagoria on Max Yasgur's farm in Upstate New York. Upon hearing of the planned festival, locals had posted signs declaring: "Stop Max's Hippie Music Festival. No 150,000 hippies here." But Yasgur persisted, reportedly saying "if the generation gap is to be closed, we older people have to do more than we have done." Quite a noble sentiment for the time, though nobody had any idea it would prove to be such a gathering. Originally scheduled over three days, August 15 to 17, it ultimately ran four days long, ending on a Monday with a two-hour set from Jimi Hendrix.

The event led to joyous celebration of the hip ethos, immortalized in the Joni Mitchell anthem "Woodstock" made popular by Crosby, Stills, Nash & Young. Despite heavy rains that turned the fields into a quagmire and sundry logistical nightmares for basic human needs, the festival remained peaceful, with only two recorded fatalities: one from an overdose and another when a tractor ran over an attendee sleeping in a nearby field. As Joni Mitchell later intoned, "Woodstock was a spark of beauty" where half-a-million kids "saw that they were part of a greater organism."

Ricky V. and a number of other Fillmore employees were

employed strategically in and around the stage because of their familiarity with many different band members. He remembers mostly getting about eight hours of sleep over the course of five days. Sis and a number of the Canandaigua crowd made it as well, but I missed it. I had moved on. My move out of the big city "back to the country" (a byword of the time) proved to be stymied by the lingering hostility in small-town Canandaigua. Like many other hippies, I looked to get out of the big-city madness and find a place where I could figure out who exactly I would be.

Disenchanted with my prospects in Canandaigua, I got in touch with Bro. While in San Francisco, Bro had begun hanging out with a group of folks from Texas, who extolled the virtues of laid-back Austin, the state capital and home to the University of Texas. He had settled into a cheap rent house there with friends and offered me a place to explore my inner space, insulated by a small but growing community of the hip in and around the university campus, the defensible perimeter allowing for a modicum of security. He survived by selling lids of pot to the like-minded, buying a pound and peddling enough to pay rent and buy food. This was made possible because Austin remained at the time one of the cheapest places to live in the country.

So I booked a flight and deplaned right onto the tarmac of the old Austin airport—at not yet eight in the morning but with the temperature already climbing through the eighties with ungodly humidity. I wondered what I had gotten into. Then lugging a large chest of all my worldly belongings, I hit the road and stuck out my thumb to hitch a ride to wherever Bro lived. I had no idea. Almost immediately a young hipster, Lynn, picked me up. He knew my brother and took me right

to his house, miles away. Such was the bond of kindred spirits at the time.

I quickly settled in to a new ascetic lifestyle, living in the unairconditioned old house with a fan in the window pointed at my mattress to cool off at night, a daily morning ritual of yoga, and a diet of wheat germ in the morning and rice and vegetables at night. I read whatever books I could find or borrow, exploring new chords on an old guitar there. I kept mostly to myself, monastic to the point that Bro's live-in at the time, Nance (ultimately mother of his first two kids), remarked that I was getting too skinny, going too far in my self-deprivation. But I thought I was "getting it." We managed to see a show or two at the hippie club downtown, the Vulcan Gas Company, but quite the music snob, I wasn't impressed: It seemed a far cry from the big-time glitz of the Fillmore. And anything short of the Beatles failed to impress. But the funky club did allow sanctum for the small but growing number of hipsters settling in town, morphing into a sanctuary city of sorts much as it would in another time.

Austin provided something that small towns like Canandaigua lacked—a certain anonymity, a chance to be left alone to "do you own thing" (another watchword of the time). *Just leave me alone to find my own way.* Austin was big enough to allow a person to hide away from the muddle and mayhem of 1969 yet not given over to the dark aspects of a large city seen in New York and San Francisco.

As summer heat seared the capital city into somnolence, time slowed and life proceeded at a more measured pace. This time of year also marked when the marijuana harvest season ended, an annual ritual when the supply of pot dried up—immortalized in the song "Henry" by the New Riders of the

Purple Sage ("Every year along about this time it all goes dry / Nothin' round for love or money that'll get you high"). With money running short, I tried to do my part by getting a gig driving an ice cream truck.

My first route fell on the east side of the north-south Interstate 35 in a predominately Hispanic neighborhood, where I got a taste of discrimination Texas style. Then, and still apparent now, the "others" in Austin society were segregated in neighborhoods east of I-35, with blacks mainly in the northern portion, Hispanics the southern. Houses in the ramshackle neighborhood I drove as I ventured forth were nevertheless neat and clean, obviously maintained with care, though the overall asperity of living conditions—and the life it bred—quickly became apparent.

A small group of kids appeared and hailed Mr. Icecream Man, and I pulled over for the sale. Before I could park the truck and step back to attend to the tykes, they had leaped on board and begun rifling through the cooler, grabbing what they could and hightailing it when I roared into action. After an agitated day with few sales, I returned to home base ready to chuck the job. Faced with losing a driver, the boss switched me to a safer route, one down by the university's married-student housing on the west side of I-35. Though also economically challenged, the area did hold a number of hippie families with kids attuned to the jingle of the ice-cream truck, and allowed me to eke out enough return to help restock the larder at home.

Life seemed to settle into a blissful and peaceful pace, allowing for a modicum of contentment. Bro, more accomplished on guitar than I, worked to put together a small band to play the few clubs catering to the hipsters clumped in neigh-

borhoods around the university. I worked on that happiness thing.

But just when everything seemed to be headed in the right direction, reality intruded, as it often does. Since leaving school, I had avoided the draft by happenstance, merely by relocating my draft board. I had gone from my initial notice for induction in NYC, moving my board upstate, then moving it again after I flew to Austin. Then the dreaded day came when I received a letter: Selective Service was inviting me to Dallas for an induction physical. This was not good.

Aside from the general fact I sought a peaceful, monastic existence removed from the surreal reality of life in these United States, I had more specifically grown even more increasingly radical in my opposition to the war. My foray into political science had hardened my resistance to the politics of the status quo—and to what I perceived as a colonial war against an independence movement in Vietnam. Before leaving Canandaigua, I had been enlisted to speak in opposition when a representative of the draft board spoke at the local community college. Someone who must have thought I looked intelligent or at least sane asked me to get the ball rolling in the question-and-answer session that followed. Emboldened by this trust, I launched into a diatribe questioning the very legality of the war, given that the U.S. had abrogated the Geneva Accords of 1954 proclaiming that Vietnam should hold an election to determine who should govern after the French colonial regime had been whipped. That started the ball rolling on a raucous discussion—and no doubt added to the file law-'n'-order compiled on me.

So when faced with the inevitable draft notice, I mulled over my limited options. I didn't know anybody in Canada

or Mexico (and didn't speak a lick of Spanish anyway), so I didn't see leaving the country as viable. I couldn't countenance the rigmarole of declaring myself a conscientious objector, consigning myself to some indeterminate number of years enmeshed in the system—and an unforeseeable future at that. I elected instead to employ the method used by a number of family and friends, the much-reviled Ted Nugent two-step: ragging out and going to the induction physical as a smelly, discombobulated, drug-addled hippie (in keeping with the commonly held public perception).

Spud had done as much when called to Whitehall in New York City, bolstered by a psychiatrist's note paid for by the Fillmore, which strongly supported its beloved staff members. When he arrived at his scheduled physical, a disheveled mess strung out on speed, the crisp Marine sergeant up front took one look at him and pointed to the psychiatrist's office, barking, "In there, maggot." Carlito had taken a more ballsy route in New York, showing up in a see-through shirt, powder-blue pants, and loafers. When the inductees were instructed to strip to their skivvies, he remained clothed, and when confronted by a military man and harshly instructed to disrobe, he demurred in a most effeminate voice: "I can't do that. There are all these men in here." He quickly earned a trip to the shrink.

So I steeled myself for a weeklong trip into the pits. This would be a test of mind over matter, of determination to persevere in face of spiritual self-flagellation. But as fate would have it, that didn't happen. A call came to Bro from Dad: Mom was in trouble. She had sold the house to buy a car and moved into a trailer, but then got blitzed and totaled the car, leaving her destitute and desolate. She needed help. Sis had moved on

to study at the School of Visual Arts in New York, and Bro had begun playing gigs with his new band, so Dad figured I was the logical one to help her get back on her feet.

He ponied up for a plane ticket that saw me returning to Upstate New York, where I once again transferred my draft board. This didn't sit well with the draft folks, and though I now qualified for a hardship deferment, having to support Mom, they had me head to Syracuse for a pre-induction draft physical in case I lost the deferment and they could grab me up. They tested this, they tested that, and I sat down to fill out the paperwork. *Have you ever had yellow fever? No. Diphtheria? No. Typhus? No. Yaddah, yaddah, yaddah. No, no, no. Are you homosexual? . . . Yes.* I wasn't going to give up without a fight.

The person reviewing my answers sent me down to the psychiatrist's office, where the doc asked me a few questions and told me to bend and spread 'em. I guess my asshole passed, because he told me that if and when my hardship exemption expired I'd be classified 1Y—but that I'd then have to return six months later with a letter from a psychiatrist affirming my sexuality. (Before that ever happened, though, President Nixon, under increasing pressure from the antiwar movement, reclassified all those tagged 1Y as 4F—"unfit for military duty.")

Clear at least for the time, I cast about for some sort of job in Canandaigua to buoy us and, finding little, applied for an opening at a factory that had opened up in town. Boss Bob saw on my application that I had spent a year and a half in college and allowed as how I might be over-qualified. I simply said, "I need a job."

So that fall and into winter, I made my first foray into basic hard labor: I worked making outdoor siding for commercial buildings from a heavy-duty type of sheetrock, loading it onto a conveyor belt to be sprayed with adhesive then coated in small pebbles. The job involved mindless drudgery, shoveling pebbles into a giant hopper, manhandling finished boards onto an industrial saw for trimming, then offloading and stacking them.

My coworkers initially consisted mainly of young redneck grunts with little get-up-and-go, and they soon got up and left one at a time, ultimately to be replaced by hippie friends in need of a job. Those new hires proved to be as diligent a worker as I, and over time I found myself as some sort of work leader for the boss, deciding on the relative merits of those hired on for the unforgiving job. Yet another, Jake, an aging punch-drunk boxer given over to paunch, proved to be a hard worker, uncomplaining of the hand life had dealt him. As has been said, the stupidest man in the world has something to teach you, and in Jake's quiet sturdiness I learned a lesson never forgotten.

Jake exhibited a stoicism I tried to emulate. I didn't have much choice, after all, and resigned myself to my lot. But by chance of birth, neither did Jake. Not born smart or sharp or clever, he was hemmed in by his ever-limited prospects, something I had never seen let alone understood. He introduced me to a whole strata of the population I had been shut off from in my upbringing. This was that chunk of society relegated to holding on to the bottom rungs, forever locked in place. I found myself really liking the guy, an empathy that would forever color my politics. When I hear someone pontificating

about all one had to do in America to succeed was grab on to your bootstraps and tug, I think of Jake and his worn-out sneakers, quietly pitching in and doing his job—and more.

At one point, Bob hired on a young kid attending the local community college, a morose sort obviously forced by his parents to work and enraged by the injustice of it all. In his funk, he made the job harder on everybody else by not pulling his weight, irritably giving minimal effort. When it came to hefting the ponderous sheets of siding onto the industrial saw, for instance, a job requiring two men on each side, Jake would be carrying two-thirds of the load on his side, softening the impact when the kid would moodily let go a foot above the conveyor belt. A word to Bob and college dude hit the road.

Life settled into a dull tedium that winter of 1969–70, as I was left to my own thoughts generally while encased in headphones and facemask against the riot of noise in the factory. I bought a beat-up old Dodge Dart from a farmer for $100, and it ran well enough to get me around town. Mom sobered up to this new turn in life, appreciative of what I did to keep us afloat. She dutifully cooked meals that helped me bulk up for the job. She knew I would ultimately move away but soldiered on, rebuilding her own life and even going out with an old flame who worked his way through divorce.

As a hard winter gradually showed signs of giving way to a spring thaw, work at the factory slowed. Siding sales for the company, never robust, slackened considerably and production began to drop off, leaving our crew manning brooms, moving dust from one end of the factory to the other or, ultimately, to day-long furloughs. The end was near. And I grew increasingly antsy about life in small-town Canandaigua.

A couple of local hipsters came by the trailer one day, primed to drive to California by way of Austin. They really wanted me to come along and share the driving as far as Texas. I perked up at the chance, but the hurt showing in Mom's face made me realize she wasn't ready for me to depart, even though she gave me leave to go. So I demurred and went back to work in the factory—part time, as production would soon shut down entirely. By then, we had both come to terms with it: I had to get out of Canandaigua.

I had remained in touch with Ricky V. in the city, though, even as Carlito headed out to California. Spud had moved into Third Street with Ricky V., both working at the Fillmore, and picked up the bass guitar. And yeah, they needed another guitar player to get the band together again. *C'mon back.* Another month had passed since my ride to Austin fell through, and Mom was reconciled to the inevitable. I caught a Greyhound back to the city.

The crew had changed since I worked at the Fillmore, with many unfamiliar faces. As someone with a bit of a track record herding cats there, I caught the eye of the new crew chief, who'd worked with me before, and he anointed me a "head usher," responsible for a sector of ushers. I fell right back into the rock'n'roll routine. On days off, we'd sit and play, listen to songs and pick up on chord changes, and sometimes even practice onstage at the Fillmore, allowing members of the light show and sound crew to try out new equipment. And boy, that felt real, and it rekindled a desire to rock out.

I felt more comfortable in the role of just another guitar player in a band, plugging into the old Rickenbacker Carlito had left behind and working in earnest to play and sing in tandem with Ricky V., the far more accomplished guitarist

and a good singer in his own right. Spud, a cute self-effacing little guy very popular at the Fillmore, fit right in on bass, and we were soon joined on drums by Melon, a classmate from Canandaigua High and a practiced flailer on his setup.

Though definitely not Fillmore material, we still could rock. Given some time perfecting our show, who knows—maybe we could be. And what better place to try out our chops than Canandaigua, something of a desert for music. Some bands from nearby Rochester might venture into town, and the local fledgling community college occasionally hosted a touring show. But not much happened locally catering to the nascent hip scene—a captive audience of sorts. We had no contacts for gigs in the city, so it seemed the logical choice ultimately to move back upstate. So in the spring of 1971 we headed north.

Just before leaving, I got a disconcerting call from Dad, now living in Virginia Beach. Bro had gotten busted. A time or two before, he had flown north from Austin with a load of pot for entrepreneurs in the city. This time he had called me to let us know he was coming (perhaps the fatal error, though we were oblivious to the lengths Texas cops would go to crush the hippie horde). Who knew about wiretapping back then, other than mobsters and G-men? Well, apparently the chest carrying the goods miraculously popped open at the airport—despite being securely bound and all but nailed shut. Dad bailed him out, and so began a years-long trek through the courts. But facing a long stretch in a Texas prison, Bro began serious efforts to put a band together.

Meanwhile we headed back to Canandaigua and set up shop in the basement of Melon's mom and began practicing in earnest, working on the type of song we liked hearing at

the Fillmore—a blend of old-style rock'n'roll (Chuck Berry, Jerry Lee Lewis) and popular cover songs (Beatles, Stones) locals would recognize plus a few original songs sprinkled in. Mom had tied the knot with her old flame and they moved off to Tucson to settle in, so I fell heir to the trailer. Ricky V. and his paramour, Gigi—not welcome at home in their unmarried state—moved in with me, soon to be joined by Sis, who moved back upstate. Wedged into the small trailer, we found ourselves headquarters for a small band of Canandaigua misfits, hosting a nightly gathering of assorted freaks and disconnecteds.

We subsisted on whatever offerings people contributed plus a small amount of food stamps, trying out our songs at an occasional impromptu party. Our first paying gig in a club just outside town was quite the event. Art-school Sis designed a flyer to distribute throughout town, and all our aligned friends made the scene. We suffered through an initial case of nerves, struggling with new guitar strings that slid quickly out of tune, but retired to a side room at break to stretch out the recalcitrant strings—and let the diet pills we'd taken kick in. Bolstered by guitars that stayed in tune and artificial energy, we returned to the stage with new-found confidence and pulled off what felt like a rollicking success. The vibe was good.

The audience contained a whole new subset of locals, those not totally in accord with the alternative developments yet curious about the changes going down. Some had already gone through a massive transformation: One of the original bad boys from Canandaigua, Bob, a much-feared member of the wrestling team who you didn't want to cross, had made a psychedelic switcheroo and became our buddy, borrowing his dad's truck to help us load in and out for our shows in the

area. These included a dance in the high school gym (which paid well but was somehow unsettling) and a gig or two at local clubs, one in a ski lodge outside of town. In all, the response seemed quite good, especially when we played recognizable covers of Beatles or Stones tunes, though our forays into the uncharted territory of original music were often met with polite applause at best. We didn't seem to be making much headway. It became apparent that if we wanted to make it in Canandaigua, we'd have to resign ourselves to being a cover band.

A taste of the big time in nearby Geneva reinforced that perception. One of our favorites from the Fillmore, Procol Harum, played at that town's community college. So we donned our green Fillmore football jerseys, purloined from the usher closet before leaving (we figured we had paid for them with our sweat and blood), and wangled our way to the front of the gymnasium and plopped on the floor right in front of Gary Brooker, the lead singer and keyboard player. The band's set featured their usual hits and impeccable musicianship, but the crowd didn't show much sign of life, the "polite applause" thing. These uptight upstate students didn't know how to rock'n'roll yet.

And as we well knew, if the crowd showed real enthusiasm, the Harum could be enticed into playing an incredible encore of old boogie—something they rocked. We quickly penned a note, pleading for the band to play some of their old-time music for their biggest fans, the Fillmore gang come upstate to hear them, and slipped it onto the piano. As the set concluded and the band walked away, students stood and gave the requisite rolling applause seeking an encore. We watched Brooker read the note, then stop his mates (Robin Trower et

al.) and show it to them. They looked at us, then bounded back to the stage and lit into "Great Balls of Fire." And the joint jumped. (With some encouragement: As the first song ended, some proper, polite young student shouted out, "Sit down!" To which we hollered: "No! Stand up!")

This was rock like it oughta be. Settling back into trailer life in Canandaigua totally bummed us out. We couldn't see scrabbling to make a living as a cover band playing high-school dances. We determined to strike out on our own—in Texas, bringing rock'n'roll to a scene that promised anonymity and a fresh start. So how to make it happen . . .

I put the trailer up for sale to fund our trip, selling it dirt cheap to a young Mormon couple moved up from Pennsylvania. That in itself proved to be something of an eye-opener. The young husband appraised the trailer with a practiced eye, noting a few things I hadn't figured out how to fix in the old structure, pulling a tool chest from his trunk and going to work. In minutes, he had everything working. The guy knew his way around a screwdriver. It gnawed at me, watching him diagnose problems and quickly grab the right tool for the job. I had sold the Dodge Dart for pennies when it began to run rough, and a local kid replaced the points in the distributor and happily drove it off—to my chagrin, as I realized how dim I was at doing the simplest mechanical repair. I resolved to learn better how to do these things.

But at least now we had the wherewithal to attempt the trek to Texas. Ricky V. and Gigi gained sanctuary at home until we could depart, Sis stayed with friends, and Spud's parents let me crash in Carlito's old room while we prepared. For $100 I bought an old rusted-out van at a school-district auction, and we found a serviceable bread truck for another $400.

At the end of April 1971, Ricky V. and I rode the Greyhound to New York to tie up loose ends at the Fillmore and pick up some equipment left stored there. It saddened us to see the state of our old stomping grounds, as the Fillmore was obviously not long for the world. We ventured in to watch a Grateful Dead show and saw freaks hanging out unhindered in previously sacrosanct spots, smoking dope as well as cigarettes in the lobby, a general malaise gripping a staff sunk into torpor. It did, however, stiffen our resolve to strike out for new worlds, and we returned upstate determined to embark on our new venture.

~9~

Tortilla Flats

If you're in trouble or hurt or need—go to the poor people. They're the only ones that'll help—the only ones.

—John Steinbeck

We had no idea what we were getting into, but we were ready to go. The six-day ordeal that marked our odyssey to Austin made the Joads' seem like a Sunday drive. We quickly prepped for our grand venture, getting in-transit plates and insurance, then overloading the remaining furniture from the trailer and all our possessions and equipment into the old bread truck and van. Ricky V., Gigi, and Melon headed out in the van, Spud, Sis, and me—along with a small herd of cats—in the bread truck.

Our first indication of what Middle America held for us came in driving through Ohio, where an officious little crew-cut prick of a state trooper pulled us over. He took one look inside the bread truck, piled high with furniture and crawl-

ing with cats, and didn't want any part of it. He focused instead on the rusted-out old school van, determined to find something wrong so he could bust him some hippies. He went around examining every light, every tire, every piece of the old truck. Of course, since it had been used to ferry kids around the county by the Canandaigua school district, everything worked—though he determined the rear license-plate light wasn't bright enough and wrote us a citation: We'd have to fix it before leaving the state or be ticketed. After he squealed imperiously away, we scraped some detritus from the light cover then forged on. *Fuck you, asshole.*

Unfortunately, the stop had cost us one item carried as a contingency plan: a vial of pills secreted in the glove box of the small van, some uppers to keep driving and some downers to sedate cats and help as needed with sleep. As soon as the cop flashed his lights to pull us over, Ricky V. grabbed the container and shoved half of the pills into his mouth, the other into Gigi's. As he notes, the paranoia of being busted for "hard drugs" in Middle America called for swift action:

> *They'll never take us, Alice! Oh man. I got most of the downers and couldn't stay awake to help Melon drive. Gigi, of course, got mostly the speed. I would wake up, drive as far as humanly possible, and wake Melon up. "What the fuck, Ricky, you've only been driving for an hour." Had to stab bushes while we were gassing up to kill the monsters that were hiding in them. Good thing I always carry a knife, huh? She was as far up in the stratosphere as I was low.*

Yet the effects of the drugs had not yet really kicked in, and we thought we'd left our troubles behind as we cruised into Indiana. But then it began to sink in just how badly we had overloaded the bread truck when we blew the first of four tires in a pouring rain near Terra Haute—and got the run-around from locals who didn't cotton to the longhairs passing through. To begin with, the tires had what they call split-ring rims, and if they're not mounted properly (within a cage), a person could be decapitated if that ring flew off when the tire inflated. We bounced around town in the van looking for a tire in numerous stores, where they either "couldn't" help us or wanted an extortionate price to replace it. We finally located a used tire in a shop on the poor side of town and waited while an old black guy fixed us up.

And this happened again and again and again—the scariest blowout to a front tire on a high-speed downhill run in Missouri, wrestling the truck to a stop at the bottom of a hill while swaying wildly back and forth. We jacked up the truck and loaded the tire into the van and Ricky V. took off for the nearest town. As we waited, though, we noticed right away that semitrailers barreling down the hill caused the truck to shudder scarily as they careened by, so Spud and I braced ourselves against the side each time (not thinking, of course, that if it teetered over, it would land right on us). Once again, guardian angels watched over us and we managed to hit the road again many hours later.

But each time a tire blew out, it cost us a big chunk of the day taking off the tire then driving the van into a town looking for a replacement—not to mention scarce dollars. By this

point, Ricky V. had gotten to where he could actually replace the tire and manhandle the split-ring rim himself, saving us hours waiting for someone to care enough to do the work, though even used tires for the truck cost a pretty penny. We had set out from Canandaigua with more than $1,000, which seemed plenty enough, but expenditures on food, gas, and tires ate away at our nest egg.

By the time we hit Tulsa, Oklahoma, we neared a breaking point. Gigi hadn't slept in three days, courtesy of the pills, and had begun hallucinating—seeing monsters in the roiling clouds that forewarned of a thunderstorm approaching. As we made our way out of town, a torrential rain hammered us, cutting visibility down to a few yards, so we pulled over in the shelter of an overpass to wait it out. We discovered later that a twister had torn through Tulsa, and we had narrowly averted being strewn across the Oklahoma plains.

As the weather cleared, we forged on and soon came across some sort of abandoned summer camp. We were fried pies by then, so we stopped and spent the day, taking a dip in the natural pool, resting our road-ravaged minds, and eating what food we had left. We might make it after all.

Day six we straggled into Gainesville in North Texas, out of food and money and steam boiling up from the bread truck's radiator. We had made it this far but it didn't look good. Out of desperation, I called Mom in Tucson and talked her into wiring us $25 that she didn't really have so we could buy enough gas to get us to Austin. Then once again, we sought advice in the poor part of town on the radiator problem, where an old Hispanic mechanic took pity on us when we admitted we had no money to fix it. He suggested we could keep going if we just cracked the radiator cap so pressure wouldn't build up.

We crawled down the interstate the last two hundred and fifty miles to Austin with blinkers flashing, waving cars around us, until we finally pulled over near Waco. The only thing that had kept us from falling asleep were the bumps separating lanes in Texas, jolting us awake whenever we drifted too far. Exhausted, we pulled into a parking lot and fell fast asleep for several hours, waking in the late afternoon to limp into Austin.

We collapsed there on the lawn of a two-bedroom house Bro had secured for us two doors down from where he lived with Nance off 45th Street, pretty much the northern extent of the town then. Bro quickly sent out for some takeout burgers to feed us, then we slowly unloaded the trucks. We packed everything we had into the house then slept for the next twelve hours.

It wasn't fancy, but it was in Austin and it was ours. We had arrived.

The first order of business had to be putting together our finances. The rent, though just $65 a month, came due every month, and we had a small band to feed. Our immediate needs were satisfied by selling the old bread truck for $400 (what we'd paid for it) to Mick—who, besides playing bass in Bro's new band, Greezy Wheels, ran a bakery selling organic bread to the few stores in town selling natural foods. That tided us over for the time, a short time as it turned out.

But we quickly melded into a family of local hippies, united in mutual defense against a generally unfriendly environment. Protests at the University of Texas had not enamored Austin's population of the tenor of the times, though we remained far removed from the hubbub. We just wanted to do our own thing, left alone to our own devise, and that didn't

include confronting authority and drawing attention to ourselves. I'd left that behind in Upstate New York.

We fell in with Bro's extended hip family, and one—David, a full-blood American Indian—made his living roofing houses. He said we could become his crew, expanding on his one-man operation, and he could then take on more work. I had muscled up working a factory job and felt quite up to the task, so we joined on. David proved an eye-opener in a lot of ways, besides teaching us roofing rudiments. When the van began to run rough, David, who had some mechanical know-how, clambered into the engine compartment, cleaned the points, and got it running again, and we were once again mobile. So as summer inexorably bore down on us, we climbed onto the roofs of new housing in the area.

At a time before compressors and nailguns automated the process, roofing entailed some basic labor—tarpapering the plywood roof, lugging bundles of shingles up a ladder and stacking them on the crown, then crouching down driving in nails with a hammer from the bottom up. It proved rough on the knees and ankles, but we did sport great tans.

Though the job left little time or energy for playing music, this worked for a time, until we hit a stretch that August of weeks without a cloud in the sky and temperatures climbing above a hundred every afternoon. One day we bought a couple quarts of beer at lunchtime—the beginning of the end.

I hadn't been much into drinking beer, or anything alcoholic at the point. In New York, Ricky V. would go out to the store and buy three quarts of "Old Bo"—Old Bohemian beer—for a dollar, but I never had the urge to partake. Part of that probably was the experience of growing up with an alcoholic mother. To this day, Bro has avoided drink. But the Texas heat

wore on me, and I gladly joined in and guzzled my share. We soon fell asleep in the shade of the house shell. That marked the end of our career pounding nails into shingles.

Next we came up with the clever idea of selling snow cones on the Drag, the street running north-south alongside the university, filled as it was with students throughout the day. We'd load a cooler with crushed ice and set up there with some bottled fruit flavors and paper cups and had a going concern—until some guy from the Department of Health or some such showed up and said we'd need all kinds of official paperwork and licenses if we wanted to do that. So much for that idea.

Then we thought fortune smiled on us. Bass player Mick approached us about taking over his bakery. Bro's band, Greezy Wheels, spurred on as he was by the inexorable legal grind slowly bringing him to justice for his improprieties vis-à-vis the marijuana laws, had begun to practice hard and gig regularly. They'd gotten the chance to play in a number of small clubs like the Hungry Horse, One Knite, and the Chequered Flag and had soon acquired some cachet among a hippie population starved for a local scene. On the eve of opening up for the Flying Burrito Brothers at the one big venue in town struggling to survive—the Armadillo World Headquarters—the band was joined by Mary, a classically trained violinist, and the weekly gigs took off.

Mick could no longer handle the bakery too, which entailed long hours producing whole-grain organic bread. As the band began playing around town on a regular basis, he found the need to divest, and what better people to take over than members of the extended family. We became heart and soul of the Earth Bread Bakery.

We moved out of our small house into a dilapidated two-story building on the east side—the poor part of town. The first floor held the accouterments for producing bread: an industrial mixer, cooling racks, and a stack of professional ovens. We settled in upstairs with little more than mattresses on the floor, which ultimately proved to be fortuitous. At one point someone broke into the top floor but quickly despaired of finding anything of value, neglecting to check the back of the closets where we had stowed guitars and amps.

We'd laid aside our dreams of rock stardom since the daily grind left no time for music. The job required long hours mixing the batter for several kinds of organic breads in the large commercial mixer, letting it rise, pounding it out and letting it sit again. The heat from the commercial ovens sweated us out of any clothes save shorts, and one lone fan provided only a whisper of relief. We'd take breaks out in the ninety-five-degree heat to cool off. Yet it was a going concern with some small customer base, so we threw ourselves into making it work. Two small rooms of the downstairs rented out to other entrepreneurs—one, a sandwich vendor, and the other an absent-minded professor with an electronic gizmo that allegedly purified water. With what little profit derived from selling loaves, we managed to eke out enough to feed ourselves.

Melon, an affable fellow with the shortest hair and trimmed beard so also the straightest looking, became our delivery guy to the few health-food outlets that catered to hippies. Our old van, "Canandaigua ISD" emblazoned on the sides, provided transportation, as the old bread truck we'd driven down from New York lay abandoned just outside the back door, tires flattened. It ended up providing Carlito a "room" of

his own when he rejoined the clan fresh off his stays first in Mexico and then in Vancouver.

We threw ourselves into cranking out all the loaves of organic bread that we could, producing as many as two hundred loaves a day through our sweat equity. But shortly we ran up against one of the basic tenets of capitalism: demand. While we had the supply side down and figured we could produce even more, we discovered that we couldn't sell it. There weren't enough hippies in town with the money to buy all the loaves we could crank out. This wasn't working out on all levels. We had no time for anything but making bread, and we were, after all, bound to be rock stars.

We split into two households. Sis, Carlito, Spud, and I heard about our former neighbors getting busted then sent up the river, vacating a nice house—by our standards (carpet, by god!)—in the old neighborhood, north of 45th Street. Ricky V., Gigi, and Melon moved into a big old frame house just south of campus, which became our practice pad, Melon setting up his drums in the living area.

Right away, we faced a problem with our nice new abode. It rented for a whole $125 a month—a prodigious amount then and a strain to cover at the time—but Carlito had picked up a straight job, and I scrounged up a couple part-time gigs. Sis ended up working at Les Amis, a campus restaurant and hip hangout. My main moneymaker entailed getting up late at night once a week and making my way up to the offices of the *Northside News,* a printed advertising circular that ended up tossed on lawns all over Austin. (Yeah, that was me. Sorry.) I'd hike or thumb the couple miles there—carrying my ID in hand for the regular harassment from cops on the beat—to bundle

up the papers and distribute to the assortment of part-timers who did the actual chucking.

One cop, though, when being immediately presented with my ID upon stopping beside me, took pity on me, saying, "This happens a lot, hunh?

"Yeah, every week."

"Hop in. I'll give you a lift."

Still, with what we could scrape together through various sources, we could then pay this *exorbitant* rent we'd taken on. But another small problem cropped up. If we told the landlord—a notorious weasel who owned a whole swath of dilapidated houses in the area—that we were new tenants, he'd likely raise the rent on this gem of a house, making the deal untenable for us. So we had to assume the identity of the former occupants (or, rather, the alias used by our imprisoned acquaintances: Allen Wayne). But the squeeze came when we discovered that there was an outstanding electric bill of some $150 we couldn't possibly pay, so we moved in without power.

Well, some of the local hip clan had stopped by to admire our new abode, and we lamented to them about our situation with the electrical bill. *Really? That's no biggie,* one allowed. He stepped outside and snipped something and suddenly we had lights. *Wow. Cool.*

This worked for several months before the electric company caught on, which then required some more po'-boy creativity: Allen Wayne had to die.

We had had a slight leak in the enclosed back porch that Sis had claimed for her room. When the weasel landlord came by and responded to this complaint by clambering onto the roof and raking leaves off the porch roof, Carlito laid into him,

calling him a fat-cat slumlord and all kinds of inventive countercultural buzz words. (As it turned out, that actually seemed to fix the leak.) So he'd already established this "relationship" with the weasel.

So I went to the landlord and told a sad tale of woe. That rat bastard Allen Wayne (Carlito) had been taking our money for rent and bills and stiffed us, taking off for parts unknown, leaving us bereft and in trouble with the utility company. The weasel, already predisposed to hate "Allen," sympathized, then accompanied me to the electric company and asserted that we were new renters who weren't responsible for the dastardly deeds done before our arrival. Problem solved. A new account was set up, zeroing out the balance owed. Poverty makes for some inventive subterfuge.

So we assimilated once again into the low-rent, albeit white, area of Austin north of the university that would one day become the fashionable Hyde Park neighborhood. At the time, though, it was home to the spreading hippie diaspora—and as such drew increased interest from the local constabulary. Squad cars made up a disproportionate part of area traffic. An encounter with a couple of them nearly cost Spud and me our freedom at one point.

We had walked a few blocks north to try to score some pot from a hippie entrepreneur in the area. He talked us into buying a lid of some particularly noxious dirt weed after plying us with a monster joint to show us you could possibly get high on it. At the time not choosy beggars, we forked over the ten bucks, I stuck it in my waistband, and we headed back south. One of Austin's finest soon pulled up next to us as we walked and the officer got out, engaging us in conversation. *Where are you going? What are you doing?*

A second squad car pulled up to help in the quest for truth and justice. Without so much as a "by your leave," the cops said they were going to search us, ordering me to sit in the back seat of his car while they proceeded to give Spud the going-over. I watched nervously as they patted him down thoroughly, then ordered him to take off his boots so they could check inside. The boots wouldn't cooperate, fashionably tight as they were, and the harder he yanked, the more the lining pulled free. Spud started cracking up.

I took the moment to become righteously indignant, opening the door and stepping out, surreptitiously nudging the lid down into my crotch.

"What is this all about?" I demanded. "We're just trying to go home."

You smell like marijuana, the first cop allowed, giving them probable cause to shake us down. To which I replied that we had just come from that new hippie club, the Armadillo World Headquarters, and we couldn't vouch for the company we had kept there. Not the best argument, but an avowal of our total innocence. They nevertheless ordered me up against the car and began patting me down, giving up on Spud's mangled boot. At one point, the officer's hand patted on the lid, but quickly shifted away, thinking it my junk. I was, after all, a big guy . . . Disappointed, they sent us on our way. It was only the first of several run-ins with Austin cops. I did mention that driving without a haircut was a prime traffic offense in the day.

On a couple more occasions over the next year or so, we came to feel the full brunt of the crusade against the hippie heathens in Austin. We hadn't realized the jeopardy we had placed ourselves in by moving into a house vacated by a bust

that sent the tenants to prison—dealers in hard drugs as they were (with prior arrests, we later found out). And in our quest to avoid a rent hike, we adroitly blundered into suspicion by assuming the alias used by the previous occupants.

The first happy occasion followed a poker game we hosted at the house. A member of our extended family visiting from out of town had befriended what seemed to be a casual bystander while noodling around the hippie market on the Drag at the university. This bystander seemed a bit strange in retrospect, keeping to himself during the card game, but it was in our nature to welcome all disaffected into our crowd. Well, during the course of the game, Melon asked if anybody wanted to buy a lid, which nobody did since we didn't have any money at the time, aside from the pennies we played with. But this question was duly noted—along with a description of all those at the table—in the warrant that was served allowing law enforcement to come in and tear the house apart looking for drugs (yielding ultimately only a miserable little tin of seeds and stems).

Spud and I happened to be elsewhere for the festivities, returning to the house that evening to find a note on the door from Bro, saying the house had been busted—come over right away. Bro and Nance, who had moved a few blocks away, had cleaned up the ransacked mess and gotten in touch with a lawyer. Spud and I dutifully turned ourselves in the next day and were fingerprinted and ushered into the local jail, hearing from the booking officers remarking for our benefit how the Austin police force was eighty percent ex-Marine. We spent the afternoon in a holding cell waiting to be bailed out. Our out-of-town visitor ultimately took the rap for the "drugs" found, and we thought that the end of it.

Until one night not too long after. I don't believe we ever learned the pretext of this "visit" to our house, but when walking home by myself that evening I happened upon a very serious group of plainclothes cops leaving the scene. They quickly surrounded me, cutting off all escape, and began firing questions at me.

"Who are you?"

"Uh . . ."

"Where do you live?"

"Uh . . . Up the street?"

"Is this you?" one snarked, holding up my ID.

"Uh, yeah . . . but I'm staying up the street with my girlfriend."

This wasn't going well.

"Have you ever been arrested?"

Nimbly demonstrating my knowledge of my constitutional rights, I fired back, "I thought you weren't supposed to ask that."

This did not sit well. They did not seem to be thrilled that they'd once again torn apart our house and found nothing but seeds and stems. So slip and slide as I might, I was headed back downtown—this time with Peter Parkinglot, a visiting friend from New York who'd been awakened and hauled off shirtless from the house.

"Hands behind your back."

The next day, I was escorted by a cop to stand in front of Judge Reggie (who would later prove to be quite progressive). He looked at me and said, "Let me see your hands."

I turned my hands over and looked at them. *Hunh? My hands?*

The cop next to me leaned over and said, *sotto voce,* "He wants to see if you have any tracks."

Oh. That's what this is about. [Extending my arms] *see? No tracks.*

I was never charged with anything since there wasn't anything worth going to court over, I guess. I did manage some small satisfaction when the booking cops cut Peter and me loose. I railed on indignantly about this egregious miscarriage of justice, swearing we'd never been druggies or dealers. They endured my spume (I did have a point, after all) as they dutifully filled out the paperwork, allowing finally that it probably happened because we lived in a "hot" house. My outburst probably didn't mean a lot, but I felt better after it—and they didn't come calling again the short time we remained in that house. We soon moved to cooler climes several blocks away next to where Bro and Nance had settled.

Sis had already moved out, joining several others of her gender in a hippie enclave occupying the better part of West 33rd Street. But we kept in touch, and one day she stopped by with word: The Armadillo had gotten a license to sell beer and wine, and they needed to get serious about security. The club had managed to get by with volunteer hippies during its first year to man the entrances, but now in order to stay right with the local law, they'd have to hire someone as a bouncer to card concert-goers.

~ 10 ~

Home to the Armadillo

And that, I think, was the handle—that sense of inevitable victory over the forces of Old and Evil. Not in any mean or military sense; we didn't need that. Our energy would simply PREVAIL. There was no point in fighting—on our side or theirs. We had all the momentum; we were riding the crest of a high and beautiful wave . . .

—Hunter S. Thompson

The Armadillo World Headquarters opened in 1970 and struggled through its first year with a smattering of shows—largely from Texas bands the club could afford to book. Our first regular forays into its halls came that spring of 1971 on Saturdays, when Sattva, a local nonprofit with Middle Eastern overtones that had set up in the Methodist Student Center, offered low-cost vegetarian meals at the Dillo. Basically, for whatever you could afford (which often meant

coughing up a dollar or so), you filled up on a meal of rice and vegetables.

The size of the hall would eventually allow for good-sized crowds as the quality of acts increased, though that alone created logistical problems. Basically a giant quonset hut with tall cinder-block walls, a concrete-slab floor, and steel beams supporting a corrugated-tin roof, the building proved too big to cool in brutal summers and heat during cold winter months. The parking lot, with its man-eating chuckholes, looked like the Normandy beaches on D-Day plus one. Efforts through the years to provide some sort of HVAC relief ran to the ridiculous: One winter, kerosene heaters were rented and placed strategically at side exits, but the heaters roared like jet engines and fouled the hall with an agonizing odor. During the summer, giant fans strewn about the floor to cool customers provided little relief, so the Dillo tried renting various sizes of air-conditioning systems. The last, a forty-million-ton unit, broke down more than it ran. Even at peak pumping power, it failed to deliver a trickle of relief to what would eventually be a dripping, packed house.

Yet the club provided a sense of community for both local freaks and those of us who had escaped the city—from both the east and west coasts—with an eye to getting "back to the country," doing our own thing, creating our own alternate reality. We were done with the reality of Dick Nixon and company. In later parlance, we were off the grid.

When Greezy Wheels opened up a show that June for the Flying Burrito Brothers, we could see the Dillo's promise, plunked as we were on carpet remnants strewn around the floor. It wasn't the Fillmore by any means, but it was ours—a

hangout for a community drawn together amid the hostility of redneck Texas. With its size and setting in an Austin already known as something of an oasis in the state (on the strength of the University of Texas and its youthful students' disproportionate influence on the local population) providing refuge for the hip, we could see it augured well for the scene.

Greezy Wheels had established a sort of residency at the Hungry Horse, a funky bar just south of campus, where they hosted a regular gathering—spurred on by a nightly chug-a-lug contest that gained the winner a free pitcher of beer. This led to raucous shows climaxing in a frenzied version of Sweet Mary's "Orange Blossom Special" on the fiddle. A good time was had by all. But the Dillo promised an even bigger venue for a larger audience—and *the* place for freaks to congregate in numbers. So when Sis brought word that the club looked to hire somebody to get serious about checking IDs, I jumped on it.

"You're perfect," she said. Well, I had been a security honcho of sorts at the Fillmore, I was a good-sized dude, and I had a good feel for the hippie ethos of the time and place.

And I extolled these virtues sitting on the concrete floor upstairs at the Dillo with "officer" Bobby Hedderman, who had also worked at the Vulcan Gas Company. (Though I may have been a bit distracted, mooning as I was over a nearby female member of Dan Hicks and the Hot Licks, Lickette Maryann Price, as they clowned around following a show.) I did mention to Bobby that I had been a wrestler and could handle myself in a pinch, but said I excelled at settling problems nonviolently. I didn't believe in throwing punches, but if all else failed I could tie a miscreant in knots until help arrived.

That fit the vibe of the time, short-lived though it turned out to be at the Dillo. For the nonce, we were all in this together. Austin, a small city of around 250,000 people, remained a laid-back place, accepting (within the confines of the university's sphere of influence, anyway) the freaks seeking shelter from the storm. We huddled together for protection—and friendship—in an otherwise hostile Texas environment.

A few smaller clubs in the surrounding area offered similar sanctuary to the nascent scene—bars such as the Hungry Horse, One Knite, New Orleans Social Club, Chequered Flag, Rolling Hills, and the I.L. Club. But in these simple, friendlier times, the Dillo served as the hub around which freaks could gather en masse, giving strength to a sense of belonging. A harnessed hippie energy transformed the club that year by moving the stage to the other end of the hall and building a raised "cabaret" area that could be curtained off and heated—more or less—for shows during the winter when it was too cold in the hall. The "grand reopening" in September 1971 featured Freddie King, Leon Russell, and local blues band Storm, all for the grand sum of three dollars.

Still and all, in the first couple years the Dillo lurched forward in fits and starts. A show with John Sebastian in October '71, formerly of the Lovin' Spoonful, bombed horribly—a major financial setback, given the $5,000 pricetag (and a disappointment for me, as well, as taken as I had been with a number of the band's big hits in the Sixties). The club was forced to retrench for a time, surviving on more economical shows to keep the doors open.

That winter of '71–72, I worked the entrance of the cabaret area for weekend shows that generally cost fifty cents to get in and often featured Greezy Wheels, a local favorite now,

allowing the Dillo to scrape by. The Wheels had practiced and gigged hard, motivated by Bro's looming date with the Texas prison system, building up a local following and branching out to other Texas cities in time. They became the de facto house band at the Dillo, ultimately selling out shows as the capacity of the club grew to 1,500. (In comparison, the Fillmore's theater seating housed in excess of 2,500 in a much more contained venue: Pot-smokers could easily be spotted and curtailed.)

But even when the weather moderated in the early years, good bands to play the Dillo were hard to find. The hall was just another shaky hippie venture in the eyes of the national booking agencies handling the big names. Unless they knew a club owner well, they'd often demand most all the cash up front, a difficult proposition considering the costs of top talent even back then.

The Dillo survived by showcasing a wide variety of local acts from Houston, Dallas, and San Antonio, as well as from Austin. For any construable reason, the club booked in benefit concerts, spotlighting ten or twelve local bands supporting the Deaf School, the People's Clinic, the Greenbriar school—and one to help defray Bro's mounting legal costs. Our little group signed on for any and all we could.

In my first year with the Dillo, major shows employing my services as security proved few and far between, meaning I had to find work elsewhere during periods of dormancy in the extremes of winter and summer. For one stretch I worked a stint flipping burgers at a Jack in the Box near the house to pay bills, where a supervisor in need of employees gave me a shot—with the proviso that I shave my beard and wear a hair net. Working the grill, I wouldn't appear out in front where

customers might be offended, and I showed up reliably, unlike some other young temporary hires. After several months, shows picked up at the Dillo again and I turned in my spatula and resumed the bouncer's life.

When shows required my services, the job only paid ten dollars a night, but again, Austin at the time didn't require much. A kitchen in the club opened serving simple healthy fare, and employees received a break on the cost—enough so that I could get a chef salad and three nachos (a corn tortilla slathered with beans, cheese, and jalapeños then baked) for a dollar. Slowly but surely the staff hired people to fill new roles, particularly when, in May 1972, a beer garden opened up at the back end of the Dillo and waitresses and bartenders hired on to staff it.

It seems that a hippie musician working there doing odd jobs, one Hank Alrich, had overheard discussions about what could be done to help make the club more of a year-round moneymaker. Unbeknownst to others, Hank had a bit of an inheritance stashed away, and volunteered to underwrite the construction of a beer garden, which could serve to keep the club open during the brutal Texas summer. Its construction using that harnessed hippie energy even managed to earn a grudging nod of acceptance from the neighboring body shop, whose workers pitched in some to help with their heavy equipment.

The communal spirit, the sense of family among the employees, drove the development of the Dillo in those first lean years. Over time, the joint developed as something of a cross between a family business (you couldn't get a job there with a résumé; you had to come recommended) and the proto-

type Japanese model (which meant working long, hard hours of real labor, at low wages, for the principle of the thing)—a grand experiment in the hip culture.

The lack of a serious revenue stream early on demanded innovative solutions for logistical problems. One involved getting beer piped to the different bars set up throughout the structure. Artist Jim Franklin, who'd taken up residency in a studio upstairs and expanded upon his armadillo-themed creations, had modeled artistic installations using blown foam, which hardened into his creative shapes. That idea morphed into cold vaults (the foam blown in as insulation covering the walls), one a small area adjacent to the main ballroom sealed off and refrigerated to store kegs of beer. A second vault occupied much of a basement space, and miles of plastic tubing connected kegs to taps in the bar areas.

In those early years, the communal efforts building up the club—and the struggle for basic survival—produced a close-knit family of like-minded friends, more so than at any time at the Fillmore East. In New York, after a show, we all left for abodes scattered throughout the city, and little of the camaraderie existed that characterized those of us huddled together in the confines of an Austin that more closely resembled a small town. Freaks, of course, didn't stand out as much in the big city, which already sported a long-established assortment of weirdos—any one of whom might go ballistic on you if you as much as looked disparagingly upon them.

At the Dillo, we hung out together on and off the clock, a social set that revolved around the Armadillo hires. Carlito and I, with friend Madman, had moved into a house next door to Bro and Nance on the corner of 45th and Barrow, a

short dead-end street where most of the houses were owned by one Dr. Johnson. Each month I'd walk down to the end of the street to the Johnson house to pay rent, where like as not I'd hand the cash to the doctor's son, Eric—destined to be a mega-star guitar player. Our house, a three-bedroom affair, turned into what we jokingly referred to as the Barrow Street Men's Club, and after Carlito moved on to his first attempt at marital bliss, Madman and I cycled through a number of roommates but always hosted sundry social events.

For the holidays like Thanksgiving and Christmas, we'd stage an "orphan dinner"—whereby any unattached singles in the extended family could join us with whatever contribution they could bring to the meal, generally resulting in massive amounts of food for all to carry home as leftovers. On Mondays, when the Dillo always closed, we hosted poker games, which grew to include as many as two tables' worth of Dillo staff, a tradition passed down to succeeding crews working the club.

Early on, we scraped together a softball team—the Slugs—to play in Austin's ultra-competitive city leagues, attired in a cool jersey designed by Henry Gonzalez, a Dillo artist who was also one of our better players. A combination of experienced baseball hands and sort-of-athletic hippies, we had a lot of fun and usually proved inevitably to be the best second-place team in our league. Undeterred by the lack of trophies, we forged on, also coaching and rooting for a women's team as well. One winter, the only season in four that we didn't compete in softball, we played in a men's basketball league (again finishing a strong second).

The camaraderie and shared misery held us together through these first unsettled years. With limited resources

in 1971 and beyond, the Armadillo ventured far and wide, managing to bring in acts like Ravi Shankar, the Velvet Underground, Taj Mahal, Fats Domino, Leo Kottke, Captain Beefheart, Leon Russell, and Earl Scruggs. Originally conceived as something of an arts laboratory, the Dillo hosted the musical "Earl of Ruston," comedians Cheech and Chong, the Austin Ballet Theatre, and the San Francisco Mime Troupe, among other eclectic offerings.

Austin hipsters, hungry to build on what the cavernous Dillo promised, ate it all up. And the unbridled enthusiasm that crowds greeted touring acts with resonated with many of the bands that began to cycle through the club. Frank Zappa, who called the club "the last fun place to play," would soon start his tours at the Dillo—and who, among Freddie King and others, recorded a live album in its funky confines. When Commander Cody and the Lost Planet Airmen recorded there, they had to dial back the audience from the final mix—it was too raucous. (For Commander Cody, we'd set up a volleyball net in the middle of the hall during the day, as they were hard-core enthusiasts. And though we had a number of good athletes working the club, I don't believe we ever beat them.)

For me, Commander Cody served as some sort of vindication. Ricky V. and I had come to Austin with visions of stardom in a rock'n'roll band. But in 1971, the locals' version of "getting back to their roots" entailed recycling the old "cryin' in your beer" country music of their forebears. An unmistakable cowboy tinge could be heard coming from the bulk of popular Austin acts playing the club, bands like Greezy Wheels, Shiva's Headband, Freda & the Firedogs, Balcones Fault, Tiger Balm, and Snaker & the Shakers. Maybe more swing, more kick, more

pseudo-religioso jive, yet somehow country. And what Austin clubgoers listened to in 1971–72: a "progressive" country (not what someone in a rock'n'roll band wanted to hear).

This homegrown music also profited from the influences of seminal Austin and Texas musicians like Steve Fromholz, Rusty Wier, and Townes Van Zandt, and a steady influx of new names, which grew to include Jerry Jeff Walker, Michael Murphey, B. W. Stevenson, Asleep at the Wheel, and, of course, Nashville expatriate Willie Nelson: the "Cosmic Cowboys" (as dubbed by Michael Murphy). The weight of all that talent ultimately—inexorably—would command attention nationwide.

Willie became the first Austin mega-star. And it was the Dillo's Eddie Wilson and Mike Tolleson and others who sat cross-legged on the floor with Willie, smoking a joint, and talked him into appearing, convincing him that what he had was honest, and good, and that he would play well to the Armadillo audience. Which proved to be a gross understatement.

In a 1973 *Texas Monthly* piece called "The Coming of Redneck Hip," Jan Reid wrote about a Willie Dillo show:

> *As remarkable as Nelson's act that night was his audience. While freaks in gingham gowns and cowboy boots sashayed like they invented country music, remnants of Willie's old audiences had themselves a time, too. A prim little grandmother from Taylor sat at a table beaming with excitement. "Oh lord, hon," she said, "I got ever' one of Willie's records, but I never got to see him before." A booted, western-dress beauty drove down from Waxahachie for the show, and she said, "I just love Willie Nelson and I'd drive anywhere to see him . . . but you know, he's sure been doin' some changin' lately." She*

looked around. "I have never seen so many hippies in all my life."

This became a familiar scene as Jerry Lee Lewis and Waylon Jennings and more followed Willie into the Armadillo, drawing a complete mix of fans young and old. Music was the common ground, a "roots" sound Texas hippies and rednecks both could relate to. Chet Flippo quoted Waylon on the turn of events:

The long-haired kids—they like country music too. They just don't feel welcome in some of these redneck joints. I did the same show in Kezar [in San Francisco] as I do in Gallup, New Mexico, or in El Paso, Texas, and it all works. Even though it's three different things: In Kezar it was the rock crowd, the Dead following; in Gallup, it's the Indians, and in El Paso it's for some pretty wild old cowboys. One of them "let's whup him" joints. You walk in there, like last night, and they say, "He's a cowboy singer, let's whup his ass." That right there is why long-haired kids have never felt welcome in country music clubs. The only exception I know of is in Austin, but there's not many places like that.

When Willie and the gang rode into town, they lent the club a certain cachet, and the next couple years proved to be for me the heyday of the Dillo—particularly when, in 1973, the drinking age was lowered to eighteen. The big touring acts no longer avoided coming to Austin, and weekend shows filled the club, with every conceivable type of music. You might hear Boz Scaggs, Freddie King, the J. Geils Band, or Bette Midler one

weekend and Willie, Tom T. Hall, or Bill Monroe the next. Ray Campi, the "King of Rockabilly," perhaps put it best: "Here they'll accept anything that's real and good. They don't care what it is . . . There's an open mind here, and that's great." And the bands played on.

Dearly departed artist and longtime Dillo emcee Micael Priest told a notable tale that encapsulates the feeling during this period. It was back before *perestroika,* when the Cold War still raged, and the head of the Soviet news agency and his staff came to Austin. After lunch with the Capitol press corps, they spent the afternoon at the progressive publication the *Texas Observer* with writer Kaye Northcott, who then asked if there was anything else they'd like to do. The Russians said, to the utter dismay of the State Department lady accompanying them, they'd like to check out this Armadillo place they'd heard about.

That night at the Dillo, the autumn equinox, Balcones Fault laid in a beat heavy on big-band swing—Fats Waller tunes and the like. Eight or fourteen pitchers of beer and numerous pocket flasks later, the Russians were jitterbugging with the hippies in front of the stage.

As Micael remembered it, "The one guy who could speak and read English pretty well was buzzing around the walls, filling up notebooks, copying people's T-shirts, the signs on the wall and paintings, stuff like that."

The Russians partied the night away, losing themselves in the good times. But before leaving, finally shepherded out long after the last dog dangled, one remarked, "This must be the freest place on earth."

By 1974, *Time* magazine got hip to the scene and gushed:

> *Rock is no longer a dirty word in Austin. Indeed, by embracing rock's big beat, Austin's musicians have evolved a brand-new style of country rock, and have made the city the fastest-growing country-music center in the U.S. Nashville, still the capital of country, may provide more regular work. Bakersfield, Calif., may offer the inspirational presences of Merle Haggard and Buck Owens. But from the point of view of new sounds, freedom and plain musical fun, Austin now definitely ranks as No. 1 . . . What the Fillmores East and West were to the rock era, the Armadillo World Headquarters is to Austin's country-rock set.*

It certainly seemed like that at the time. And nothing could stop us now from having our fun.

~11~

Sex in the Seventies

Every story's got a moral and mine does, too
It ain't nobody's business whatever you do
All of us got weird notions of time
The Lord only knows that I sure got mine
I'm public enemy number-one
All because I wanna have too much fun.

—"Too Much Fun," Commander Cody
& the Lost Planet Airmen

In college I had found sanctuary in the arms of a young lady—Beth, my first love—resuming an on-again/off-again relationship that had begun in my infrequent trips hitchhiking home the ninety miles from Syracuse. It would be giving the relationship short shrift to say she was, in comedian Gamble Rogers' words, my first pelvic affiliate. In short, it was love as I knew it then. We had each other and that's all that mattered at the time. For the first time, I felt that a female cared about

me. We shared everything—hopes, dreams, political beliefs. It opened my eyes to a new world.

She and her mom lived outside town in a trailer on a plot that contained a giant black-cherry tree, and we'd sit up in the tree and gorge on the wondrous fruit. The only child of a single mom, Beth turned eighteen out of high school and was thus legally an adult, but because of a past transgression her mom was able to invoke a legal ruling that gave her parental control until she turned twenty-one—come into play when she moved briefly into the trailer with Mom and me. This would not stand.

We drifted apart for the time I spent in Texas in 1969, but then she surreptitiously joined me in my second sojourn to the city to usher at the Fillmore, working in a shop that groomed and boarded dogs. When we left the Fillmore and moved back upstate, she had to resume living at home. About then, her mom convinced her that if I did love her, I would marry her—the prevailing sentiment at the time (when divorce had not yet become endemic). So when the band determined to move to Texas, it became a matter of if I wanted her to go, we'd have to go through wedlock.

Ricky V.'s mom, a fave English teacher in our Canandaigua school who had encouraged my madcap creativity in her classes, typified the prevailing notion of love and marriage at the time, despite a decidedly progressive notion of life (and a marriage marred in its own right by dramatic crises). On a visit one time with Beth before we left for Texas, she made some disparaging remark alluding to my wanting Beth to be my "concubine," reflecting the mores of the time. I let the comment slide by, though I knew exactly what she was saying

and why. She had already denied Ricky V. and Gigi a room in her house for their wicked cohabiting ways, and they moved into the trailer with Sis and me prior to the final move to Texas.

In retrospect, I guess marriage to me seemed the final move to respectability, which I had resisted all along—the typical kid thing to go against everything parents wanted and expected of you. I could trot out all the normal excuses: product of a broken home (harbinger of things to come, as half of all marriages would end up dissolving), the "free sex" of the Sixties beckoning, fill in the blank. I just wasn't ready. I was still at a loss as to what I was or what I'd grow up to be.

It's not that I had a clue about anything to do with the opposite sex. In my first stint at the Fillmore while not attached to Beth, I spent a totally embarrassing evening one time when Ricky V. and I escorted a couple of interested—and attractive—young ladies home to see the "hippie pad" we lived in. While Ricky and one repaired to the back room for a sexual romp, I remained in front with the other making stupid small talk—until she ultimately fell asleep sitting up. I laid her down next to me on the mattress and fell into an uneasy sleep myself. I was incredibly inept at skirt-chasing, mostly because of my own feelings of personal worthlessness.

And this was in no way enhanced by an episode Ricky V. experienced with a girl he happened upon while we walked home one day from the Fillmore. He was looking back to see that she was looking back at him and they connected. A day or two later I heard Ricky swearing from our tiny commode: His piss burned like hell, and he had to endure the shots that would cure him of the clap. Though not as serious as the STDs that would later raise their ugly heads, the notion of contract-

ing gonorrhea was enough to persuade me that free sex could have its price.

A time or two at the Fillmore co-workers blatantly came on to me, and I had no idea how to handle it, aside from a foolish grin and deflection. One, sidling up close and latching on, remarked how big my shoulders were.

Oh . . . Uh . . . Thanks. Totally inept.

So it wasn't as though I faced a choice between marriage and a romp through the "free sex" bandied about in lurid tabloid stories of the hippie scourge. I remained mired in a no-man's land of noncommittal. And unready to make that final plunge, I left solo with the guys for Texas.

And at least initially, our social life in Austin revolved around Bro's band, as they practiced regularly and gigged hard to ward off thoughts of his ultimate incarceration by the state of Texas. Greezy Wheels, particularly with Sweet Mary on fiddle, could hoedown with the best of them, their up-tempo music also a blend of a cosmic Jesus rock of a sort, blending the hippie consciousness into a recognizable country sound. This played well, and the band's hard work and non-stop gigs built them a following, which led, in the two-plus years before Bro got sent up the river, to their becoming (as mentioned) the de facto house band at the Armadillo—and, ultimately, recording two albums on London Records.

My little band mostly tagged along as best we could. We found that the music we wanted to play—old-time rock'n'roll—had few fans in Austin in the early Seventies. The Texas hip scene, such as it was, leaned decidedly to the cowboy western. This evolved into cosmic cowboy, progressive country, redneck rock, and, ultimately, outlaw country (devolved, in some estimations, as r&b singer Delbert McClinton

once opined that cosmic cowboy sucked, and not very well). We also didn't put in the long hours of practice, hampered as we were by day jobs required to keep us afloat that left us spent, often working the only jobs available to hippies at the time—construction. If you had long hair, no one would hire you for the office jobs with the state or at the university. So we were mostly just along for the ride with Greezy Wheels, trying hard to ditch cover tunes played in small-town Canandaigua and pick up on some country tunes to make our music more palatable.

As we were family, they let us open for a number of these gigs. We played shows with the Wheels at the Hungry Horse, as well as signing on for the innumerable benefits put on at the Armadillo. Then, of course, we'd set up and play at any party that would have us: at Red River Motors (a shade-tree amalgam of mechanics that kept half of Austin's hippies mobile); at a gathering in the country of the local spelunkers club; at soirées hosted at one of the two hippie enclaves on 33rd Street, one east and one west of Lamar Boulevard.

We had enough minor successes to keep us believing in what we were trying to do—one on a huge stage at the university in front of hundreds of students (Ricky V. seemed a hundred yards away, though a good sound system helped), another a raucous party at the Lake Austin Inn. The success of one particular show kept us going for a long time. We booked a gig at the funky One Knite club on Red River for a Sunday evening, not usually a very big night for turnout—and generally for meager pay in the pass-the-hat format of the joint. But come to find out, unbeknownst to us, it preceded a Monday state holiday, and the joint jumped. The rock'n'roll worked that night, the beer flowed, and at one point a comely young

lass joined us onstage and danced topless—though I was so intent on rocking that I was totally oblivious to that and groaned when later informed of it. Last call came and went, and the revelers locked the door (making it into a "private party"). And the band played on, finally caving in the wee hours of the morning. For at least a short time, we held the record at the One Knite for Sunday-night beer sales. This kind of show carried us through the bad ones of old guitar strings that wouldn't stay in tune and sparse audiences in the few club dates we managed to land on our own.

The minor successes and then my job as "bouncer" at the Dillo gradually seeped me into the Austin social scene. Bro and Nance, at first believing I needed to settle down with one "old lady," sought to make me connections with various girls in the family orbit, one a waitress in a club date we shared. I demurred, resisting the thought of settling into anything, as muddled as my life seemed. And besides, I became aware of a steady stream of young lovelies pouring out to sample the budding nightlife, many from the university and on the prowl for their first experience in the other-worldly.

Gradually I had come upon a new sense of self in the struggle with my own inadequacies. I regularly practiced yoga still (when the reality of temp jobs to keep the beans from getting too thin didn't impede) to clear my thoughts and quiet the inner noise. And where once I'd felt the need playing in a band up north to pop a pill to get out of my head and perform, I gentled my mind to the point where I'd come to accept—and sometimes even relish—my role onstage rocking out. I was just part of the *whole* going on. And in the heat of a Texas summer, I'd even taken to imbibing a beer or two (just to share in the revelry, mind you) and relished immersing in

the ever-expanding social set revolving around the burgeoning Dillo scene. I'd left behind the stuck-in-the-mud introvert for a much more comfortable fun-loving persona ("hail fellow, well met").

The family of folks hired on at the Dillo as shows got bigger in 1971 and '72 nurtured the bonhomie inspiring us all, and in this time like no other, I found myself quite happy and settled. Years later, in the beery aftermath of another softball game for yet another team with Jon, a longtime Austin friend and a restaurateur of some note in the capital city, we reminisced about the decade, allowing as how a window of opportunity had opened in the Seventies and soon slammed shut. Women had gained the pill, allowing for personal experimentation, and the specter of diseases such as herpes (let alone AIDS) had not yet reared their ugly heads and cast a pallor on this country version of the "free love" of the era.

And truth be told (as boorish as it may sound today in the "Me Too" era), in that brief window of time, the girls were every bit as eager to partake as well—they were just as horny as the boys. Not those suspect big-city girls of unknown provenance that once had me so skittish, but rather a host of fetching, clean-living Texas girls out for a good time, a steady stream of new faces cycling through to see all the different bands playing at the Dillo. For those attuned to the tenor of the times, it became a time of no-fault fun: no attachment intended or implied.

Living the life of a bon vivant, I became all too adept at readily discerning a young lady's carnal intents, settling happily into a life of constant carousal. (I've often felt that those of the era who *didn't* partake became the dirty old men of my generation's dotage, trying to capture what had so long

eluded them.) *Did she just like being around you cause you're fun to be with, or is she just interested in a roll in the hay?* Either would serve, as all became friends in a widening circle of acquaintances, including many fellow Dillo workers of the female persuasion. In general, you wouldn't sleep with people you worked around, as it could possibly create unforeseen entanglements, as I discovered with one aborted attempt at navigating an "open relationship."

This involved a co-worker with a captivating accent who happened to be involved with another Dillo employee. I found her quite engaging, as we played ping-pong in the office area of the club (another employee benefit). She expressed interest, and allowed as how in her understanding with her partner, he himself had dallied with another and caught the clap in the process, passing it on to her. We hit it off on many levels, so she opined to said boyfriend that she too might like to experiment outside their relationship—with me (after undergoing the cure). That apparently didn't sit well with him, and he flipped out at her and became quite sullen and morose around the shop. That kind of experimentation worked for him, but not for her? I see. So much for open relationships (and intra-office diddling as well).

But opportunities abounded, and I found myself "dating" a lot (the euphemism Sis used to describe my fancy of the times). And dating became a happy pastime as comely young lasses from the university area ventured forth to sample the moment. I admit to the addictive nature of the readily available sex and plunged in wholeheartedly.

Gone was the elaborate, scripted romantic interplay of an earlier age, the careful tiptoe to a semblance—or even a hope—of any kind of intimacy. One instance on a casual eve-

ning at the Soap Creek Saloon, a popular club outside town, should illustrate. On encountering a young lady I hadn't seen in a while—what? weeks?—we embraced warmly and savored a moment.

"You look good."

"You do too."

Backing slightly away but maintaining touch, if not caress: "You feel good too."

"Mmm. So do you."

"You wanna ball?" (the innocuous term then serving as coin of the realm for a not-so-innocent invite for sex).

"Sure!"

What was not to like?

Occasionally, though, you might encounter a woman you felt could be the one with whom you'd like to settle down. Then it became the age-old conundrum: You commit too much of your feeling, she might reject you. Or too-ardent interest might just chase her away. She might have the same problem with you, with the shoe on the other foot.

When that happened to me, I usually ended up reverting to a bumble-brained idiot spouting nonsense and going against everything I'd learned in cozying up to women—freaking them out with my ineptitude. So it went, every so often encountering someone and getting burned in the experience, making me more cynical about the prospect of settling down. Why bother? Why put yourself through the heartburn when so much fun was there for the having?

At some point I lost a sense of immediacy, an importance in what I *had* to do with my life. A lack of any sustained success in "making it" as a rock'n'roll star challenged any expectations I had in that regard, suffering irreparable damage

when bassplayer Spud suddenly announced he was leaving the band. He had become infatuated with a Canandaigua lass visiting Austin, then left with her when she longed to return to her roots in Upstate New York.

We had one final gig booked at the Hungry Horse, a last hurrah attended by a small collection of couples, and we played better than ever before—those present pushing the tables aside and dancing the night away.

That should have led to a retrenching, given us confidence in our potential and a desire to press on. But instead it led to a sad sequence of cycling through bass players, never achieving any sort of cohesion, beset by the struggling musician's pecuniary torment: no sound system, a deteriorating collection of failing amps, old guitar strings. This ultimately resulted in a declining interest in a band that for all intents and purposes had hit the wall.

This, of course, was ameliorated in part by a new fascination with the fairer sex. And when in 1973 the legislature lowered the drinking age in Texas, a whole new slice of Austin music enthusiasts flocked to the Dillo for shows.

As the big shows became more numerous, I took up post on the entrance to the backstage, holding back adoring fans from the sanctum of the green rooms. This became more of a problem as the size of crowds grew, and I finally had to agree with Bobby that I knew too many people—who could take advantage of my friendship to gain admittance. Bobby gave me my choice of *other* stations to repair to, whereupon I opted to work outside in the parking lot, where some sense of decorum had to be maintained to keep open the entrance to our neighbor's lot, Doug Scales Body Shop, as well as allow for cars coming in or leaving.

Any car blocking the body shop when a wrecker needed into their yard wound up being unceremoniously towed within the confines of the fenced-in compound, to be bailed out in succeeding days. On the strength of his Fillmore experience, Ricky V. hired on as well, and the two of us assayed bringing law to the untamed masses of cars crowding into the lot, a sprawling moonscape of potholes and gravel. With hundreds of cars wedging in, searching for any unclaimed spot, the job required constant vigilance to prevent the Scales entrance from being impeded—as well as cars from being trapped by hippies in a hurry.

At times this meant helping early departees blocked in, which entailed recruiting other bouncers to grab hold of one end of the offending vehicle and on one, two, three, *hump*—bouncing the car over a bit at a time, first one end then the other, to clear a way out.

And in our newfound bailiwick, we became friends with the affable old Mexican dude hired by Doug Scales to protect their entrance. From him, we learned our first Spanish, as his remarks always seemed to include his main preoccupation with the music fans: *mucha panocha* ("much pussy").

~12~

Innocence Lost

The first halcyon years of the Dillo lent themselves well to the hippie ethos. I was a "bouncer," but my modus operandi when dealing with disruptions in the social mien generally involved isolating transgressors and appealing to their better nature (which in sleepy Austin we all seemed to have): *Hey, man. We don't do that here. Be cool.* This was our extrapolation on how people should behave, something that had stood us well even within the confines of the Fillmore (until it didn't, and the hulking outside crew came in to quell any disturbance to the hip continuum). It was a shared perception of our new reality, what we should be aspiring to—and probably why so many Canandaiguans (six all told) with their small-town notions were welcomed into the fold at the Fillmore. We were nice people.

In Austin, there even came a time in the early Seventies when the Dillo reached an uneasy peace with the town's constabulary. As one wag suggested, cops refrained from busting

into concerts for fear that some of the attendees might well be local politicos themselves or their sons or daughters—or worse, statewide officials or their progeny in this, the capital city of Texas.

Gradually then, the creation of a scene opened up a bit of a breathing space for hippies who had once been anathema to the local powers. And in so doing changed my perception, admittedly self-serving, of a perceived martyrdom: I had believed, for instance, that hippies had supplanted minorities on the bottom rung of society in Austin, hounded as we seemed to be by cops. I reasoned that blacks should welcome hippies being on the scene as it gave the establishment some other evildoers to focus attention on. To some extent, that may have been true, given my run-ins with the law. But one episode in my early years bouncing at the Dillo gave lie to that fanciful notion.

It happened one night when employees escorted an overly inebriated attendee out through the entrance. He became agitated and pulled out a knife, threatening those of us who spread a wide ring around him. We didn't move on him, knowing cops were on the way, and we didn't want anyone getting stabbed as we tried to reason him out of his berserk. Within minutes, two cop cars skidded to a halt in a shower of dust and gravel just outside our gathering, and a burly cop strode through our circle, brandishing a stout nightstick and barking, in that command voice, "*Put it down,*" the steady bounce of the weighted club in his hand communicating the menace of an impending whupping. The drunk quickly dropped the knife and put his hands behind his back.

After the cops stuffed the drunk into one squad car and the area cleared, a second officer accepted my thanks and

chatted a bit with me. (I always tried to maintain an affable demeanor, retaining some appreciation of cops from my days in New York City.) Then he noted that he had to return to the "dust bowl" on the east side—the colored side of town—and took his leave. He deigned to talk to this friendly hippie, no doubt because of the unmistakable whiteness of my being. A teachable moment.

A further lesson learned came courtesy of aforementioned artist Henry, who took great pains at self-deprecation, labeling himself "the greaser" and otherwise belittling his Hispanic heritage as done to him throughout his upbringing in redneck Texas. I didn't understand this initially, having lived in NYC surrounded by all kinds. It took some experiencing life among the rubes beyond our defensible hippie perimeter before I understood his defense mechanisms.

But these small lessons paled in comparison with what awaited at the dawn of the cosmic-cowboy age (or *menace,* as one wag allowed). More and bigger shows filled the Dillo with increasingly rowdy crowds, Willie Nelson leading cowboy-western acts into the mix in 1972. And as laid-back Austin gave way to a more cosmo outlook, the mood gradually began to darken. To deal with shows that often drew 1,500 revelers or more, the club took on more muscle, extending beyond the peaceable pot-smoking hippies that had once sufficed as bouncers to bigger and badder dudes. As the crew expanded, I found amongst our number those I wouldn't feel comfortable backing up because of their belligerent approach to "peace-keeping."

Other changes closer to home signaled further disruption in my world. The legal appeals to Bro's case ran their course in 1973, and he was carted off to Huntsville to serve what would

prove to be eleven months (a sentence shortened thanks to political connections the Greezy Wheels had made playing at various fundraisers and the like). The band soldiered on, joined at various times by additional musicians such as Madman on percussion, Riley Osbourne on piano, and Jimmy Day on pedal steel. Sis, honored as an all-state vocalist in high school, had been added to the lineup earlier, chipping in on mandolin.

By the time political ties sprung Bro in 1974, the band approached escape velocity, extending their touring beyond the state—signing with London Records and recording the first of their two albums. The APA talent agency then added the band and began booking them gigs up along the East Coast.

While all seemed rosy with the family, I grew frustrated at my own situation, beset as it seemed by a host of little indignities. While life became ever more expensive in boomtown Austin, the Dillo still paid only $10 a night for a job that grew increasingly hard to deal with, in the company of coworkers with quite different dispositions. And truth be told, it rankled further when another crew member was anointed "head" bouncer. Bobby took pains to tell me he didn't choose me because he didn't expect I'd be around long. Since my own faint hopes of stardom appeared dashed, I assumed he referred to my future given the success of Bro's band. But a young man's ego is not so easily assuaged.

Then opportunity beckoned when in April 1974 the Texas Opry House opened less than a mile away. A large airconditioned concert hall with tables and a dance floor—serving mixed drinks, not just the beer and wine the Dillo could offer with its limited license—the club offered a more *refined* environment for the concertgoer. The opening, however, exhibited

the growing pains of a new operation, an inauspicious debut with the Eagles, which apparently had drunk patrons dancing on the tables and nearly trashing the place, a perfect opening for this entrepreneurial hippie bouncer.

Fellow crew member Mike and I, after a quick huddle with roommate Madman, hastened over to the club and spoke to the beleaguered management, touting my experience as a honcho at the Fillmore and years at the Dillo. For a mere $15 a night apiece plus a small surcharge, we would provide the best of the local bouncers to maintain peace in the new venture (and ultimately wangled $20 for nights when Willie and the the gang played into the wee hours of the morning, a not uncommon occurrence). With an agreement in hand, we had our choice of those Dillo bouncers we felt had the best attitude and approach to the job, as nearly all approached us to sign on.

The new venue quickly attracted the cowboy-western bands, as Willie (reportedly a secret partner) and the Armadillo had run afoul over questions of money and the pistol-packin' predilections of some of his followers. Back at Willie's first Fourth of July picnic, a number of Dillo bouncers hired on as experienced help to manage security. I ended up working onstage trying to herd the gigantic throng of followers and hangers-on—onto the stage area as members of a performer's coterie then off the stage to make way for the next entourage—all in the inexorable heat of a Texas summer, trying to maintain a studied cool to deal with the myriad personalities gravitating to the scene. A fellow bouncer served as gatekeeper to the backstage parking area, where only those with special passes could attain entry—that is, till one self-entitled cowboy in a Winnebago showed his conception of a pass, a

magnum .38 pointed at the gatekeeper's head. Needless to say, he gained admittance.

That was part and parcel of the falling-out with Willie, aggravated by a money-losing nine-city tour around the state with Michael Murphey that the Dillo sponsored. But the upshot of that breakup gave me and our little bouncer confederation a shot at the big time with the opening of the new venue.

And with visions of commercial prospects dancing in our heads, we coined a lofty biz moniker, Concert Security Consultants, printed up business cards, and contrived to secure more work for the crew—expanding into a pure cowboy club, the El Paso Cattle Company, and signing on for various outdoor fests and shows at the city auditorium.

For the short time the Opry House survived in this iteration—a shade over six months—we rubbed shoulders with the cowboy glitterati, becoming nodding acquaintances with Willie and the gang, who, after all, were mostly nice people, as many performers tend to be who rely on public adulation. We maintained relations with our Dillo coworkers (a few of whom we'd periodically sneak in to shows) and even pitched in a bit on some remodeling work going on to make the implacable cavern more fan accessible. Some of our crew worked both places to make ends meet, through whom we got word of an ugly incident in the beer garden, when some Dillo bouncers exchanged blows with a biker group. One of the bikers apparently had taken a razor to a number of them, requiring hundreds of stitches to sew them up. (One of the victims told me years later that he had ultimately caught up with the offending biker and settled the score. I didn't ask what that meant.)

For our brief stint at the Opry House, we managed to avoid this ugly offshoot of the growing cosmic-cowboy scene—the

violence of real thugs or the "outlaw" poseurs. (Some of the wannabes of the music biz, personified by such hangers-on as David Allen Coe, actually encouraged this with blatant puffery to inflate their image as a bad dude.) Our genial crew of level-headed security dudes managed to maintain the peace even during some of the more rowdy performances. For a time, all seemed to be coming up roses.

That is, until word filtered down to us of money woes involving management of the club. Apparently they had run afoul of the taxman on withholding and the landlord on unpaid rent, among others. Some signs of skullduggery had been noted by one of our number working the front door, who allowed as how one of the bosses would come by during big shows and grab a fistful of dollars for personal "consumption." We duly reported this to a fretful moneyman, who instituted changes on access to the till—but too late. In November 1974 the the Texas Alcoholic Beverage Commission pulled the club's liquor license, citing unpaid taxes.

In retrospect, the era's out-of-hand proclivities for partying best defined the loose money management. A good time was being had by all. And though the countrified acts definitely led to more communing between hippies and rednecks at the Dillo, Opry House, and elsewhere, an insidious element had begun to creep in: cocaine. As artist Micael Priest put it, "When the cowboys got into cocaine, things got a whole lot uglier before they got nice again."

Cocaine lends a person an empowerment that otherwise may be lacking, a power perhaps heretofore missing in one's life. Some fell heavily into the drug and its allure (and I was no doubt a better person because I didn't have the wherewithal to partake on any meaningful level). Some wielded it as a way

to greater riches—or as just a prelude to ready sex. One young lady in the ever-widening Dillo family joked once about how a slick dude with good cocaine and a smooth line spread the clap to a number of the girls in the group.

Coke also fed into the dark side of a shit-kicker mentality creeping in, a perversion of the outlaw-country mystique grown around the music of the time. This ugly side of the scene often reared its head outside the friendly confines of the Dillo in outdoor concerts staged in and around Austin, where I suffered my only physical damage working security. In those wild and woolly days, conflict maybe smoothed over in the early years of the feel-good cosmic-cowboy surge turned ugly when the sun went down and revelers got thoroughly liquored and/or drugged up.

In one, a concert staged with Willie Nelson and friends at the Party Barn outside town, our little bouncer outfit contracted to maintain the peace. Late that night, as I cruised the area in front of the stage where Willie launched into his headline act, I came upon a longhaired dude shoving a redneck so hard that he fell down, cradling his longneck beer. I quickly stepped in to stop the altercation, embracing the recumbent gentleman—who, thinking me his assailant, swung his bottle and konked me on the back of the head.

"Hey, man. It's me," I implored, and he then saw it *was* me, not his attacker.

Fueled by my own dose of go dust, I hefted him upright. Turning to the assailant, I noticed that Big Charlie, our crew member who minored in competition weightlifting, had arrived on the scene. Pointing to the hippie, I told Charlie, "Get him outa here."

The subdued attacker glumly—yet meekly, given Char-

lie's bulk—left. I was surrounded by concertgoers patting me on the back, one remarking, "I like the way you handled that."

His companion, a comely young female, noted, "You're bleeding."

Not too badly, though, and stopping my wound (and still buzzing), I continued through the night.

On another occasion, a number of us ventured out to see a Waylon Jennings show at the Steiner Ranch some twenty miles outside Austin. We always liked him (a gentleman I'd have chance encounters with at the Opry House), so several of us determined to talk our way in. We weren't scheduled to work, but Buddy drove us out and I blustered our way in, saying we worked at the Armadillo and heard they might need extra hands for security. Though not everyone with us cut much of a bouncer figure, they let us in. We were, after all, Dillo veterans, and I for one presented a good-sized body in case of trouble.

As the festivities wore on and dark descended, we ventured outside the backstage confines—fueled once again by marching powder—to deal with a number of fights that had broken out. We proceeded from scuffle to scuffle, breaking assailants apart and acting the peacemakers. As I approached one fracas, pumped up with my chemically induced empowered righteousness, I hadn't noticed that my compadres were still occupied with the previous ruckus. I seized on the assailant poised to deliver blows to a guy on the ground and, thinking my accompanying peacemakers would then restrain him, pulled him away, turning to the prostrate combatant. As I bent over to assist him, the attacker, gone whacko in a hopped-up rage, seized me by the hair and yanked me off balance, dragging me to the ground. One quick kick caught me in the nose,

and as he gripped my hair and rared back to deliver another, I caught his heel, tripping him up. Whereupon my fellow heroes arrived on the scene and restrained him, swearing mightily and struggling wildly. Buddy led me away, ruefully stopping a bleeding nose and regretting I hadn't thrown a punch in return for what proved to be a deviated septum.

That resulted in a long wait lying on the operating table of the hospital, ultimately, waiting for an insurance approval the concert promoter assured would be given to cover my mishap. Dunno if they ever got word, but they finally said "Let's do it," knocked me out, and straightened my beak.

That served to cure me of any notions that the bouncer life was for me. Our bouncer consortium didn't survive the shuttering of the Opry House, in part because of a subsequent home visit from an officious dude from some state bureau or other, inquiring after the licensing and bonding of Concert Security Consultants.

"Oh, no," I averred. "That was disbanded."

Fortunately, I had remained good friends with the Dillo family and was accepted back into the fold—however grudgingly in some cases—but this time as a bartender, safe from any mayhem breaking out in the crowd.

A final episode in my Dillo bartending stint reinforced my desire to stay out of the bouncing game. One of the dudes hired on at the Dillo (and never used by us at the Opry House) had a particularly abrasive style of crowd management. On a busy evening I buzzed around the bar in the beer garden serving up beers, he apparently tried muscling a couple of interlopers in the nearby waitress station. They apparently weren't buying Texas tough, having themselves just graduated from the Texas penal system, and one planted his buck

knife squarely into said bouncer's mouth, knocking out his front teeth and sending him to his knees. I heard a bang but was preoccupied shuffling drinks and didn't see what happened. Two other staffers, neither particularly big, cautiously tailed the assailants to their car, where they pulled off the rear license plate to avoid identification, avowing they weren't going back to prison. They quickly loaded up and peeled out.

At this point, I hadn't yet taken the bandage off my bent nose, and I seriously began questioning my life choices once again. I had settled into a long-term relationship with one of the Dillo waitresses, Che, who was finishing a degree in microbiology at UT, and started thinking about my options. Fate once again intervened, as Bro's band had launched into serious touring and he approached me about joining on as a roadie/road manager. I don't believe I thought twice about it—and spent the next two years traveling to gigs in everywhere from Lake Placid in Upstate New York to Miami, Florida, swinging back through Mississippi and Louisiana on our way to Austin.

In that time, I did miss massive upheaval at the Dillo, which went through bankruptcy and a massive retooling that enabled the club to ultimately survive the decade. Before the club's last waltz, though, I left the band and began a seven-year stretch working as a mechanic at the local Volkswagen dealership—so spent some time with my belle seeing an occasional band there and the final blow-out show. But that's a story for another time.

~13~

No Regrets

Men have money not because they are smarter than other men, but because they have devoted such intellect as the Lord gave them to the base purpose of acquiring wealth.

—Clarence Darrow

The years I invested in rock'n'roll heaped a fair share of regret on me—*I coulda, I shoulda*—but time has a way of slathering mellow on remorse. From my perspective on the back nine of life, I can't say I'd want to change much, given the chance. Sure, I could fill volumes with the dumbshit things I've done in my life, and those regrets pile up over time, coming back to haunt you in those stinging moments of doubt. But if you've learned that lesson, does it really help to dwell anew on it? If you waste time looking back at all the mistakes you've made, churning inside over your failures, you can lose sight of what's in front of you and trip

over what might be coming your way.

I came to chide myself whenever I began bewailing my mistakes and/or failings, telling myself to just shut the fuck up and move on. It proved the healthier attitude. My foray in hippiedom provided some relief in that regard. As noted before, Eastern philosophy—in which the hip steeped—teaches that there are many paths up the mountain. Okay, though mine has been a twisted trail, a meandering path with more than a few tumbles down the slope, I ended up somewhere along the way (far from any summit) that at least gives me a good perspective on my failings.

Traditional theology might see it another way, with its one sanctioned path to enlightenment, but now more than ever, conventional orthodoxy (particularly that espoused in those big mega churches) leaves me flat, given the mindless prattling of ersatz evangelicals nowadays preaching the prosperity gospel as some sort of glorious communion with commerce for the masses. I believe in spiritualism but have no faith in religion.

Even further, too much mainstream religion veers wildly into governance, become (to bowdlerize Marx) an opiate of the politician, who has wielded it to weaponize morality and demonize the "other" in everyday life—all too successfully. Archibald Macleish once observed, "Religion is at its best when it makes us ask hard questions of ourselves. It is at its worst when it deludes us into thinking we have all the answers for everybody else."

I was at one revolted and activated by this form of brand-name belief. Early on in New York City, a youthful piety that hippies shared fueled my spiritual musings. Dear old Dad's advice on Sufism gave me probably my best steer-

age. Like he said, if you say you're a Sufi, then you're not. How appropriate. If you say you're religious, you're not. Sounds about right.

But further, as someone once noted, it's not enough to do the right thing; you have to do it in the right way. Hippies were as guilty as any at being sanctimonious. Something about that mote in thine own eye? Plenty of motes here, which often blinded me or ultimately caused me pain, a fine example of youth wasted on the young. It seems to me that the bulk of pain we experience—physical as well as mental—is self-inflicted.

Not all my time went for naught. I would spend seven years working as a mechanic in a Volkswagen dealership, my blue period, fulfilling my desire to become more self-sufficient, also serving to further cement in me a hardcore populist belief (not the populism trumpeted by politicians intent on selling the inattentive on the next big ripoff—you know, as in "drain the swamp"). I had already received a smatter of on-the-job training in auto repair with a funky VW bug I'd bought for $400, with the manual for the compleat idiot my guide. Then two years on the road with the Wheels, broke down in locations from Mahwah, New Jersey, to Tampa Bay, lent some real-world necessity to my toolbox.

As I really learned the trade, my fellow mechanics in the garage became my brothers in arms, sharing my pleasures and my pains through good times and bad. The dealership sent me to classes at the Volkswagen training school in San Antonio, and I learned from instructors there the wonders of German ingenuity. Back at work, if I ran into a problem I hadn't yet encountered, someone was there to help. And as I delved further into the job, I developed a fair talent for

reading schematics, sussing out obscure electrical problems, making myself a good buddy to have in the shop (as this tends to be a weak spot among mechanics).

For a time, I found another bit of the happiness I'd continually sought. And the press of time and budget led me inexorably to a more middle-class existence, as mate Che and I bought a small house and settled in, even buying a couple air conditioners, my first in eight years living in Texas.

Home ownership also conveyed with it a more proper American existence, a do-it-yourself contentment furthered in my fifteen-year relationship with Che (a woman smarter than I and more rooted in reality). She figured if I could fix cars I could no doubt translate these talents into taking care of general household maintenance. And with friends skilled in various trades, I could solicit any needed advice (this, after all, predated the internet and its instructional videos)—for mounting ceiling fans, hanging wallpaper, all manner of plumbing and electrical repairs.

There came a time, though, when the novelty of expanding my blue-collar horizons wore off. Eight months of the year at the dealership, I'd sweat through my work blues before nine o'clock in the morning in the brutal Texas heat, which seemed to extend inexorably. To boot, the newer cars came out needing less and less regular maintenance, meaning jobs available on a daily basis tended to be warranty work—that is, fixes on new cars that paid mechanics significantly less and frustrated considerably more (since manuals describing the new models lagged far behind their introduction).

At the end of the Seventies I turned thirty, an age I think when a person feels the need to take stock and con-

sider what path in life to finally embark on. Maybe it's just the nagging sense that you may be running out of time. For me, anyway, it became the point where I decided it was time to get serious about life and figure out where I *should* be heading.

Part and parcel of my malaise was a now-festering social scene, as the ringing truths of the Sixties gave way at the close of the Seventies, ushering in the disco era—which to me seemed little more than some slither-tongued devil crooning about bootie over a throbbing beat. *Enh . . .*

Nixon had been unceremoniously drummed out of the scene (though then pardoned by Ford), and politics seemed to enter some psychic doldrum, though the election of southern gentleman Jimmy Carter seemed at least to augur more honesty in politics, if nothing else—and however briefly.

At any rate, I'd reached one of those "fuck it, I can't take this anymore" stages in life and enrolled in classes at the University of Texas, working part time for the duration. Since I'd somehow managed to accumulate thirty-three hours of credit at Syracuse in journalism/poly sci (and then fulfilled some language requirements by testing out of a couple French courses), I determined J school would be the shortest distance between two points. But I did want to polish my chops pontificating (as was my inclination), so I also enrolled in every English writing class I could take.

It didn't take long to realize that times had changed on campus. Granted, I now was a good ten years older than most of my classmates—senior as well even to some of my profs. The tenor of student life now reflected a return to more of a staid, "pre-war" life. Fraternities and sororities were staging a comeback, leading Jackson Hooper, then vice

president of the Interfraternity Council, to sniff: "There seem to be less people walking around who don't bathe. The campus in general seems to be closer to where the Greeks have been all along." *Okay . . .*

And I soon began to chafe at some of the requirements of my classes, which in journalism meant writing stories assigned by students running the campus newspaper. When one of my articles, on some godawful piece of campus puffery of no import, ran "above the fold" on the front page, I determined that wouldn't serve.

Fortunately, I'd seen a presentation in the class of one older, progressive prof about a local public-access news show that prided itself on covering stories ignored by the mainstream media—*Alternative Views*—and begun doing a bit of work for the creators, Frank Morrow and Doug Kellner, a UT prof. They dug into meaty journalism like the Reagan administration's shady funding of the contras in Nicaragua. This gave me something to write that I didn't mind seeing my byline on in the student paper. So I began to write more political pieces, editorializing on Reagan, the arms deal, the contras, the lack of diversity at UT itself. And they appeared in the student paper.

Well, one day, while sitting in the lobby reading and waiting for a class to start, I began to notice someone discoursing with increasing vehemence just down the table from me. It got louder and louder, someone railing on about communism, falling dominoes, etc., so at one point I glanced over to hear who might be raving so. Turns out, it was one of the teaching assistants in the J school, a young bug-eyed red-faced conservative, and he was ranting to another stu-

dent—but directing his invective *at me*. I slowly turned my head full frontal to the windbag, raised an eyebrow, then casually went back to reading.

Something in that look must have given him some idea of the thin ice on which he trod. I typically walked around campus with a bad-on—usually in my work blues, the sweat from the morning not yet dried off—almost spoiling for trouble. Perhaps sensing impending doom, he subsided into muttering to the table in front of him, avoiding succeeding pointed glances.

His kind would surely set me off. I had gotten my absolute fill of what I'd come to see as entitled yuppies while working at the dealership. One in particular stood out, party to a particularly noxious encounter one day.

Marcus, a short, longhaired young guy, worked as a porter at the shop, sweeping up and bringing up customers' cars when they arrived to reclaim their vehicles. A sweet, clean-shaven fellow, Marcus had served in Vietnam but had totally lost it it when his unit was overrun during the Tet Offensive—his marble sack developed quite a hole. But still, he was a hard-working, affable sort everyone liked, other than this one self-important prick, who took great exception one day when Marcus skidded a bit when stopping in front of him to deliver his car. Bellowing that he didn't want some dirty hippie driving his new car and screwing up its precious brakes, he created an obnoxious scene, berating the service writer and everybody within shouting distance.

Poor Marcus quietly slunk away, unsure of what he'd done to inflame him and not really capable of understanding. This pretty much pissed off everyone in the shop,

and one of the office ladies enlisted my help, as a former bouncer, when said prick returned a short time later. (As we subsequently found out, he had been racing his car, voiding his warranty, and causing recurring brake problems.)

As the jerk stood in the service drive waiting for some more *appropriate* person to bring up his vehicle, I went out and cranked it up, flying into the garage and skidding halfway across the shop to stop within shouting distance of him. With a roar, he ran to the car bursting with bluster when . . . this big sweaty hippie with supreme prejudice stepped out to face him.

"Uh . . . Stops good, don't it?" he meekly squeaked as I turned and stalked away.

Unseen by him, all the ladies in the parts department and front office, behind class partitions, convulsed in laughter, my fellow mechanics ducking behind toolboxes and cars to guffaw. A blow against some kind of empire.

So I did have a bit of attitude when I got to campus for class, the sweat of the day not yet dried. And this "Ain't We Got Fun" era, the concerted effort to put the Sixties in the rearview mirror didn't sit particularly well with me either. Fortunately, I found a lot more substance in denizens of the local music scene, which had gone decidedly punk—complete with riotous confrontations with the local constabulary. Punk, to me, offered a sight more than the disco or glam rock that vied for attention nationwide. I guess I was punk in my own way.

I had fabricated a pin at the campus copy shop to wear around campus and trumpet my thoughts on the prevailing social conservatism. "Fuck the Moral Majority," it read. This caused no small manner of consternation among a few

young coeds—sometimes just short of the vapors—when they espied this as I prowled campus. But for others, as when I ran into Biscuit, a notorious Austin punk musician, it proved a source of hilarity. "Oh, you are so right," he remarked, chortling.

> *In this age, the mere example of noncomformity, the mere refusal to bend the knee to custom, is itself a service.*
>
> —John Stuart Mill

Fortunately, many of the students I encountered in class didn't buy into the conservative bent oozing onto campus. "We're pretty jaded," one opined in a class when challenged by my beloved progressive prof over some political point.

And classmates in several English writing classes seemed most well-disposed to my hippie rants (though I'd soon cut back my locks to accommodate the wane of my hairline). One, in fact, peer in a class for advanced expository writing, would ultimately recommend me for proofreading to her editor at *Third Coast,* an artsy avant-garde city magazine in Austin that was the dream job for every journalism student then.

I had also picked up a part-time job proofreading, something suited to my ultra-anal nature, for a time working forty hours a week or better between it and the shop—besides my classes. This schedule got old fast, particularly given my declining income working at the dealership. One old goat who had hired on as service writer (the people who take orders and direct work to mechanics) decided a part-timer like me didn't deserve to get "gravy" work, instead relegating mostly piddling jobs and warranty work to me.

Since I couldn't rightly beat the shit out of him, I instead shucked my work blues and carted my toolbox home. Parting from my brother mechanics proved sweet sorrow indeed, and when I packed up they gifted me with purloined shop supplies I might be needing out on my own.

So while finishing up on a degree, I gravitated between part-time jobs at G&S Typesetting (a force in the production of college textbooks in addition to its magazine printing) and *Third Coast,* which ultimately became my sole full-time job—beginning a long foray back into the star-crossed world of journalism. The magazine, in my five-plus years there, proved ultimately to be the best job I ever had, working under John Taliaferro, an enlightened editor with cheek. He abetted the kind of environment journalists would die for, putting together a small staff surrounded by a talented group of Austin freelance artists, photographers, and writers who loved their work and, more than anything, enjoyed each others' company.

This was journalism as it was meant to be, a fine group of creative types fomenting all kinds of good trouble. And for their efforts, *Third Coast* twice made the finals of the national magazine awards. Each issue offered a new perspective on the mixed bag of Austin life and politics. The type of features running in the monthly varied as much the writers.

One memorable tale came about when a particularly favored freelancer, Patricio, sold John on a story about riding the Aztec Eagle train from the border down to Mexico City—and off a bunch of magaziners went on the 24-hour trek, resulting in a rollicking cover story and some fast friendships. (Excursions to various parts of Mexico would become a yearly event for our group to escape the mercan-

tile madness of Christmas.) For the daylong train trip down, we humped cases of beer and coolers of food and snacks aboard and settled in, hands of poker filling the hours when not napping, writing, or reading.

At one of the interminable, inexplicable stopovers the train made while waiting for some kind of clearance, Patricio and I stood looking out at a familiar rural Mexican-desert scene exchanging profundities (the wont of word wranglers). A tattered shack of scavenged lumber, railroad parts, and burlap squatted along the rails, bounded by a fence formed of scraggly cactus. A trio of nearly naked, scruffy *chicos* tumbled about the dusty enclosure, kicking around a soccer ball of wadded-up something-or-other and raising holy hell. Their young mother, barefoot and clad in a ratty but serviceable shift, leaned in the doorway, arms folded across her chest, watching with a smile on her face.

Struck dumb at the scene, I remarked to Pat in a moment of lucidity, "You know, just because that *mamasita* doesn't have shit in this world—and has no prospects for any—that doesn't mean she loves her kids any less."

That may have been the *Casablanca* moment in our relationship, as in "I think this is the beginning of a beautiful friendship." We would remain close over the years, and I would always find a place for his reflections in the various publications I would find myself editing.

Sad to say, *Third Coast* would ultimately succumb to a real-estate bust in the Austin economy, and I found myself bouncing between editing or writing for a number of Texas media companies and publications—before *their* demise, portent of the sad state of journalism today. Between actual stints in the fourth estate, I'd always find solace in the

typesetting shop along with Patricio and a slew of expatriates with wide-ranging talents. The family that ran the business, the Grosskopfs, offered me some renewed faith in our society, considering they were small "r" republicans as well as devout christians but lived as they did a sincere form of faith and politics far from what mainstream versions practiced.

The Eighties, with the ascendancy of Reagan, had devolved into a seemingly never-ending seepage of news about the latest administration malfeasance, from Debategate to Iran-Contra, the EPA, HUD, Wedtech, FEMA, and ultimately the savings-and-loan crisis—which Economist John Kenneth Galbraith called "the largest and costliest venture in public misfeasance, malfeasance, and larceny of all time" (to which the Trump administration would later acclaim "hold my beer"). The Age of Aquarius given over to the Age of Acquisition.

All too much of this, of course, was swept under the rug of Bush pardons. But the litany of corruption—the investigation, indictment, or conviction of over 138 in the Reagan administration—scarred the political landscape, if still not reaching the collective conscious of the American people (deadened, perhaps, following the Nixon follies). A former history professor ascribed this type of mainstream myopia to a "tyranny of the majority," a phrase coined by Alexis de Toqueville in his 1835 *Democracy in America.* The prof said this didn't refer to a majority ganging up on a minority, but rather to a populace's preoccupation with their own trials and tribulations in daily life (exacerbated in our lifetime by the predations of politicians beholden to monied interests). As Alex noted, we "meekly allow ourselves to be led in ig-

norance," so tied up in our own problems that we fall prey to the blandishments of dissembling politicians.

This adequately sums up what for me would become the norm, drifting on through abortive attempts in journalism—and out of a long relationship with Che borne at the Dillo. Not a dramatic or violent separation: Suffice it to say that we didn't meet each other's expectations (maybe not an uncommon occurrence among breakups). But it still proved a heavily emotional experience, as relationships are a lot harder to get out of than they are to get into.

Eventually I would find solace in company of Jan, leading over time to a comfortable and long-lasting marriage—and, lo and behold, to a young son when we approached a time when we'd almost aged out of parenthood. This may have proved fortuitous in the sense that we'd matured past the point of wanting to seek excitement in the boisterous Austin social scene, preferring to nest around the proper upbringing of a young'un, providing the tools this next-generation lad might need to pursue *his* dreams (unencumbered by parents distracted by their own desires for adventuresome behavior).

That entailed a whole new chapter of middle-class involvement, from band trips to select baseball tournaments, lessons in the interests *du jour* of our fledgling, money found to fund these occupations. The demands on parents constitute a binding force in the thralldom of everyday life. And I was content to concentrate on my duties at hand.

Not to give short shrift to this passage of years: I'd just kinda shot the wad on the rock'n'roll era of my life, subject of this meandering muse. This might best be relegated to a

tale told elsewhere. My passage into middle-class snug lacks the luster of the tumultuous times whence we had sprung.

Perhaps this descent into the mix of the hoi polloi best describes what happened to the hippies gotten old. They would be the generation that changed the world, taking it by its ear and shaking it up good. How many years before had I sat in a bar getting drunk next to a stranger while a punk band blared in the background? "Just wait till we get in power," he'd said. "We'll show them how things should be run." What a cruel slap of fate it'd been when the most memorable moment of *this* generation's first Leader of the Free World had been a peppermint blowjob. My, how things changed.

~14~

The Raw Deal

A quarter of the country
Is one paycheck from the street.
A tenth of the country
Has never had enough to eat.
And one one hundredth of the country
Is strangling all the rest.
And every policeman on the street
Is wearing a bulletproof vest.

—David Baerwald, "Stranger," from the 1990 album *Bedtime Stories*

Probably the signature "accomplishment" of my generation was in ending the Vietnam War, but hey, our asses were literally on the line, right? The other struggles of the era—involving race, gender, and class, in the main (yet all interwoven)—would languish or sputter intermittently until the Black Lives Matter and Me Too movements rekindled

agitation for reform years later, empowered by the proliferation of cell phones to graphically expose abuse, the prevalence of social media to give voice to concerns, and the exasperation of women fed up with the behavior of men in powerful positions. You couldn't put the toothpaste back in the tube, though you could delay the time before posture and pretense had to give way to action.

My own reawakening to sentient political life coincided more or less with a return to an empty-nester reality, when our laddybuck left home and I emerged from my somnolence. It's as if I awoke from a bad dream to discover the shambles governance had made of everyday life. We had charged into a nonsensical war in the Middle East that would tear up the region for decades (I thought it a dumbass move, but what could I do?). Politics had devolved into a full-contact blood sport, courtesy of banty roosters like Newt Gingrich, Rush Limbaugh, and a motley collection of right-wing media mouthpieces (thanks to the repeal of the Fairness Doctrine). The Supreme Court's decision in *Citizens United v. Federal Election Commission* and succeeding cases had opened up the floodgates to a mass infusion of money into the electoral process, power in the act of corrupting absolutely.

Garrison Keillor wrote scathingly about the transmogrification of the Republican party (become ever more prescient in succeeding years, as this predated *Citizens United*):

> *Rich ironies abound! Lies pop up like toadstools in the forest! Wild swine crowd round the public trough! Outrageous gerrymandering! Pocket lining on a massive scale! Paid lobbyists sit in committee rooms and write*

legislation to alleviate the suffering of billionaires! Hypocrisies shine like cat turds in the moonlight! O Mark Twain, where art thou at this hour? Arise and behold the Gilded Age reincarnated gaudier than ever, upholding great wealth as the sure sign of Divine Grace.

Here in 2004, George W. Bush is running for reelection on a platform of tragedy—the single greatest failure of national defense in our history, the attacks of 9/11 in which 19 men with box cutters put this nation into a tailspin, a failure the details of which the White House fought to keep secret even as it ran the country into hock up to the hubcaps, thanks to generous tax cuts for the well-fixed, hoping to lead us into a box canyon of debt that will render government impotent, even as we engage in a war against a small country that was undertaken for the president's personal satisfaction but sold to the American public on the basis of brazen misinformation, a war whose purpose is to distract us from an enormous transfer of wealth taking place in this country, flowing upward, and the deception is working beautifully.

Since the presidency of genial hack Ronald Reagan, Republican "voodoo" economic policy had been relentlessly plutocratic, championing tax cuts for the rich and benefit cuts for everyone else—though it can be argued the effort began in earnest earlier, in response to FDR's New Deal.

As I burrowed back into current events (once again a preoccupation, courtesy of the internet), I came to believe that the great American experiment had gone off the rails, the downtrodden so much flotsam washed up in a flood of

vulture capitalism run amok—retirees, minorities, the middle class all low-grade ore mined for money by the ultra-rich and powerful. Small "adjustments" made hither and yon to tax law and jurisprudence over the course of time led in slow motion to a quag of injustice, the death of a thousand tiny cuts.

The facade of Dow Jones buoyancy, so loudly trumpeted by the Donald as a hallmark of prosperity, masks the struggle of the average citizen, success in the stock market providing a thin veneer of well-being while millions of Americans remain unemployed or under-employed. Nearly half of American households own no stock at all, even counting pension and 401k plans or IRAs. For Black and Hispanic families the numbers are even worse: 69 percent and 72 percent, respectively. Indeed, the wealthiest 10 percent of households own 84 percent of all stock. A RAND study in 2020 determined that in the U.S., the top 1 percent has taken $50 trillion from the bottom 90 percent over the past 50 years. From 1975 to 2018, it noted, $2.5 trillion *each year* was sucked from the bottom 90 percent into the coffers of the wealthiest 1 percent of all Americans.

And pandemic aggravated the plight of American families, providing hard lessons for this country—not the least of which is the effect on working people, the common core of society that keeps it functioning. In September 2020 a Census Bureau survey stated that 10.5 percent of adults, some 23 million people, reported household members weren't getting enough to eat, a sharp increase from the 3.7 percent in a Department of Agriculture survey in 2019. At the same time, food-insecurity estimates for households with children ranged to nearly 30 percent. Yet as an October 2020

Washington Post report noted, of the $4 trillion approved in the pandemic aid relief package (exceeding the cost of the 18-year Afghanistan war), only 20 percent actually went to workers and families, the bulk targeted for businesses and the wealthy. The stock market reached all-time highs, while cars lined up for hours at food banks.

Hopefully this harsh reality will help us emerge from an age where public perception replaced knowledge, goaded on by patriotic sloganeering designed to gloss over the latest political chicanery, shrouded in concert with a sham religiosity. The reality show of the Trump years has exposed those tawdry truths hidden in plain sight, drowned out by the ministrations of whoever says the craziest thing or wields the biggest microphone—the top story *du jour.*

It seemed to me that politics had devolved into a suppurating pustule on the face of that "shining city on a hill" we've always fashioned ourselves—while paradoxically offering some explanation why so many opted to vote for a total wild card in 2016, the unpolitician: an electorate sickened by the business-as-usual approach to governance. But it doesn't explain why so many still supported such bunco after four years of that administration, even bolstered so blatantly by brazen voter suppression and a steady stream of right-wing disinformation.

Now, I'm not deluded into thinking that Democrats stand nobly high above the fray, beholden as they are as well to monied interests to fund campaigns. But at least they exhibit a semblance of care about the plight of the masses, if only in fighting a rear-guard action against plutocratic rapacity. (And they did, in fact, introduce an amendment following the election to overturn *Citizens United.*) Add to

that continued Republican efforts to restrict voting through outrageous gerrymandering and outright suppression, including attempts at a massive purging of legitimate (chiefly nonwhite) voters.

After the Supreme Court gutted the Voting Rights Act in 2013, Republican politicians rushed to close nearly 1,700 polling places to make it harder to vote in states previously subject to judicial review (750 in Texas, 320 in Arizona, 214 in Georgia, 126 in Louisiana, 96 in Mississippi, 72 in Alabama, and 29 in North Carolina). During the 2020 election, Republicans filed some 300 lawsuits in 44 states trying to stop the counting of mail-in ballots, as these made it easier for "those" people to vote. Blatant efforts in the 2020 election to suppress voting led critics to label Republicans in Congress the Jim Crow caucus.

Because of these and other scabrous acts—all designed to retain power in a foredoomed effort to stem the tide working against a shrinking white demographic—I remain what they call in Texas a "yellow-dog Democrat": I'd vote for a yellow dog before I'd vote for a Republican. To me, the elections are binary. No Green Party protest vote is worth what the 2016 elections foisted off on our country.

Granted, Joe Biden wasn't my first pick in a crowded field when the 2020 election season got underway, maybe not even in my top five. Yet his selection might have been a foregone conclusion, given the desire of a wide swath of the electorate to return to a more placid governance, what passes for normality—and the feeling that he might best garner the needed support. Even so, his win over the modern equivalent of a super-sized P. T. Barnum didn't end up the wholesale tsunami many predicted. But for Trump's doltish

mismanagement of the Covid crisis (fearing as he did its impact on the economy), Biden might well have lost.

In my mind this may be due at least in part to the Democratic party's hamhandish response (or lack therof) to Republican branding—saying, for instance, that to "defund the police" meant *not* to redefine policing and actually lighten the load on cops but to disband them entirely and loose chaos on our cities. Shades of the Sixties and Richard Nixon's crusade for law and order (derided by cartoonist Walt Kelly in "Pogo" as "lawn order").

And some pundits aver that the "socialist" brand, bogus as it may be, has been affixed to the party through constant Republican iteration—constantly drawing comparisons to poor Venezuela, a country we've strived overtly as well as covertly to beat into economic destitution. (One wag has suggested that "socialism" is used to describe everything to the left of hunting the homeless for sport.) It should be noted that nowadays, the label "communism" to tar progressive notions has fallen out of fashion in the Republican playbook, given the ascension to power in Russia of Putin and his pet plutocrats (and, as mentioned in a recent post, the fact that there are more Chinese billionaires than any other nationality). It's all about the benjamins, as in he who has the gold makes the rules.

And in truth, the power and the gold have resided in the grasp of the Republican party. Even with the election of Democrat Joe Biden, we've had, in essence, one-party rule for decades—witness, for one, the Republican dominance on the Supreme Court. Including Amy Barrett, the party has picked six of the last ten justices although it has lost the popular vote in seven of the last eight presidential elections.

With Trump's third appointment to the court, Senate majority leader Mitch McConnell running roughshod over the process, Republican presidents have picked sixteen out of the last twenty justices. Justice Barrett was the first Supreme Court justice to be confirmed without bipartisan support since 1869.

Even more indicative of this single-party trend in politics, however, is the fact that Republican presidential candidates gained office twice in the last four elections despite losing the popular vote—in 2000 and in 2016—courtesy of the Electoral College. And in 2020, only the margins in a couple "swing" states prevented it from happening again, in an election where Biden claimed the highest percentage of any challenger since FDR in 1932. Biden won the popular vote by seven million, and Trump lost the popular vote in 2016 by three million—yet they won the electoral vote by the same margin.

The Electoral College, an anomaly in "democracies" worldwide, favors land over people. An elector in Wyoming represents around 150,000 voters; a California elector, some 500,000 residents, making their votes over three times more powerful. Voters in Montana rate 31 times the electoral bang for their buck in presidential votes than their counterparts in New York. Those in Washington, D.C., and Puerto Rico get zilch.

This wasn't always the case. As states increased in population, the number of electors did as well. But, as historian Heather Cox Richardson writes:

> *The 1920 census showed that the weight of the nation's demographics was moving to cities, which were con-*

trolled by Democrats, so the Republicans in control of the House of Representatives refused to reapportion representation after that census. Reapportioning the House would have cost many of them their seats. Rather than permitting the number of representatives to grow along with population, Congress then capped the size of the House at 435. Since then, the average size of a congressional district has tripled. This gives smaller states a huge advantage in the Electoral College, in which each state gets a number of votes equal to the number of its senators and representatives.

These injuries to our system have saddled us with an Electoral College that permits a minority to tyrannize over the majority. That systemic advantage is unsustainable in a democracy. One or the other will have to give.

The winner-take-all approach most states take in allocating electoral votes also has the effect of negating the tally for losing candidates therein. More equitable at least would be awarding each candidate an amount proportionate to the number of votes received—given the nigh-impossible alternative of a constitutional amendment changing the system.

This flies in the face of popular opinion: U.S. adults believe, fifty-eight to forty percent, that the Constitution should be amended so the presidential candidate who receives the most votes nationwide wins. In one of many history courses I've taken in college (my favorite subject), a professor opined that this was a feature, not a defect, built in by the founding fathers. He insisted that their intent is apparent in the changing of those ringing phrases in the Declaration of Independence—"life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness"—to

the magisterial version in the Constitution—"life, liberty, and property."

This affront to the notion of one-man, one-vote democracy as practiced elsewhere in the world doesn't represent the extent of the problem. The U.S. Senate, our own House of Lords, reflects this same disparity, giving each state two senators regardless of its size. Once again, land triumphs over people. A voter in Wyoming has seventy times the representation in the Senate as one in California, while once again, citizens in Puerto Rico or Washington, D.C., go without. (As journalist Ari Berman points out, Wyoming, population 578,000, is 92 percent white and has 2 senators. DC, with 705,000 people, is 46% Black and has 0 senators.) In 2013, the *New York Times* pointed out that the six senators from California, Texas, and New York represented the same number of people as the sixty-two senators from the smallest thirty-one states. Following the 2020 election, the Senate was split evenly, but the 50 Democrats represented some 41.5 million more people than the 50 Republicans represented.

And when a Mitch McConnell wields Senate leadership like a cudgel to maintain power—as seen in denying Barack Obama's nomination of Merrick Garland to the Supreme Court as well as those of more than a hundred federal judges—it only reinforces the perception of one-party rule.

Which seems all too in step with the notion of "originalism" as relentlessly espoused by conservative members of the Supreme Court following the lead of the late Antonin Scalia. Bill Moyers has noted that this represents the Founding Fathers' intent at the outset to limit democratic (small "d") input:

> *The Senate, with equal votes for every state, large and small, would ensure that citizens of large, populous states had far less influence over legislation and judicial appointments than those in smaller ones. Alexander Hamilton wanted its members to serve lifetime terms, for "nothing but a permanent body can check the imprudence of democracy." Though he opposed giving each state equal votes, James Madison thought the upper house should serve "as a check on the democracy," a way to impede the influence of those who "labor under all the hardships of life, and secretly sigh for a more equal distribution of its blessings."*

Demographics mitigate against those who might "secretly sigh" for more equity—America's nonwhite population, which tends now to live in large or medium-sized states. Less than fifteen percent of citizens (predominantly white) now live in rural counties. And as Republicans gained ascendancy in statewide races, redrawing district boundaries during reapportionment, representation in the House of Representatives became skewed. As the progressive Center for American Progress pointed out, for each of the three elections between 2012 and 2016, fifty-nine seats would have changed hands if the percentage of seats won by a party matched the percentage of votes cast for its candidates: Republicans won nineteen additional seats each election because of districts biased in their favor.

As contrary as this development might *seem* to our avowed principles—you know, the much ballyhooed "American exceptionalism" and all that razzmatazz—it extends further if you consider one of the major grievances (and, indeed,

rallying cry) of the revolutionary period: "no taxation without representation." So who pays the freight nowadays? Where does tax money come from and where does it go?

According to a post-election Brookings Institution study, counties won by Joe Biden make up 70 percent of all U.S. economic output (gross domestic product, or GDP), while Trump's counties just 29 percent. Left-leaning economists say blue states essentially subsidize red states, which overwhelmingly accept more federal funds compared to what they contribute. According to the Rockefeller Institute, only 8 out of our 50 states send more to the federal government than they receive in return. The top 6 are traditional blue states—New York ($22 billion), New Jersey ($12 billion), Massachusetts ($9 billion), Connecticut ($8 billion), Colorado ($2 billion), and Minnesota ($725 million). The other two are the traditional red states of Utah ($511 million) and Nebraska ($315 million). The bottom ten of "takers," those who receive more than they give—Virginia, Maryland, Kentucky, Alabama, Ohio, Pennsylvania, North Carolina, Arizona, Tennessee, Michigan, and Florida—are predominantly red states. But I don't suppose "originalists" care to hear this kind of argument, though.

What does warrant discussion ultimately, though, is the utter perversion of honor and the rule of law during Trump's rogue administration. He has blown up every hallowed tradition associated with the office, wielding power as would the don of a crime family. During his reign, he's sought only to enrich and ennoble himself—besides picking at the scabs of racism, nationalism, the sores of the forgotten in our society, to distract by fomenting confusion, division, and anger—cementing his imperial control over party

minions with an itchy twitter finger holding them in thrall, his only interest what's in it for him.

This quid-pro-quo attachment to the office, ignoring convention as well as law, revealed itself early when he refused to release his taxes or divest himself, raked in emoluments from the time of his very inauguration, hired progeny with vaporous credentials, overriding security concerns—leading finally to impeachment, where party lackeys in the Senate had preordained his innocence. And those subservient toadies proclaimed, "Let the people decide with their votes" in the upcoming election, until the all-powerful Oz declared it rigged and further fouled the process by dragging it on for months with bootless court challenges.

Then, during his bizarre fight to overturn the results, he first called for donations to pursue his bogus claims, just one more egregious example of grift, the flimflam man building up his war chest for the inevitable lawsuits to follow his descendancy. Even to the end, he acted the *capo di tutti i capi,* saying he wanted to see a list of those in Congress who did (or didn't) sign on to his cause, maniacally trying to maintain his grip on the party. His every action during the denouement of this tragicomedy showed his desire to maintain the power he so savored, seen in his own mind extending beyond a single term.

For that reason, it's imperative to rip the shroud off the Trump debacle, revealing for all what has been done in—and to—the people's name. I only hope to live long enough to see the truth, finally, in the light of day, every detail in each tell-all book from every stooge released from his megalomaniacal grip.

To break his hold, there first must be a careful examination of every norm and convention Trump shattered, making explicit in the rule of law what has previously operated under an honor system, rendered meaningless by a president who lacks any such fealty to integrity. Two impeachments have done nothing to teach the Donald any lesson, as Maine Senator (and waffle queen) Susan Collins insisted would happen after the first—other than that he could get away with anything. He retained hold on the Republican party after the Capitol riots. Only 7 joined Democrats voting to convict in impeachment part *deux*. (The 57 senators represent 76,000,000 voters more than do the 43 sticking with the boss.)

So on to legal malfeasance. Unseal every indictment waiting in the wings and prosecute him and his coterie to the furthest extent of the law. It will not be easy, given his penchant for dragging every case out till an opponent's desire to continue flags. But the wheels of justice grind slowly, and even with the $200 million conned out of his devotees in his quest for "election justice," his means will be bounded. This house of cards can't stand up to what awaits. *Forbes* magazine said his debts due over the next four years total more than a billion dollars, so it will soon be time to pay the piper. He may stiff a lawyer or two, but he's gone to that well too many times to have much access to people's good will.

Every transaction of the Trump mob needs dissection, from the time well before inauguration to the last dirty pardon given to head off damning testimony (as payback to those who hadn't ratted him out). No mercy. Rather, the mercy Trump showed infant immigrants torn from their

parents, those Americans *not* a lighter shade of pale, the bedrock citizens of this country struggling during the Covid crisis. Only in this way can the spell be broken, the last fool bending a knee to the swindler up and stealing away, abashed and ashamed to be taken in by such bunkum.

The Trump name must be so tainted that Plasticine Princess Ivanka and Donald Amok Jr. won't care to show their faces in public, let alone run for office, as suggested. Republican sycophants turned to dust in the wind—or off to lick some other's boots. The Proud Boys, Oath Keepers, Q-cumbers, and assorted troglodytes slid back under the rocks whence they slithered.

All must be revealed, else some future politician who's not such a dunderhead and blatant liar and thief could take better advantage of Trump precedence and make a shambles of remaining democratic norms. This is the one herd immunity that must closely follow that of the Covid virus.

~15~

Rage, Rage . . .

Do not go gentle into that good night,
Old age should burn and rave at close of day;
Rage, rage against the dying of the light.

—Dylan Thomas

By December 2020 the Mad King had hunkered down at Mar-a-Lago, giving up any semblance of governing while the pandemic raged and the economy teetered (only grudgingly signing a skimpy relief package for millions on the brink of disaster in a conspicuous example of Covid capitalism). Then, in a typical display of their patrician concern, Trump went golfing and VP Mikey Pence, the human Q-tip—he who ostensibly led the pandemic task force—emplaned for a ski vacation in Vail, Colorado.

Don the Con had wheedled his way into the presidency with his brand of sloganeering and snake oil, smearing opponents with snide names and claiming he would "make

America great again," baldly lying in a steady stream of "populist" sputum and saying he would "drain the swamp." What he delivered was more trickle down, less regulation, and a heapin' helpin' of gangster radical right. Then, in the face of a thumping in his reelection campaign, he went full *il duce,* yapping to the rabble about a stolen election, spouting full-bore fabrications about voting irregularities (the Big Lie)—while at the same time attempting behind the scenes to strong-arm election officials to reverse clear losses in battleground states.

The chaotic culmination of this sad debacle unfolded on January 6, when Congress met to certify his defeat. Trump, returning to the capital to exhort a frenzied mob of worshipers who had followed him down the rabbit hole, spurred them to march, saying "*We're* going to the Capitol." He then slunk back to the safety of the White House to gleefully exult in what he wrought, in his power—until, maybe, it became all too apparent that his *putsch* had careened out of control. He awakened the beast but then it had to be fed.

The ensuing riot at the Capitol, where lawmakers huddled in fear over what had been unleashed, led ultimately to nine deaths and an initially small but steadily growing number of arrests (as mobster selfies led to positive IDs and apprehensions). Over the weeks that followed, stark video proof emerged of the murderous frenzy of the rioters, the wanton violence visited upon those of the Capitol police who tried in vain to stem the tide. Images of thugs with zip ties (apparently to take congress people captive), a noose strung up outside the building, flooded the airways. Some supporters of the Big Lie began to weasel away from blame as an inexorable FBI investigation began in earnest, and

Newsweek reported that tens of thousands of Republicans have since changed their party affiliation following the riot.

As condemnations flooded in over the insurrection, the first time the Capitol had been occupied since the War of 1812, it seemed that Trump might have finally stepped on his own dick. This was, for many, a boogaloo too far, and when the House vote on a second impeachment of the Donald, ten Republicans signed on. A majority of Americans polled said they favored his removal. As the sun set on his presidency, his popularity fell to its lowest point ever, some thirty-four percent, according to a Gallup poll. And two-thirds of respondents to a Pew poll said Trump should not continue to be a major national political figure.

What is puzzling, though, is what the Donald, in the grip of his Trumper tantrum, sought to gain by enlisting and inciting his thug rabble to exercise their propensity for violence (a group once derided widely by liberals as "Meal Team Six" or "Y'all Qaeda"). Did he really think himself such a charismatic character that millions of his supporters would then ignore the mayhem and rise up to acclaim him president anew? Instead, the whole grim episode fostered a wave of investigation into the roots of the lawlessness, the money and supervision behind the riot—as well as a proliferation of black-humor memes (e.g., one lamenting that we as a country spend $750 billion a year on defense and the center of American government fell in two hours to the Duck Dynasty).

Yet a majority of Republican congress members clung to his skirts, fearing the backlash from his mass of diehard (if misinformed) supporters. A large segment of his devotees still believed the election to be illegitimate. As Vladimir

Lenin once noted, a lie told often enough becomes the truth. A Quinnipiac poll found that nearly three-quarters of Republicans believed there was widespread voter fraud, thanks in large part to a right-wing media machine that has yet to be called to account for its role in the spread of Trump disinformation. Nor will it in the foreseeable future.

After all was said and done—and some 25,000 National Guard troops poured into D.C. for the inauguration—the Democrats assumed power, faced with the daunting prospects of an economy on the verge of collapse and a rampaging pandemic. Not to mention a populace bitterly divided over what exactly is truth. One ray of light: A *Washington Post* report noted that online misinformation about election fraud plunged 73 percent after several social media sites (including his drug of choice, Twitter) suspended President Trump and allies, underscoring the power of social media to curtail the spread of the Big Lie.

Now remains the task of coaxing a large segment of the population *out* of the rabbit hole. I'd first like to see a reclamation of the term "populism" so bastardized during this misbegotten regime. Nothing in Trump's short brutish reign (however never-ending it sometimes seemed) offered anything for the average American, the populace. It functioned rather as the end game of the Reagan revolution, serving up a government small enough to drown in a bathtub—and weak enough to leave a legacy of gross incompetence in dealing with a pandemic. What has Trump actually done in the last four years that could remotely be seen as populist?

Rather, he fabricated a coalition of the well-heeled with the disaffected and those slugs wed to alt-right lunacy, adroitly fanning the flames of racism, nationalism, and rit-

ualized religiosity with wedge-issue distractions to modify policy—all too often to the detriment of what a majority of Americans might actually wish. As philosopher Eric Hoffer opined, all mass movements are born of the frustrated among us who make holy causes out of their grievances.

The powers that be must face these resentments, the problem of winning back those enraptured by the fever dreams of a faux populism espoused by Trumplicans. To begin with, that entails providing hope where promises only flickered. Max Brooks, son of comedian Mel Brooks and Anne Bancroft, likened the task to how we dealt after World War II with Nazi zealots who had taken to the hills to fight on. The U.S. Marshall Plan induced extremists to return to civilized society by providing them what they need—jobs, education, a chance for a better life.

A modern-day version of the Work Projects Administration, for instance, directed to providing jobs—and training—in developing industries might serve, as opposed to the empty Trump promises of work in new coal mines that never materialized. Further, millions could be enlisted to deal with a crumbling infrastructure, something promised from time immemorial by innumerable politicos.

In short, a Democratic party that purports to be "of the people" needs to consider what they actually want (or need) politicians to do. Providing for the common weal fits the traditionally accepted role of government, however novel that notion now seems, and would go a long way to restoring faith in a system that too many see as rigged for the benefit of a fortunate few.

What else might serve the interest of the many today? Consider just this one common concern: The CEO of

GoFundMe said recently that one out of three of their campaigns now go to pay medical bills, making GoFundMe one of the biggest insurers in the country. Nearly two-thirds of all personal bankruptcies result from medical debt and loss of income. A majority in this country favors universal healthcare, though monied interests (who fund campaigns in both parties) to date have managed to deflect conscious efforts to that end. Even a Fox News exit poll from election night showed that more than 70 percent of voters favored some form of government-run healthcare plan.

An interesting sidelight of that poll found that the same percentage of respondents favors public investment in decarbonization—one indication that maybe the Biden administration, with its attention to environmental concerns, might be listening. According to a Gallup poll, six out of ten Americans, including 80 percent of Democrats and 37 percent of Republicans, say they would favor policies that would reduce emissions to address climate change.

Wielding only a slim majority in Congress, however, the Biden administration (should the spirit be willing) will find the going tough against an entrenched system funded by monied interests. Money talks. This overwhelmingly mitigates against progressive reform and serves to thwart the will of the people, many of whom are now aware: In a study from the University of Maryland and nonpartisan research group Voice of the People, three-fourths of survey respondents, including 66 percent of Republicans and 85 percent of Democrats, back a constitutional amendment outlawing *Citizens United.* The study also noted that most Americans (88 percent overall) want to reduce the influence large cam-

paign donors exert over lawmakers at a time when congressional races can cost tens of millions of dollars.

The question then becomes how do you translate popular opinion into legislative change—particularly when a large swath of the electorate can be gulled into thinking a conman and swindler is the one to "drain the swamp." What does it take to idiot-proof a democracy? Is the Big Lie to become an insuperable weapon in the hands of duplicitous politicians? Not necessarily. As a team led by Lisa Fazio of Vanderbilt University found, with or without repetition, people are still more likely to believe actual facts as opposed to lies. The problem is, then, where do people get their facts, when so many get their information exclusively from a Fox News or the One America News Network—which served as a bullhorn (or an echo chamber) for seditious conspiracy theories.

Some have suggested that a modern version of the Fairness Doctrine (which, however, applied only to broadcast news) might seem in order, though the proliferation of sources for information compounds the problem and careens quickly into First Amendment arguments. The advent of social media introduced whole new worlds of fantasy fabrication, also opening up the prospect of foreign actors weaponizing sites such as Facebook and twitter, as highlighted in the 2016 election—fevered protestations of "witch hunt" notwithstanding.

Which leaves the polity prey to the next scam, and the GOP gave every indication of sticking to the gameplan—shrinking the *electorate* enough to drown it in a bathtub. Immediately following the election, more than 400 bills

designed to restrict voting access were introduced in 48 states. The battle rages on, with Republicans miming the role of the sorely aggrieved party beset by an embroidered electoral malfeasance.

This time, perhaps, their counterparts in the Democratic party show signs of being woke to the gambit. Some glimmers of hope shone in Georgia, where a determined effort by voting-rights activist Stacey Abrams (cheated in her run for governor) and journalist Greg Palast succeeded in regaining the vote for enough purged citizens to turn the state blue. Both Democratic candidates for Senate won their elections, as did Biden—the first in the Georgia presidential race since the 1976 election of Jimmy Carter. Their efforts to *expand* the voter base could offer a roadmap for reclaiming the vote in the myriad states where GOP gerrymandering and blatant voter suppression have congealed into de facto one-party rule. But first they face new bills designed to thwart that effort.

Still, the knowledge that blood-red Georgia can be turned by grassroots organizing is indeed heartening, triggering similar activist action in other locales and challenging Republican strangleholds in states like our Texas—where the Snowpocalypse of 2021 served to illustrate what the excesses of a rampant free-market capitalism has wrought and what little our elected representatives did to prevent it. The battle turns to a state-by-state struggle, as the razor-thin margin in the Senate and a reduced majority in the House don't otherwise bode well for pushing through any hint of a progressive agenda.

It falls to progressives themselves to pound the pavement, reform-minded journalists to pry into the political

perfidy plaguing our nation. Nothing in Washington comes easy anymore. No false hopes of a bright new day dawning this time, as shown in the pollyanna optimism that suffused liberals following the 2008 election of Barack Obama (before running head on into the obdurate obstruction of the Mitch McConnell Senate).

For me, the year 2008 also brought a seismic change in my happy space. I discovered that changing economic times threatened my safe harbor at G&S Typesetting—the firm soon to be sold to an Indian firm as everywhere publishing houses sought cheaper (and less fastidious) sources. Time to rework the résumé . . .

Already mired in middle age, I didn't entertain any thoughts of finding an editorial position where I could start afresh and somehow rejoin the battle, given the paucity of said jobs. (Over the last fifteen years more than a fourth of America's newspapers and half of its journalists have "disappeared.") I took a flyer on a job listing and ended up working as communications director for the Texas Criminal Defense Lawyers Association (TCDLA), an estimable organization that's the oldest and largest of its kind in the country. Its mission can best be expressed in the words of the late great TCDLA Hall of Fame member Stuart Kinard: "Protecting the Lord's children who have fallen short of perfection from the wrath of those who believe they have attained it."

For the next twelve years, I found myself doing my small part in forwarding the good efforts of a hard-working bunch of true believers fighting the good fight in a decidedly hang-'em-high state. Their work, though often derided by the public (as in "how can you defend that kind of person?"), has led to a spate of exonerations and even changes

to constitutional law. I took vicarious enjoyment seeing the wrongs of a baked-in two-tiered justice system made right by the warriors in TCDLA.

At the same time, I expanded my own need for social involvement through the very platform so used and abused in the new-age media: Facebook. Rather than spending an inordinate amount of time as I did on the internet chasing down truth (to no good end), I determined I could at least do *something* by providing a place to compile what I thought to be the best of available progressive material. So I opened a Facebook page, "Seniors for a Democratic Society," quite a tongue-in-cheek contrivance given my aforementioned abortive go at the original SDS in the Sixties.

In a decade now acting as admin for the site, I've found some comfort in the fact that more than 60,000 followers check in to see what I've found, an audience for progressive thought. And amongst the regulars lurk some seriously discriminating newshounds, calling me on the carpet whenever something I've posted turns out to be stretching the truth, necessitating a quick deletion or modification. The upshot of that: I rely almost totally on trustworthy sites for information.

A good number of the best sources hide behind pay walls, however, limiting access to many of the seniors following the site who might be on limited income. I soon discovered ways around these, when necessary to cover the best stories, or alternate means of discovering when other free sources cover the same information.

All in all, the process allows for rapid dissemination of good info—as well as getting and posting tips from other serious devotees, who range from priests to businessmen to

a cadre of hyper-motivated retirees. The time I spend policing the site represents the downside—the daily excursion through comments to ferret out trolls for deletion. No discouraging words, bad vibes, or Trumpublicans allowed. Almost a part-time job in itself, but hey: What can a poor boy do (who's too old for a rock'n'roll band)?

Better to stay involved in whatever way possible, given the parlous age we live in. As Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn, who faced his share of hard times, once expressed in his 1972 Nobel lecture:

> *The simple act of an ordinary brave (human being) is not to participate in lies, not to support false actions! (Their) rule: Let that come into the world, let it even reign supreme—only not through me. But it is within the power of writers and artists to do much more: to defeat the lie! For in the struggle with lies art has always triumphed and shall always triumph! Visibly, irrefutably for all! Lies can prevail against much in this world, but never against art.*

About the Author



Craig Hattersley graduated summa cum laude from the University of Texas School of Journalism. He recently retired as communications director for the Texas Criminal Defense Lawyers Association to work on his own interests—editing/designing/typesetting book-length projects. Craig has served as senior editor for *Third Coast* magazine (twice a finalist in the National Magazine Awards), *Texas Life* magazine, and the *Austin Weekly.* In addition, he has written or edited for *Third Coast,* the *Texas Observer,* the *Austin Chronicle,* the *Village Voice,* and Texas Monthly Press. Craig is the author of *Style & Substance: A quick reference guide to punctuation using the wisdom of the ages for examples.*

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